

Settan Lands

The Settan Lands, Arq and Low Weir

Stand on the western Ring Road where it crosses the Settan River at Barból and turn south. The horizon stretches endlessly. Rolling fields of vegetables, orchards heavy with fruit, scattered villages sending up thin columns of cookfire smoke. Travel east for many days and you'll reach the great grain markets of Kurosol. Walk west instead and you might stumble into Aranzen territory before you realize you've left the Saskan Lands entirely. Head east along the river and you'll pass through countless farming communes, each with its own dialect, its own interpretation of the river goddess, its own approach to the backbreaking work of manual pollination that keeps this breadbasket productive.

Ask someone in Kurosol if they're part of the Settan Lands and they'll probably say yes. Ask them who governs the Settan Lands and they'll look at you like you've asked who governs the wind.

This is the essential character of the South: abundant, diverse, productive, and profoundly ungovernable.

A Region Without a Center

The term Settan Lands describes a flexible concept rather than a coherent political entity. Unlike the United Rider Provinces with their voluntary union centered in Bordered, or the Fatunik Dominion with its rigid hierarchy emanating from Beshquahoek, the Settan Lands have no coordinating authority. The closest thing to a central hub is Barból town, but its influence is commercial rather than political. It is a place where farmers sell seed, where herbalists trade innovations, where the Dauni Vakasaqua maintain one of their largest research facilities

outside Low Weir itself.

The region sprawls across more than six hundred kilometers from Barból to the remote reaches of southern Arq. Settarune alone could swallow several northern provinces. The distances are not just geographic but cultural. The river-worshipping communes of western Settarune share little with the nomadic bands of Arq except for a vague southern identity and a mutual suspicion of northern interference.

Even the boundaries remain contested. Arq province, separated from the rest by the Outer Lands, connects to its Settan cousins only by sea. Some old maps group it with the Outer Lands instead, though that is definitely not something the Magisters of the Night Hall would agree has ever been agreed to. Low Weir, though culturally and spiritually intertwined with Settarune and Barból, technically, in a geographical and to a degree cultural and linguistic sense, belongs to the Weir Lands. Which is a designation perhaps even more meaningless than Settan Lands from a political perspective. The provinces of Terpinol and Baranuq, dominated by their Terpin populations, hover on the southern edge of the Settan provinces, and have a huge influence on their neighbors, without quite belonging to something that could be described as a shared national identity.

The name itself derives from the Settan River and from the widespread belief systems found closer to its southern banks that revere the river as a living, sacred entity. The further from the river, the more diverse and diffuse such beliefs become, though they find echoes for hundreds of kilometers from its waters. In Arq, legends revolve around hidden rivers and lost waters rather than the Settan itself. In Low Weir, the Settan is one of countless springs, cenotes, and streams that sustain the Dauni Vakasaqua's carefully camouflaged settlements.

What Binds the Southern Provinces Together

If political unity eludes the Settan Lands, certain common characteristics nevertheless distinguish them from their neighbors to

the north and east.

The most obvious is the relationship with the Settan River itself. From the hidden springs of Low Weir to the great bend on the river where Barból reigns, the river shapes both economy and spirituality.

Irrigation systems feed thousands of villages. Manual pollination, that endless, careful work of touching every flower, every blossom, makes agriculture possible in a world where bees and birds no longer exist.

The Dauni Vakasaqua perfected these techniques in Low Weir and over the centuries spread them throughout the South, turning ecological catastrophe into opportunity through sheer disciplined innovation.

The South supports the largest sint population in the Saskan Lands.

Somewhere on the order of one hundred thousand individuals across all provinces, though accurate counts are impossible when many sint communities prefer to remain hidden from their hum neighbors.

Rabbits dominate numerically, but snake-sints, lizard populations, and mammalian sints with badger or otter lineage appear throughout the region. Unlike in the Dominion or the Rider provinces, and to a much greater degree than in the Outer Lands, mixed hum-sint families exist in Settarune with enough frequency that they no longer draw attention. Children with scales partially hidden beneath human skin, or with pupils that reflect light in unsettling ways, work the fields alongside their fully hum cousins.

Language patterns distinguish the South as well. While Fatunik Eibar and its related dialects dominate the northern provinces, the Settan Lands preserve older linguistic traditions. Sogomsh, spoken widely throughout Settarune and Barból, is considered the classical language of the Saskan Lands by scholars in Byenung. It is the tongue of ancient learning and ritual. Sogomsh and Eibar are linguistic cousins, perhaps even close cousins, but to say they are mutually intelligible would be stretching the truth. In Arq, an even older language persist. Arql is the language of antiquity, and Arqq is a dialect of it that is spoken by the most isolated bands. A merchant fluent only in Eibar will struggle to conduct business in the deep South without a translator.

The spiritual and cultural milieu revolves around animist nature-

worship centered on reverence for the Settan River, though centered overstates the coherence. River cults proliferate in dozens of forms. Some worship the river as a goddess, others as a living network of consciousness, still others as the physical manifestation of an abstract force called Setta that imbues all things with energy and meaning. Syncretic Returner beliefs blend with river worship, creating hybrids that would scandalize orthodox Fatuniks and puzzle practical-minded Riders. The Dauni Vakasaqua, though not precisely a religious order, channel this river-reverence into agricultural science and herbal medicine, making the spiritual practical and the practical sacred.

Most striking to northern visitors is the profoundly rural character of the South. Large fortified towns are rare. Settarune province, despite its vast population and agricultural wealth, contains not a single fortified town—only countless villages ranging from a few dozen to a few hundred inhabitants. Even Barból town, the largest urban center south of the Settan River, feels more like an oversized market village than a true city in the Fatunik mold. The South values dispersed settlement, communal land management, and resistance to the centralizing impulses that shape life in places like Jivakól or Bored.

Borders and Neighbors

The South's geography shapes its character. The Settan River marks the northern boundary. It is a physical barrier but also a cultural threshold. Cross the river into the Borda Woods and you enter territory where Fatunik is strong. The woods themselves, still scarred by the Great Conflagration that ended the Eelani-Fatunik War five centuries ago, serve as a buffer between southern abundance and northern politics. Cross into Kahilabequa and you will find yourself in a territory friendly to the south lands, even integrated in a variety of ways, but entirely distinct in language, culture and demographics.

To the west, the Settan Lands border Aranzén and blend into the dizzying array of heights, channels, meandering meadows, woods, rivulets, washes, falls and mysteries of Low Weir. Aranzén, with its

puzzling technologies, maintains cordial trade relations with Barból but is a fundamentally foreign culture not easily reachable by land. Low Weir, nominally part of the Weir Lands, functions as the spiritual and intellectual homeland of southern agricultural innovation. It is where the Dauni Vakasaqua perfect the techniques that make the South's productivity possible and the home base for their activities that influence all the Lands, but the southern provinces most of all.

The southern and eastern borders press against the Komikols and eventually the Krbsh Sea. These are foreign territories where sint populations dominate and huum venture with caution. Arq province is remote, not only does the Ring Road come nowhere close to it, but the idea of roads as such is risable.

These border relationships matter. The South's agricultural surplus makes it essential to the Fatunik Dominion's food supply, which in turn gives the South leverage in negotiations. The Dominion cannot easily coerce regions that feed its garrison towns. The Riders also depend on Settan grain to support their populations. Even the Outer Lands, with their proudly self-sufficient communes and successful agricultural trade, buy Barból seed stock and employ Dauni Vakasaqua consultants to improve their yields.

The South's lack of political coordination paradoxically strengthens its position. There is no single authority to intimidate, no capital to threaten, no council to bribe. Individual villages make their own trade arrangements. If one sub-region or collection of villages refuses Dominion terms, a hundred others will happily step in. This diffusion of power infuriates northern administrators while enriching southern farmers.

The Ring Road and Regional Identity

The Great Ring Road enters the South at Bordakol, where it crosses from the Borda Woods into Barból province. From there it follows close to the Settan River's northern bank, passing through the border regions of Settarune before continuing east into the Kahila Lands at Brokily. This route, hugging the river rather than plunging into the

southern interior, reflects practical and political considerations. The river provides water and trade. The interior, with its epic maze of villages and competing authorities, offers no clear path for a road that requires constant maintenance and protection.

Notably, the Ring extends to neither Kurosol town in Baranuq province nor to Terpinol on the Aran Sea coast. Those towns developed their own trade networks and roadways, including the remarkable Aran Canal that connects the Settan River to the Aran Sea, linking Barból to Terpinol by water rather than road. The southernmost Terpin-dominated provinces manage quite well without the Ring, thank you very much.

The Ring's proximity to the Settan River rather than to its southern territories reinforces the region's identity as the southern lands or, as some would have it, the wild lands. Much of its territory consists of places either only glimpsed from the Road, or very far from it and certainly not tamed by it. Travelers along the Ring see the South's prosperity in the caravans heading north, joining on to the Ring, laden with grain and herbs. But few travelers from outside the region choose to venture into the interior where that prosperity is actually produced.

The Question of Governance

How do the Settan Lands function without centralized authority? The answer varies by province and even by village, but some patterns emerge.

Representative democracy operates in Barból province, where village councils electing clan councils, which in turn send representatives to the Barból Town Council that governs the entire province. Settarune's thousands of villages maintain their own systems. Some are democratic, some based on elder councils, some organized around extended family networks, others around religious or agricultural cooperative traditions or charters. What they share is a resistance to outside interference and a pragmatic willingness to coordinate when necessary, then immediately return to their preferred state of

independence.

The Dauni Vakasaqua function as something between a coordinating council and a guild network throughout the South. Their agricultural expertise makes them essential. Their healing services create loyalty. Their network of contacts allows them to coordinate responses to threats without maintaining anything resembling a formal bureaucracy. When the Fatunik Dominion pushes too hard on grain prices, the traveling missions of the Dauni Vakasaqua quietly plant seeds suggesting that farmers focus on vegetable production for a season. The resulting shortage brings Fatunik negotiators back to the table with better terms.

This is governance by influence rather than by law. It is a type of cultural hegemony practiced by people who would never use such terms. The Dauni Vakasaqua shape norms, spread innovations, provide healing and train the next generation of farmers and herbalists. Through these soft activities, carried out persistently and steadily, generation after generation, they helped to create a shared southern identity that needs no formal institutions to maintain itself.

A Region in Flux

The Settan Lands face pressures that their lack of centralization makes difficult to address. Jaxen infiltration, particularly in Barból and Settarune, proceeds largely unnoticed by authorities too decentralized to track patterns across multiple villages. It is much farther advanced here than in any other region. As in all regions, ecological challenges continue to make life hard and the future uncertain. Crop failures, mysterious blights, the ongoing absence of natural pollinators all make agriculture dependent on intensive manual labor.

Yet the South's very formlessness proves adaptive. When Tonedor Rumpet's Kahila-Fatunik War threatened to spill across the Settan River, Settarune's villages coordinated an unprecedented popular mobilization without any central command structure. The sight of tens of thousands of farmers massing on the southern riverbank, with more moving northward in waves, helped to convince the Dominion to stop

the massacres and declare victory. The southern army melted away, its soldiers returning to their villages as if nothing had happened.

This capacity for sudden coordination followed by immediate dispersal defines the Settan Lands. They could not accurately be called a nation or a federation or even a loose alliance. They are a very large landscape populated by people who share certain beliefs, certain practices, certain memories, and who will cooperate intensely when threatened before dissolving back into their preferred state of a determined but largely cheerful and productive chaos.

Stand on that bridge in Barból again. Watch the river flow south toward the sea. The water -- or at least the idea of the water -- connects these disparate provinces: Low Weir, Settarune, Terpinol, Baranuq, Barból and even distant Arq more effectively than any government ever could. The South is defined not by what rules it but by what sustains it: the spirit of the water, steady work on a massive scale, and a stubborn insistence that abundance need not require hierarchy.

The Settan River

The Settan begins as a whisper. A thousand tiny springs seep from limestone caverns in the hills of Low Weir, each one cold and clear, converging into rivulets that feed pools and cenotes hidden beneath forest canopy. The Dauni Vakasaqua know every source, tend every spring, and guard the knowledge of which waters cure fevers and which ones induce visions. They will not tell you exactly where the river begins, because in their cosmology, the question makes no sense. The Settan does not begin. It emerges, the way consciousness emerges, from many sources at once.

By the time the gathering waters spill from the low western hills into the plains of Settarune, the Settan has become recognizable as a river. There it is perhaps thirty meters wide, shallow enough to ford in the dry season, swift and cold with snowmelt in early spring. It flows

east, carving a gentle arc through the most fertile agricultural land in all the Saskan Lands. At Barból it swings south, fed by tributaries from the Borda Woods, widening and slowing. Near Barból town, where the Ring Road crosses on an ancient stone bridge, the river runs deep enough for boats and barges. The Barból Riverwaq maintain the waterway nearly 500 kilometers to Brokily, and another 400 kilometers or so all the way to Byenung.

South of Barból, the Settan is more myth than reality. The people there look as much to the great inland lake near the Bay of Bar as they do to the river itself, both representing the foundational role of the Settan waters for life in the southlands. Then there is the Settan's remarkable opening act, long before making its long trek to the Krbsh Sea, where it pours into the thousand kilometers of the Aran Canal, that engineering marvel constructed by Terpin vision and Byenung labor, carrying the sacred waters from Barból to Terpinol, a distance as far as from Barból to Byenung, and every inch of it constructed and managed by conscious effort.

This is the Settan's physical journey. But the river waters that the Southern folk worship in so many different ways is not the water you can touch.

The River as Living Entity

Ask a farmer in Settarune about the river and she might tell you, "The Mother knows when fields need water. We listen, and she tells us when to open the irrigation gates." She does not mean this metaphorically. The river, in southern belief, possesses awareness, perhaps even intention. It is similar to how many devout Fatuniks truly believe in the consciousness of the solar entity, but in a much more tactile, embracing way.

The detailed nature of that awareness, of that touch, depends on whom you ask.

For example, in riverside villages just south of Barból, the Temple of Flowing Spirits teaches that the Settan carries the souls of ancestors in its current. When someone dies, their body may be burned or buried

depending on family tradition, but a portion of ash or a lock of hair is always given to the river. The dead flow east and south, eventually reaching the lake or the marshes or sea, but their essence remains in the waters forever. Every time you drink from the Settan, every time you irrigate your fields, you are sustained by those who came before. This is not seen as macabre but as profoundly comforting. Death becomes a form of continued service to the living.

Further west, near Low Weir, Settan beliefs take on a more abstract character. Here the river represents not a collection of individual spirits but a single, vast consciousness. It is closer to what might be called a world-soul or planetary mind. The Dauni Vakasaqua, though they rarely speak of theology directly, hold some version of this view. They treat the river with the same careful attention they give to a patient. They monitor its health, address imbalances, and celebrate its flourishes. When they teach pollination techniques or irrigation management, they frame it as working with Mother Settan's rhythms, rather than imposing human will on nature.

In Brokily and the surrounding regions, the Circles of Ancient Weavers practice syncretic forms of river worship that blend Settan reverence with Kahila traditions. They create intricate textiles using natural dyes derived from riverbank plants, and believe these patterns communicate with the river's spirit. The very act of weaving sends prayers or requests downstream. During times of drought, the weavers work day and night, creating water-summoning patterns that they hang from poles along the riverbank. Whether this actually works remains debatable, but the weavers point to the regions's reliable water supply as evidence.

In Arq, far to the east where the river's influence is mere memory or purely myth, river beliefs take on a plaintive quality. The hidden river or lost river of Arql legend refers both to underground waterways and to a spiritual condition. It evokes a sense that something essential has been hidden or forgotten. Some Arql scholars believe their ancestors once lived near a different river entirely, perhaps in the distant north or even in lands beyond the Saskan Lands, and that the Settan represents a substitute, a replacement for something lost. This gives Arql river worship a melancholic edge, a quality of longing that

contrasts sharply with the confident abundance of Settarune.

Practical and Sacred

What makes Settan river worship distinctive is its integration with daily agricultural practice. There are no monasteries where monks contemplate the river's mysteries while others do the work of farming. The farmers themselves are the priests. The fields are the temples.

Consider the rhythm of a growing season in Settarune.

Before planting, village herbalists often trained by the Dauni Vakasaqua or at least familiar with their methods walk the fields and listen to the soil. They press their hands into the earth, smell it, sometimes taste it, and determine what the land needs. This is not mysticism masquerading as agriculture; it is agriculture that treats the soil as a living participant in the relationship rather than an inert medium. The herbalists mix composts, adjust drainage, and decide which herbs to plant as companion crops. These decisions are both technical and devotional.

During planting, many villages hold riverside ceremonies or an equivalent. Not elaborate rituals with priests in ornate robes, but working gatherings where farmers pause from their labor to make offerings, usually of seeds, sometimes of herbs or food. They pour water from the river over the first planted rows. They sing, though the songs are as likely to be bawdy field chants as formal hymns. The point is acknowledgment. We see you, we depend on you, we work with you.

Then comes the pollination. This is where practical and sacred merge completely.

In the world before the Great Catastrophe, wind and insects and birds moved pollen from flower to flower. In the Saskan Lands, that work falls to hum and to sint hands, to the careful coordination of village teams who walk through orchards and fields with brushes and careful fingers, touching each blossom, transferring pollen, making fruit possible through sheer manual effort. This work is exhausting,

endless, and absolutely essential.

The Dauni Vakasaqua transformed pollination from desperate survival into spiritual practice. The practice has an almost meditative quality in the southern provinces. They taught that manual pollination is not a poor substitute for natural processes but rather the highest form of participation in the river's generative power. The water sustains the plants. Huum and sint work help them reproduce. The cycle continues. This is co-creation, not exploitation.

Pollination teams often work in silence or with quiet singing. They develop a rapt, contemplative focus, moving from plant to plant, hour after hour, day after day during the blooming season. Some describe entering a state where they can feel which flowers need attention and which have already been fertilized. It is a claim that skeptics dismiss as imagination but practitioners insist is real. Whether this represents genuine heightened perception or simply the expertise that comes from thousands of hours of practice hardly matters. The work gets done, and the folks doing it experience it as sacred.

When harvest comes, the river receives thanks through feasting and sharing. Villages hold communal meals along the riverbank. A portion of every harvest, usually herbs or vegetables that can be returned to the water without contamination, goes into the Settan or its symbolic substitute. Not as sacrifice to appease an angry god, but as return. The river gave, we give back, the cycle continues.

Diversity in Devotion

No single orthodoxy governs Settan river worship. Dozens of major cults and hundreds of minor ones operate throughout the South, ranging from the highly organized Temple of Flowing Spirits to informal family-based practices that barely qualify as cults at all.

The Serpent's Embrace, based in Barból town, offers an interesting case study. They worship the Settan as a great serpent deity. It is understood as a symbol of wisdom, transformation, and fertility. Their ceremonies involve elaborate dances and snake-handling. The cult's priests, many of them snake-sints, perform choreographed movements

with wild, non-sentient serpents, believing these actions connect them with the river's serpentine flow. They hold regular feasts celebrating the river's abundance.

They have an ambiguous relationship with Snek, a powerful snake-sint who operates independently in the region and who tolerates but does not encourage their attention. The cult treats Snek as a living avatar of their serpent deity, while Snek regards them with the weary patience of someone who has been mistaken for a god too many times to bother correcting the error.

The Whispering Reed Society, a small cult in southern Baranuq near the Komikol border, operates far from the Settan itself but maintains pilgrimage routes north. They believe that reeds and rushes possess the ability to communicate on behalf of running waters. Their practice involves sitting in reflection by lakes and streams, listening to the whisper of reeds in the wind, interpreting these sounds as messages. Once a year, elders from the society make the long journey north to Barból, where they sit by the Settan itself and listen for what they call the original voice: the river's clearest, most direct communications.

The Moonlit Water Rhapsody, based in the lake region west of Brokily, practices a syncretic form that blends Settan reverence with moons worship. They believe that the reflection of the moons on water carries sacred messages from the Mother, conveyed by celestial beings. During full moons nights, cult members gather on shorelines to chant and perform intricate water dances, mirroring the moons' reflections in their movements. They understand the lakes as extensions of the sacred network fed by the Settan.

Perhaps most mysterious are the Echoing Caves Conclave, based in labyrinthine caverns along the Settan's southern banks, especially across the river from the Fatunik stronghold of Stanbol. This cult believes the river's true voice echoes within underground chambers, and they spend long periods ruminating within the caves, listening for what they describe as the river's whispers within stone reverberations. They paint elaborate murals on cave walls depicting their visions. Some scholars have postulated connections between this cult and the Elders of Juuj in the Dominion, though no definitive link has been established.

Syncretic Streams

The boundary between Settan river cults and Returner beliefs often blurs, particularly in Settarune and Arq. Many Settan worshippers are cultural Returners, which is to say they have an interest in ancient artifacts and the pre-Catastrophe world, but without the ideological fervor of groups of more hard-core Returner cults like the Dixelites.

The Seekers of Setta's Energy are one of the larger river cults that explicitly combines both traditions. They focus on detecting and channeling what they call Setta, understood sometimes as the spirit of the river, sometimes as a more abstract force pervading all existence. Seekers practice thought experiments and conduct rituals at ancient sites they believe have been illuminated or washed by Setta's energy. These sites often feature pre-Catastrophe artifacts such as fragments of old structures, mysterious objects whose original purpose has been forgotten. The Seekers believe that by attuning themselves to Setta's presence in these objects, they gain insight from the past.

More orthodox Settan worshippers sometimes view the Seekers with mild suspicion, finding them too interested in old things and not present enough with the living river. But the Seekers are tolerated and even welcomed in many villages, as they sometimes bring useful knowledge from the ancient sites they study.

More controversial are Malavorra's Devotees, who venerate a possibly mythical southern guru as a living incarnation of the Settan Mother. Malavorra, if she exists or has ever existed is a controversial topic, is said to embody Setta in hum form, a divine intermediary between people and the ancient forces that sustain the world. Devotees make pilgrimages to sites they believe she has designated as sacred or has visited, often overlapping with Returner temples and shrines. This creates occasional tensions with the Seekers, who dislike what they see as personality cult surrounding an unverified individual.

The question of Malavorra's existence remains carefully unanswered throughout the South. In villages where the cult is strong folk will speak of her recent visits. Others treat her as ancient legend, but very real. The Dauni Vakasaqua, when asked, smile and change the

subject. Whether Malavorra is real, mythical, or perhaps an ancient title or role rather than an individual, remains one of the South's enduring mysteries.

The Dauni Vakasaqua

The relationship between the Dauni Vakasaqua (DK) and Settan river worship is profound but not straightforward. The DK are not priests, not exactly. They do not perform formal ceremonies or claim authority to interpret the river's will. Yet their entire practice rests on deep reverence for what they sometimes call the living waters and other times simply Mother.

The Dauni Vakasaqua approach the river as both scientists and devotees. They study water quality, track seasonal variations, monitor the health of riparian ecosystems. They develop irrigation systems that work with the river's natural rhythms rather than fighting them. They breed plant varieties suited to Settan water's particular mineral content. All of this is intensely practical.

Yet they describe this work in spiritual language. When a DK herbalist tests soil composition near a riverbank, she might say, "I'm listening to what Mother is telling the earth." When crews construct a new irrigation canal, they perform brief ceremonies acknowledging the water's gift. When they teach pollination techniques, they frame it as "continuing Mother's work when she can no longer do it alone."

This blending of empirical method and devotional language baffles northern observers, who want to categorize the Dauni Vakasaqua as either pragmatists or mystics. The DK themselves see no contradiction. The river is alive. That's not metaphor or faith; it's observation. It responds to treatment, changes with the seasons, supports or withdraws support from communities depending on how they treat it. Why wouldn't you approach something alive with both rigorous study and respectful attention?

The DK's headquarters in Low Weir, particularly the town of Salassa, sits at the river's source. They tend the springs, maintain the underground chambers where water first emerges, and guard the

knowledge of which waters possess which properties. This is not hoarding but stewardship. They freely share their agricultural innovations, but they protect the sources. The river begins in mystery, and the Dauni Vakasaqua intend to keep it that way.

Contrast with the Pavan

The Settan's northern counterpart is the Pavan River, which flows mainly through Fatunik territory and feeds provinces like Pavanarune. Yet the Pavan inspires nothing like the Settan's devotional intensity. Only Pavanarune province identifies strongly with its river, and even there the relationship is practical. The Pavan provides water, transportation, defense and is important, but without the spiritual charge that defines the South.

Why this difference?

Part of the answer is historical. The Settan's southern territories developed away from Fatunik dominance, allowing indigenous beliefs to flourish without suppression. The Pavan flows through the Dominion's heartland, where Fatunik orthodoxy discourages nature-worship as superstitious and potentially heretical. The Center of Authority prefers its citizens to venerate Fatune's law rather than rivers.

But there's something else. Southerners will tell you the Settan simply is more alive than the Pavan, that you can feel the difference if you pay attention. Northern skeptics dismiss this as regional chauvinism. Yet it's worth noting that the Beqawar, those enigmatic observers from the Empafarasi mountains, take unusual interest in the Settan's southern territories. They watch carefully what happens there. They notice things.

Make of that what you will.

Living with the River

In practical terms, daily life throughout the Settan Lands revolves

around water in ways that shape everything from architecture to social structure. Villages built along the river or its tributaries develop around communal water access points: wells, cisterns, bathing platforms built out over the current. Morning routines begin with water-carrying, with bucket chains, with the particular music of water splashing into clay vessels. It is much the same far from the river, where wells, springs and irrigation canals play much the same role in daily life.

Fishing provides supplemental food, though the river's species have changed since the Catastrophe. What remains are small, tough fish suited to the warmer waters and altered chemistry. Skilled fishers learn where different species gather, which baits work in which seasons. Fishing rights are typically communal within villages, with occasional disputes between neighboring communities over particularly productive stretches.

River (and canal) transport moves goods more efficiently than overland carts in many cases. The Barból Riverwaq operate barges and boats carrying everything from grain to passengers. These river and canal workers develop their own culture, somewhat separate from farming communities. More mobile, more cosmopolitan in outlook, more likely to speak multiple languages and trade freely with northern merchants.

Flooding shapes the agricultural calendar. The Settan floods predictably in spring when mountain snowmelt arrives. Villages in the floodplain build with this in mind. Structures are on raised platforms. Earthen barriers channel water into fields rather than homes. There are extensive drainage and irrigation systems. The flood brings fresh silt and nutrients. Farmers welcome it, even as they work to manage its force.

In dry seasons, the complex network of irrigation channels becomes critical. Villages must negotiate water-sharing agreements, often mediated by Dauni Vakasaqua representatives. These negotiations can become tense. Water means survival. But the South has developed sophisticated traditions of water law that generally prevent violence. Still, stories circulate of feuds that began over a broken weir or a diverted stream.

The river also serves as a natural boundary and, paradoxically, as a connector. The Settan marks the division between the South and the Fatunik-influenced regions to the north, yet it also links the diverse southern provinces together more effectively than any road. News travels along the river. Trade follows the river. Cultural practices spread along the river's length. A musical style developed in Barból will appear in modified form in Baranuq villages within a season, carried by water workers and traveling musicians.

The River's Future

The Settan faces both ecological and political pressures. Climate variations affect flow levels. Some years too much water, other years too little. Pollution from upstream settlements degrades water quality downstream, creating tensions between provinces. The ongoing absence of natural pollinators means the agricultural systems depending on the river remain labor-intensive and vulnerable to population decline.

More ominously, forces in the North occasionally propose projects that would dam or redirect portions of the Settan to serve Dominion interests. So far, the sheer logistical difficulty of imposing such schemes on the wildly cross-grained South has prevented serious attempts, but the suggestions alone create anxiety.

The Dauni Vakasaqua work tirelessly to address these challenges, developing new techniques, breeding hardier plant varieties, mediating disputes, training new generations in agricultural science and river stewardship. Their work is never finished. The river gives, but it also demands attention, care, respect.

If you ask a southern farmer what would happen if the Settan died, if the springs in Low Weir dried up, if the flow stopped, she would look at you with genuine incomprehension. The river cannot die, not while folks tend it. That's not faith. That's contract. We care for the river; the river sustains us. Break the contract and both sides fail.

So the fields get planted, the blossoms get pollinated, the irrigation channels get maintained, the festivals get celebrated, the devotions get

sung. The Settan flows east and south, carrying the work and prayers of the people it sustains, and the South endures. Abundant, diverse, ungovernable, and alive.

Where Roads Converge and Secrets Keep Themselves

The Terpinol community occupies the southeastern corner of the Saskan Lands, a semi-arid province that shouldn't work as well as it does. Bordered by more neighbors than almost any other region, it somehow maintains relationships with all of them without being absorbed by any:

- North: Barbol, where the Settan River meets ancient trade routes
- Northeast: Settarune, the breadbasket province of endless communes
- East: Baranuq, the grain-heart and spiritual center of southern life
- Southeast: West Komikol, foreign land of animal-sints who speak in growls and songs
- West: The Aran Sea, opening to Aranzen's mysteries and southern maritime routes

It is always referred to as a community, not a province, state or region. There is something distinctive about the place and it sticks in the public mind.

The Great Ring Road passes some 50 kilometers north of Terpinol's northernmost frontier. Terpinol maintains sea routes that are unconnected to the Saskan Lands, maritime connections that most land-dwelling folk know nothing about. Terpins are sailors. They simply don't mention it often.

The landscape is harsh and beautiful in equal measure. Semi-arid

plains give way to sudden oases of agricultural settlements that materialize from nowhere. The coast drops precipitously to the sea in places, offering dramatic clifftop views. Inland, the land ripples with low hills concealing unexpected valleys. Sandstorms blow in from the direction of Aranzén with little warning. Summer heat can kill the unprepared.

And yet folks thrive here. Not just survive. Thrive. The province sustains a population far larger than the dry land should support, through methods that look like magic but are actually sophisticated engineering, collaborative labor, and knowledge carefully applied.

Climate and Survival

Terpinol is not forgiving to the ignorant. The sun bakes exposed rock until it's too hot to touch. Water sources are precious and carefully managed. Summer months require adapting daily rhythms; moving in early morning and evening, resting through the brutal midday heat.

But the Terpinol folk have turned harsh conditions into advantage.

A network of channels, weirs, and aqueducts brings water from multiple sources:

- Rainfall captured and stored in underground cisterns
- Moisture extracted from air through greenhouse condensation systems
- Seawater brought inland, then desalinated through slow-filtration techniques
- Distant connection to the Settan River via the Aran Canal

The engineering is remarkable but not ostentatious. Aqueducts look like natural stone formations. Channels follow landscape contours so precisely they seem to have always been there. Windmills, especially around Scatterling, appear decorative but serve crucial functions in pumping and circulation.

Farms cluster in oases where water systems concentrate. Instead of

spreading thinly across the land, agriculture intensifies in these spots.

- Large greenhouse complexes with internal irrigation
- Crop selection favoring heat-tolerant and salt-resistant varieties
- Intercropping systems learned from Baranuq herbalists
- Mycorrhizal networks carefully cultivated to help plants share resources underground

Walking through Terpinol farmland feels like discovering hidden gardens in a desert. Around one bend, nothing but scrub and stone. Around the next, an explosion of green, fruit trees, herb gardens, grain fields, all thriving impossibly.

Buildings maximize shade and airflow.

- Thick walls that store coolness from night
- Courtyards designed to create cross-breezes
- Reflective white or light-colored surfaces
- Underground spaces that maintain constant temperature
- Shade structures using fabric, wood, and living vines

The result is a built environment that works with climate rather than fighting it. Even at the height of summer, properly designed Terpinol buildings remain comfortable.

Cosmopolitan Harmony

More than anywhere else in the Saskan Lands, Terpinol embodies authentic diversity. Every language spoken anywhere in Saskantionon can be heard here. Every culture has representatives. The easy mixing of huum and sint, including non-huum-appearing sints, is conspicuous even by southern standards.

Walk through Terpinol town and you'll see...

- Terpin merchants moving slowly through markets, carrying goods on their broad backs
- Rabbit-sints serving food in cafes, their quick movements a blur

- between tables
- Huum scholars debating astronomy with dolphin-sints who visit via the marina
- Mixed-species families raising children together without comment
- Relationships between obviously non-huum sint and huum that elsewhere would draw stares but here simply are

This isn't performative tolerance. It's the lived reality of a community that has been genuinely multicultural for three centuries. Different ways of being in the world coexist because they've learned how to make space for each other.

Terpinol culture is syncretic in the best sense, not erasing differences but weaving them into something new.

- Religious practices draw from Settan river-worship, Terpin contemplative traditions, Kahila nature-reverence, and even some Aranzen influences
- Cuisine blends Baranuq vegetarian dishes with Komikol seafood traditions and Aranzen spices
- Music incorporates instruments and styles from every corner of the Lands
- Clothing shows Baranuq textile craftsmanship adapted for maritime life, with Dominion practical design and Kahila decorative flourishes

Most Terpinol residents speak at least three languages. Sogomsh dialects dominate daily conversation, but Eibar is understood for trading with northern visitors, and various sint languages using whistles, gestures, scent-signals, sign and so on are accommodated naturally.

The Academy's influence shows everywhere. Multilingualism is treated as normal intellectual hygiene, not special achievement. Children grow up code-switching without thinking about it.

The Invisible Network

Visitors to Terpinol frequently report an uncanny phenomenon. They are expected.

An artisan arriving after a long voyage from Kurosol arrives at an inn and finds a room prepared, a meal being cooked that accommodates their dietary preferences, and the innkeeper asking after their village elders by name, though no courier preceded them.

A scholar heading to the Terpinol Academy stops for the night in a village fifty kilometers away and wakes to find notes left under their door: "The text you seek is in the third archive, west wing, second floor. Ask for Keeper Dalva."

Merchants report that goods they need often arrive just before they realize they need them. Tools break and replacements appear. Ailments develop and the right healer somehow knows to check in.

Theories abound about how this happens....

The prosaic explanation is that Terpinol has simply perfected ordinary communication. Fast riders, signal flags, message lizards, careful observation and prediction. The suspicious explanation is that some form of surveillance network, perhaps connected to the Academy's mysterious competencies, tracks movement through the province. The mystical explanation says that the land itself is waking up, becoming aware, and that Terpinol, perhaps through its connection to terpin root-network practices or something else entirely, has learned to listen. The true explanation is unknown. Asked directly, Terpinol residents smile and change the subject. Ma Eshuna simply says, "People take care of each other here. Is that so strange?"

What is certain is that traveling through Terpinol feels safe in a way few other places do. Not because of visible guards or walls, but because you sense that if something went wrong, help would come. Hospitality is not just custom here. It's infrastructure.

Economy and Trade

Terpinol's economy rests on several pillars.

The Academy is an economic engine. Scholars bring coin and goods. Visiting delegations require food, lodging, supplies. Texts must be copied, translated, preserved. Instruments need crafting. Buildings require maintenance. The Academy alone sustains a significant portion of the province's population.

Maritime trade is robust and Terpinol is the only Saskan port on the Aran Sea. This gives it monopoly access to...

- Goods from Aranzen like spices, unusual materials, knowledge from a deeply foreign culture
- Maritime resources from West Komikol like seafood, shells, and coral
- Sea routes to distant lands that land-bound folk barely know exist

Terpin sailing expertise, rarely advertised, makes this possible. They build ships designed for terpin crews are slower than Mobali vessels but incredibly reliable, able to navigate by methods others don't understand.

The eastern sections of Terpinol, near the Baranuq border, host concealed manufactories that work in...

- Glassmaking, using combustible materials from Baranuq province
- Paper and scroll production, using materials from Settarune
- Textile engineering specializing in fabrics for extreme climates
- Precision tool-making

These industries are kept deliberately low-profile to avoid drawing Dominion attention or triggering trade conflicts. Production is modest but high-quality. Terpinol goods command premium prices elsewhere.

Though not a major grain producer, Terpinol's oasis farms provide:

- Specialty herbs and spices for medicinal use
- Fruits adapted to saline soils

- Seeds bred for drought tolerance, exported to other regions
- Knowledge and consulting. Terpinol agronomists are sought after advisors

The Invisible Council

Here's something strange: Terpinol is called a Community and everyone assumes it has a formal governance structure, yet no one can point to a governor, council chamber, or bureaucracy.

Decisions clearly get made. Roads are maintained. Disputes are resolved. Resources are allocated. But by whom? Through what process?

What is known is that...

- Major decisions seem to emerge from consensus rather than decree
- The Academy's senior members carry informal authority but claim no official power
- Village elder councils handle local matters but defer to... someone... on broader issues
- Ma Eshuna is frequently mentioned when people discuss "how things work," but she holds no title
- The Root Circle is sometimes referenced obliquely, but never clearly, as a leading body

What this looks like in practice is that someone notices a bridge needs repair. They mention it. Within days, materials appear, skilled workers show up, the bridge gets fixed. No bureaucratic approval process. No contracts or formal planning. It simply... happens.

This drives visiting officials from more structured societies to distraction. Dominion administrators looking for someone to negotiate with find themselves passed from person to person, each claiming they're not actually in charge. Eventually, deals get made,

but the process feels like negotiating with fog.

The system works because...

- 1 Trust is genuinely high. Folks believe others will act in good faith.
- 2 Roles emerge organically based on skill and need rather than hierarchy.
- 3 Long-term residents understand unspoken conventions.
- 4 The Academy provides neutral space for resolving the few serious disputes that arise.
- 5 A connective tissue beneath visible society coordinates actions.

Whatever that something else is, it's not simple. And it's not shared with outsiders.

The Villages

While Terpinol town dominates, several villages play important roles.

Scatterling serves as the community's outer face. It is a place where Academy influence extends but feels less overwhelming. Where philosophical work happens away from the main campus. Where diplomatic back-channels operate. Where ancient artifacts like a typewriter and a slot machine draw pilgrims. Where enormous windmill fields hint at technologies most folk don't fully understand.

Aranmouth huddles near the border with Barból and Aranzen. It is a fishing village that has resisted growth. Its residents maintain trade relationships across the border that they prefer not to discuss. Occasionally, someone emerges from Aranzen, dusty and sun-mad, carrying items or knowledge that eventually make their way to the Academy. Aranmouth folk nod and ask no questions.

Greenharbor, even more remote than Terpinol, located on the tip of the peninsula jutting into the Aran Sea, manages the main marina facilities in the community, distinct from the marina at Terpinol but closely coordinated. Here, Terpin shipwrights work alongside hum and sint sailors. The smell of tar and salt permeates everything.

Travelers arriving by sea get their first glimpse of southern Saskan culture here, usually startlingly welcoming after the paranoia of Komikol ports.

Stonespring sits to the west, near the border with Settarune and Baranuq, in the Terpinol highlands, at a natural water source. What began as a watering stop for caravans has become a small community of stoneworkers, jewellers, and crystal specialists who work mainly with materials sourced from Baranuq. Their craftsmanship rivals Kurosol's, though on a smaller scale.

Dozens of smaller settlements — farmsteads, herding camps, isolated research stations — dot the landscape. Most welcome visitors warmly. All feel somehow connected to the invisible network that makes Terpinol function.

Borders and Relationships

With Barból relations are friendly and economically intertwined. The Aran Canal connects them and trade flows easily. Many Barból folk send their children to study at the Academy. Cultural exchange is constant.

With Settarune there is a respectful distance. Settarune's radical decentralization and refusal to create towns makes them philosophically interesting to Terpinol scholars but practically difficult to engage with. While cultural exchanges are constant, trade happens through Brokily intermediaries.

With Baranuq there is a deep kinship. Most terpins originally came from Baranuq. Ma Eshuna hatched there. Cultural and spiritual ties remain strong. Baranuq provides grain and materials. Terpinol provides manufactured goods and knowledge access. The relationship feels less like separate provinces than like different organs in one body.

With West Komikol the relationship is complicated but functional. Komikol animal-sints view hum with suspicion, and Terpinol's hum-sint integration puzzles them. But trade occurs and diplomacy happens, if somewhat fitfully. Terpinol serves as neutral ground when Komikol needs to negotiate with wider Saskantion. Occasionally,

Komikol raiders test Terpinol's southern borders during hard years. The community's lack of visible militia sometimes misleads various Komikol bands into thinking the Terpins are soft. They learn otherwise.

With Aranzen, mainly via sea routes since the desert is nearly impassable, the relationship is inscrutable. Aranzen is foreign in ways that even the Komikols are not, a different civilization entirely, with a huum majority. Terpinol maintains the only regular Saskan contact with Aranzen. What exactly gets traded, what knowledge flows, what relationships exist, these questions go unanswered. Those who know aren't telling.

Festival and Flow

Life in Terpinol follows seasonal rhythms adapted to heat and maritime cycles.

Seasonal Celebrations include...

- The Spring Tides Festival celebrating the calm sailing season, with boat races, seafood feasts, and maritime contests.
- The Summer Contemplation during the hottest months, emphasizing interior work like study, meditation, and craft rather than travel.
- The Autumn Gathering. When Road travel becomes more or less comfortable again, this is a time for welcoming travelers and new students to the Academy.
- The Winter Lights. The winter festival features nighttime events with elaborate lantern displays and astronomical observation parties.

As for the rhythm of daily routines, activity peaks in early morning and again at evening. Midday is for rest, indoor work, or remaining in shade. Markets bustle at dawn and dusk. The Academy's food halls serve constantly but see rushes at off-hours. This pattern confuses northern visitors at first, but makes sense once they experience

southern heat.

Arts and Expression

- Music blends traditions—terpin drum-rhythms, Kahila flutes, Baranuq string instruments
- Visual arts favor calligraphy, textile design, and intricate glasswork
- Performance includes storytelling (multiple traditions), dance (from solemn to ecstatic), and collaborative improvisation
- Architecture itself is considered art—the way buildings frame light, create sound, shape experience

The Academy hosts visiting artists constantly, but art also flourishes in villages, in marketplaces, on street corners. Terpinol culture treats creative expression as necessary rather than luxury.

Spiritual Landscape

Terpinol's spiritual life is syncretic and non-dogmatic, reflecting the Academy's influence and Ma Eshuna's philosophy. Many strains of ritual are practiced. The most common are...

Settan River reverence. Though geographically distant from the river itself, folk maintain connection through ritual and remembrance. Water from the Settan, brought via the canal, is used in ceremonies.

Terpin contemplative practices. Turtle-sitting, life-energy cultivation, and slow movement forms are practices available to all interested, not restricted to terpins. Many find their way to Terpinol specifically to study these methods.

Nature animism is widespread, often in syncretic combinations. Respect for the land as living and aware permeates daily life. This isn't abstract philosophy. It's expressed in how people interact with place. Asking permission before taking. Offering thanks. Listening to what the wind and waves seem to be saying.

Cosmological inquiry is a Terpinol specialty. It is one of the main

reasons why the Dominion tends to take a dim view of the Academy and the community. The Academy's astronomical work feeds directly into spiritual questions. What is consciousness? How does observation affect reality? Are the stars and moons aware of us as we're aware of them? These lines of inquiry aren't separated into science and religion; they're one big set of investigations.

Ancestor acknowledgment inform multiple traditions of honoring the dead such as: Terpin methods like preservation in root-networks, Baranuq burial customs involving returning to earth, Settan water-rites that include some ashes into the river or other waters, and even Komikol sky-burial practices all happen here, and all respected.

There are no religious authorities demanding conformity. No temples requiring attendance. No orthodoxy testing belief. Instead there are many paths, all honored, all leading toward... something. What that something is remains an open question.

What Makes Terpinol Special

Visitors struggle to articulate what makes Terpinol different from other places. It's not just one thing but a combination. Safety without oppression; you feel secure but not surveilled. Protected but not controlled. Somehow both free and held. A commitment to diversity that functions effortlessly. Not just tolerance but genuine integration. Difference doesn't erase; it enriches. Somehow. Knowledge is freely shared, for the most part. Information isn't hoarded or weaponized. It flows. Scholars from enemy nations work side by side, and while they might take knowledge home, while here they collaborate honestly. An almost eerie sense of otherness, a feeling that anything could happen, that reality works slightly differently here, a nagging sensation that beneath visible society, there is something else, something older, something connected to the land itself that is paying attention. This the mystery of Terpinol. All of this works through mechanisms that resist explanation. Ask how Terpinol does what it does, and answers dissolve into mist. Not evasion exactly. More like, the question doesn't quite make sense any more. It's like asking a tree how it grows. It just does.

Travelers getting there..

- By road. Take the Ring Road to Barból, then switch to hired transport from the Terrapin Travel Company for the long, slow ride southwards.
- By sea there are maritime routes from Komikol, Aranzen, and distant southern lands to Greenharbor marina. Fewer foreign ships dock directly at Terpinol.
- On foot, it is possible but very challenging. Heat and distance demand proper preparation.

The Future

Terpinol has thrived for three centuries on Ma Eshuna's vision and terpin patience. But Ma Eshuna grows older. The Saskan Lands grows more fractured. Pressures increase from Dominion politics, Empafarasi expansion, Untamed militancy, and stranger forces still.

Can a place built on cooperation and neutral ground survive when all sides demand loyalty? Can knowledge remain free when information becomes weaponized? Can diversity persist when identity hardens into tribalism? These questions haunt the Community's deeper circles. No answers have emerged. Only determination to try, for as long as possible, to hold the center.

One thing is certain: if Terpinol falls, something irreplaceable will die with it. It is not just another province or institution, but proof that another way is possible. That beings from wildly different origins can build together. That knowledge can serve life rather than power. The rest of Saskantanon doesn't always notice Terpinol. But they'd miss it if it were gone.

A Village at the Edge

Scatterling hides inside a unique ring of heights that overlook a deep

lake not too far from the coast, 100 kilometers south of Barból, and still 100 kilometers north of Terpinol town. Cliffs drop sheer to Prayzo Lake and the wind never quite stops moving in irregular patterns. The water in the lake is impossibly deep, the rocks on the hilltops circling the lake and the village are sharp. The way through them is hidden, through a tunnel. The village faces the lake, towards the west, as if watching for something that may or may not come from over the western rim of the surrounding hills.

The approach to Scatterling is difficult. Those who have not been invited often report strange obstacles: windstorms materializing from clear skies, roads that seem to loop back on themselves, a sudden exhaustion that makes continuing feel impossible. Locals shrug at these stories. "The wind has moods," they say. "Sometimes it wants you to turn back."

Those who persist, or who arrive with implicit invitation, find the wind settles. The road straightens. The entrance to the tunnel appears. You pass through and suddenly there it is, a delightful village in Terpinol style, white-walled buildings with shaded courtyards, small gardens tended with obvious care, and stretching in every direction, the most remarkable feature of the landscape: windmills.

Hundreds of them. Perhaps thousands. They line the inner part of the cliffs, march across the lower hills, cluster in the valley around the lake. Tall elegant structures, their blades turning steadily in the constant breezes. At dawn and dusk, when light hits them just right, they cast shadows that pattern the land like writing in some enormous script. At night, some glow faintly, not bright enough to read by, but enough to suggest that power flows through them toward purposes not immediately obvious.

When visitors ask about the windmills, residents offer a prepared answer: "They are art. A demonstration of our willingness to obey the voices of the wind." The explanation is both true and false and utterly insufficient.

What Scatterling Is

On the surface, Scatterling is a village of perhaps three hundred permanent residents, engaged in modest industries.

The Free and Independent Tailors Guild maintains its leadership council here. Scatterling clothing, the rarest and costliest of garments, is renowned across the Lands for style, durability, and clever design. Here you can buy fabrics that breathe in heat, repel water, resist tearing. Master weavers work here, their patterns said to incorporate protective geometries alongside aesthetic beauty.

The Free and Independent Scribes Guild keeps extensive facilities in Scatterling. Beyond simple copying, these scribes specialize in translation, cipher-work, and document authentication. If you need text rendered from one language to another while preserving subtle meanings, you come here.

The Independent Healers Association coordinates from Scatterling, working closely with the Dauni Vakasaqua, the Dexelites and others. The village hosts one of the most advanced surgical facilities in the Saskan Lands. It is a clean, well-lit clinic where healers perform procedures that elsewhere would be considered impossible such as setting compound fractures, removing internal growths, treating infections that normally kill. Their success rate is unnervingly high.

These are real industries, employing real folks, producing real goods and services. But they're also façades. Not false, by any means, but incomplete. Scatterling is more than the sum of its visible activities.

The Root Circle

There is a group that gathers in Scatterling when needed. They have no formal name, though tradition has settled on the Root Circle. It is not an organization, but a recognition. They are:

- Deep scholars from the Academy
- Terpin elders some of whom may remember times before the Academy existed
- Certain philosophers whose questions have led them beneath surface explanations

- Those who study esoteric principles not as theory but as lived practice
- Individuals who have learned to listen to what the land itself whispers

They meet in chambers beneath Scatterling, in spaces fitted with strange devices. Cages woven from specific metals, sound-dampening geometries built into walls, materials that somehow prevent observation by methods both mundane and esoteric. When the Root Circle gathers, even other Terpinol residents remain unaware.

What they discuss is not recorded. What they decide emerges as action without attribution. They are not a conspiracy. Their goals are not hidden. They simply recognize that some work proceeds better when not watched, some questions deepen better in darkness, and some coordination functions best when it looks like coincidence.

Ma Eshuna is connected to this circle, though whether as member, founder, or simply respected elder is unclear. Other members include:

- Senior knowledge workers from the Academy
- Representatives from the Dauni Vakasaqua's inner councils and Dexelite priests
- Occasional visitors sent by the Magisters from Bye, Empafarasi Table leaders, and even the occasional scholar from Ingar
- Terpin navigators who understand sea-routes and star-paths
- Those who work with the windmill network and understand what it actually does

The Root Circle is why Scatterling exists. It provides a meeting place away from the Academy's bustle, protected by distance and deliberate obscurity, where those who coordinate Terpinol's deeper workings can speak freely.

The Windmills

The windmills are beautiful. This is not deception. They genuinely are

artworks, their placement and proportions carefully designed. But beauty serves function here.

- The windmills generate mechanical power distributed through underground systems
- They pump water, grind materials, drive ventilation for underground spaces
- Their patterns create airflow effects that influence local weather, slightly, subtly
- They serve as observation platforms and signal points
- Some incorporate unusual materials, certain crystalline elements and metal alloys not used elsewhere
- The windmills form a network that extends beyond mechanical function
- They may be resonators or amplifiers for something, of energy, information, ...consciousness?
- Their patterns might encode meaning, a kind of data storage in geometric form
- They could be part of the invisible network that makes Terpinol function
- They're connected to the Academy's deeper competencies

Ask the windmill tenders and you get variations on: "They listen to the wind, and they speak to the earth. What they say to each other, we don't fully understand. But they've been here almost as long as Terpinol itself, and while they turn, the land stays healthy."

Some nights, if you watch carefully, the windmills' movements synchronize in ways wind patterns shouldn't produce. As if they're conversing. As if something moves through them beyond mere mechanical rotation.

The Surgery

The surgical facility in Scatterling doesn't advertise. There's no sign, no announcement. But those who need it find their way here, or are brought here by Dauni Vakasaqua members, sometimes working as

Dessani Mider, by Dexelites, or by others devoted the healing arts.

The Facility...

- Features spotlessly clean rooms with excellent natural light supplemented by focused lamps
- Use instruments of remarkable precision, many made in Terpinol's concealed workshops
- Has anesthetics that work better than they should. Mostly herbal preparations developed through Baranuq-Terpinol and Mobali-Terpinol collaboration
- Provides post-surgical care that prevents infections at rates approaching miraculous
- Hosts healers who combine anatomical knowledge with life-energy techniques

They treat internal injuries that elsewhere would be death sentences, growths that need removal, complicated births, infections deep in tissue or bone and reconstructive work after accidents or violence. They cannot cure everything. Death still comes. But they push the boundaries of what's survivable, using methods that blend careful observation, accumulated knowledge, and something else—a sensitivity to how life-energy flows through bodies, how to support healing rather than merely cutting and hoping.

The Dauni Vakasaqua are strong supporters of this operation, providing the public face of respectable healing work. Behind them, Academy researchers study outcomes, refine techniques, and quietly advance medical understanding. The collaboration works because diverse groups share the same goal: reduce suffering, extend life where possible, ease passing when not.

Some patients arrive at Scatterling expecting to die and leave walking. Others come hoping for miracles and receive instead gentle honesty about what can and cannot be done, followed by the best possible care until the end. Both groups leave grateful.

The Ancient Artifacts

Scatterling possesses two items that draw pilgrims, particularly Finders, Returners and others devoted to varieties of what they consider to be the old-time-religions.

There is a typewriter, a manual device of metal and keys, impossibly ancient, that inscribes letters onto paper through mechanical action. It sits under glass in a small shrine-like room open to visitors. No one knows precisely how old it is. It is certainly pre-Arrival, possibly much older. The mechanism still functions, though it's rarely demonstrated in order to preserve it. Byenung scholars are studying ways to reproduce it.

Finders and Returners and some Dexelites come to study its construction, to pray beside it, to touch the glass and feel connection to the world-that-was. Some claim to receive visions near it, claiming glimpses of the past, of cities and technologies beyond current imagination. Others simply sit quietly, contemplating the mystery of a device that turns thought into permanent mark through purely mechanical means.

The slot machine is another pre-Arrival artifact, this one even stranger. A metal box with a lever and spinning wheels marked with symbols. When activated, which requires specific coins that are no longer in circulation, so it's rarely used, it spins and sometimes dispenses more coins than inserted, sometimes none. A device of chance, of random outcome, of play without any evident productive purpose.

To Finders and Returners, it represents the abundance-thinking of the old world, the idea that systems could generate surplus, that play itself had value, that randomness could be harnessed for entertainment. To others, it's simply baffling. Why would anyone build such a thing?

Both artifacts are meticulously preserved. Their presence in Scatterling rather than at the Academy is deliberate. They draw certain seekers here, to this outer edge, where other things can be quietly observed and assessed.

Hospitality and Boundaries

Scatterling is famous for its hospitality, even more so than Terpinol. Visitors are welcomed warmly, fed well, housed comfortably. The village exudes safety and calm. People speak in measured tones. No one rushes. Time moves differently here, stretched and softened by sea-wind and the constant turning of windmill blades.

But boundaries exist, invisible but firm.

Certain buildings are not entered. Doors remain closed. When asked, residents simply say, "That's private space," and the questioner finds themselves accepting this without argument.

Certain topics are not discussed. Questions about the windmill network's deeper functions, about who makes decisions in Terpinol, about Academy secrets. These questions are met with pleasant redirection. Not rudeness. The conversation just flows elsewhere.

Certain people are not welcome. Most visitors feel embraced. A very few find the village inexplicably uncomfortable. Food tastes wrong. Sleep comes poorly. The wind feels hostile. These individuals usually leave quickly, sensing without being told that Scatterling is not for them.

The village protects itself through subtlety. No guards patrol. No walls stand. But something watches, something judges, and those who mean harm find themselves gently, or not so gently, encouraged to leave.

Daily Life

For permanent residents, Scatterling offers a particular quality of life.

The guilds provide employment. Textile workers, scribes, and healers practice their crafts at high level. But work is not all-consuming. There's time for contemplation, for walking the clifftops, for sitting among the windmills and listening to their creaking song.

Scatterling is genuinely close-knit. People know each other, care for each other, share joys and griefs. Evening meals are often communal. Stories are shared. Music is made. Children grow up safe and curious.

Like Terpinol generally, Scatterling hosts huum, terpin, and various sint without hierarchy. Mixed families are common. Relationships between species that elsewhere would draw comment simply are. A huum weaver might partner with a terpin scribe. A rabbit-sint healer might raise children with a huum carpenter. Life happens.

No temple dominates Scatterling. Instead, spiritual life weaves through daily existence. Meditation at dawn. Offerings to the lake, the hills, the wind. Quiet acknowledgment of forces larger than self. The windmills themselves serve as focal points. Many residents spend time sitting near specific mills, as if drawing something from their presence.

The Outer Face of Deeper Things

Scatterling serves as the place where Terpinol's philosophical and practical work can interface with the wider world without exposing the Academy itself.

When leaders need to meet but cannot do so publicly, Scatterling provides location. The Mother's Circle from the Dauni Vakasaqua, the Magisters of Bye, the higher Tables of Empafarasi, occasional scholars from Ingar, Selaron, Borted and Eelan come to Scatterling when direct Academy involvement would be too visible.

Conversations happen in cliff-side pavilions, in quiet rooms above tailor shops, in gardens where windmill shadows pattern the ground. Agreements are reached. Understandings are formed. No records are kept. No announcements are made. But the world shifts slightly, becomes a bit more cooperative, a bit less violent.

Scribes in Scatterling don't just copy texts. They facilitate information flow between communities that don't directly communicate. A Kahila band's discoveries about herbal medicine reach Dominion healers without either side knowing the source. Empafarasi strategic insights

inform Nyland merchant decisions through chains of translation and paraphrase that obscure origins.

Scatterling is a dense node in networks that official histories don't record. Knowledge scatters like seeds, takes root elsewhere, grows into understanding that seems to emerge spontaneously but was actually carefully planted.

Some who visit Scatterling are being evaluated. Not through formal testing, but through observation. How do they treat those serving them food? How do they respond to not getting answers? What questions do they ask? How do they sit with silence? In some cases, a visit to Scatterling will determine whether or not an invitation to Terpinol will be forthcoming. Those who demonstrate capacity for deeper work might receive invitation. Not explicitly, but by the presentation of an opportunity. A suggestion to visit the Academy at Terpinol. A chance meeting with someone who asks interesting questions. A door that opens when previously it was closed.

Scatterling seeks out those who might join the work of holding Terpinol's center, of maintaining neutral ground, of keeping knowledge flowing and cooperation possible.

Dangers and Vulnerabilities

Scatterling's position makes it both powerful and exposed. Far from Terpinol town, close to the Komikol border, reachable by roads that are easily blocked. If someone wanted to strike at Scatterling, isolation could become trap rather than protection. And the windmills cannot be hidden. They announce technological capability. To those who fear Terpinol's competencies or who wish to control advanced knowledge, the windmills are provocation.

It is a well-known meeting place, despite the difficult some folks encounter trying to find it. Anyone watching for diplomatic activity knows to watch Scatterling. The village's role as neutral ground depends on all parties respecting that neutrality. What happens when someone stops respecting it? Furthermore, the typewriter and slot machine attract not just reverent Finders but also those who might

wish to possess or destroy such things. Scatterling must balance accessibility with security.

As word spreads about healing that shouldn't be possible, more desperate cases arrive. Each success raises questions: How? Why here? What do they know that we don't? Jealousy, suspicion, and desire to control all follow.

Scatterling is a word for something scattered. Seeds on wind, stones across a field, people dispersed from origin. It speaks to diaspora, to things that were once together and now are apart. Scattering is also how things spread. Seeds must scatter to grow. Ideas must disperse to take root. People must move outward to discover and return with understanding.

Scatterling is where Terpinol scatters its influence without seeming to. Where knowledge disperses. Where those who will carry work forward are identified and invited. Where the wind takes what it learns here and carries it elsewhere. The windmills turn. The wind never stops. Scatterling continues its work of scattering seeds that will grow into gardens which others might mistake for wilderness, into understandings that seems to emerge naturally but were carefully planted, into connections that feel like chance but are actually cultivations.

The village is small. Its influence is vast. And like the wind that moves through the windmill fields, it touches everything without most folks ever fully appreciating the source.

The Fourth Pillar of Saskan Learning

Three centuries ago, when the Settan Lands were still finding their footing after generations of upheaval, a young terpin dreamer named

Eshuna convinced a handful of scholars, builders, and visionaries to join her at a remote fishing village a thousand clicks south of Barból on the Aran Sea. What began as a modest observatory and meeting hall has become one of the architectural and intellectual marvels of the known world: the Academy at Terpinol.

Unlike the Night Hall Library at Byenung with its bureaucratic layers, or the archives at the Holly Tower of Ingar, guarded by the Seven Titans and hosting the ancient memory of Dominion politics, of the carefully guarded vaults inside the Mistral Tower, the Terpinol Academy emerged free from ideological constraints. It stands as the fourth great pillar of Saskan culture, balancing the martial traditions of Bored and Beshquahoek, the mercantile networks of Byenung, and the emerging power of the Empafarasi with something entirely different: a commitment to evidence-based knowledge paired with profound spiritual inquiry that demands no dogma.

The Academy is nearly indistinguishable from Terpinol town. Most residents dedicate their lives to its maintenance and flourishing, whether as scholars, craftspeople, cooks, or gardeners. To walk the streets of Terpinol is to walk the corridors of the Academy. They are one and the same.

Architecture & Grounds

The Academy rivals and arguably surpasses the Night Hall as an architectural wonder. Where Byenung built both horizontally and vertically with precise engineering, Terpinol sprawls organically horizontally and then burrows deep, creating a maze-like complex that reveals surprises at every turn.

Above Ground

- Towers rising toward the stars, housing the observatory instruments
- Rotundas with domed ceilings painted to mirror seasonal star patterns
- Vast halls for lectures, debates, and demonstrations
- Innumerable gardens, patios, verandahs, and balconies offering

- views of the Aran Sea, the desert, or the distant mountains
- Open-air courtyards where students practice forms both martial and meditative

Below Ground

The underground sections are whispered about more than seen. Vast caverns house...

- Climate-controlled archives protecting ancient texts from humidity
- Acoustic chambers where sound behaves strangely, used for certain spiritual practices
- The Green Room, a chamber of mysteries
- Workshops for delicate instrument-making, away from wind and temperature fluctuations

Every corner offers discovery. A narrow staircase might lead to a rooftop meditation platform. A service corridor might open into a library annex specializing in pre-Arrival maritime charts. The Academy was not planned all at once—it has grown organically over three centuries, each generation adding their own vision.

The Library

The Academy's library exceeds Byenung's renowned collection in scope and accessibility.

Documents, maps, scrolls, and codices in every language spoken across Saskantinon and beyond fill shelf after shelf. Sogomsh dialects, Eibar variants, little-known variants of the Bar language, Kahila pictographs, even texts describing the whistling script used by certain dolphin-sints. All are preserved here.

Permanent knowledge workers, librarians, scribes, translators,

maintain the collection:

- Collating new acquisitions
- Cross-referencing related materials
- Translating key texts into multiple languages
- Repairing damaged manuscripts
- Creating finding aids and annotated bibliographies

Unlike some institutions that restrict access to their treasures, the Academy's philosophy is simple: knowledge grows when shared. Any visitor in good standing may request materials. Rare or fragile items require supervised viewing, but even these are made available to serious scholars.

Departments & Fields of Study

The Academy houses specialists in every known discipline.

Natural Sciences

- Astronomy and celestial mechanics (the observatory is unmatched in the Lands)
- Botany, with extensive study of medicinal herbs and agricultural innovation
- Geology and mineralogy (drawing on Baranuq's crystal and tar-field knowledge)
- Marine biology (the Aran Sea provides endless subjects)

Applied Knowledge

- Evidence-based medicine and surgery
- Engineering and water management (irrigation systems, aqueducts, canal design)
- Architecture and urban planning
- Textile engineering (developing fabrics for extreme climates)

Sentient Studies

- Linguistics and comparative language studies
- History and chronology (attempting to piece together pre-Arrival events)
- Philosophy (with particular attention to questions of consciousness and planetary resonance)
- Mathematics and theoretical geometry

Esoteric Practices

- Life-energy cultivation techniques
- Dream interpretation and collective dreaming studies
- Resonance mapping (how consciousness interacts with physical matter)
- Meditation and contemplative traditions from across all cultures

Disciplines overlap constantly. A botanist might collaborate with a healer and a chef to develop new medicinal s'lah blends. An astronomer might work with a philosopher to explore questions about observation affecting reality. This cross-pollination is encouraged.

Daily Life at the Academy

The Academy maintains exquisite cafes and food halls, all free of charge and open day and night. Visitors from agricultural Baranuq often marvel at the seafood abundance. Fresh catches from the Aran Sea are prepared with culinary artistry. The s'lah here is legendary, crafted by specialists who treat beverage-making as a form of alchemy.

Meals are communal but not compulsory. Scholars eat when hunger strikes, not by rigid schedule. The cafes buzz with conversation at all hours: a midnight debate about star-drift, a dawn discussion of new

grafting techniques, an afternoon argument about proper translation of ancient Sogomsh poetry.

Exercise programs focus on internal martial arts and yoga-like practices that emphasize breath, balance, and subtle energy work. In the early morning, courtyards fill with practitioners moving through slow, deliberate forms. Ancient terpin masters (some say they've been teaching here since the Academy's founding) guide students in movements that look like dance but feel like meditation.

These practices are not separate from intellectual work. They're considered essential to it. A clear body supports a clear mind. The Academy understands that breakthrough insights often come after hours of physical exertion, when the conscious mind steps aside.

There are no formal semesters or graduation ceremonies. Learning is continuous. Some students stay for a season, others for decades. Some come seeking specific knowledge, others to immerse themselves in the atmosphere of inquiry.

Teachers don't lecture from positions of untouchable authority. The Academy inherited the Terpin preference for dialogue, for questions that spiral deeper rather than answers that close discussion. A master is simply someone who has spent more time with a question, not someone who has solved it.

The Mysteries

Certain aspects of the Academy resist easy explanation.

Visitors frequently remark that inns along the roads to Terpinol seem to expect their arrival. Meals are prepared before they order. Rooms are ready as they approach. Some attribute this to excellent organizational systems. Others sense something deeper, a form of communication that doesn't rely on couriers or written messages. The Academy offers no public explanation.

Deep beneath the oldest section of the Academy lies a space spoken

of rarely and seen by almost none. It is called the Green Room. Only terpins are permitted entry, with occasional exceptions so rare they become legend. It is said to be a bio-symbiotic archive where memories are preserved not in ink but in living root-networks, where songs are sung not with voices but through touch and vibration.

What happens there, what is stored there, who has access, these questions go unanswered. When pressed, terpin elders simply say: "Some things must remain in the dark to stay alive."

The village of Scatterling, south along the coast, serves as an outer meeting place for the Academy's philosophical community. Folk speak of the Root Circle. Not a formal organization, but a loose network of thinkers who gather there when deep questions need addressing away from the bustle of the main campus. What happens in Scatterling stays in Scatterling. Windmills turn. Conversations unfold. No records are kept.

Cultural Significance

The Academy functions as neutral ground in an increasingly fractious world.

When Kahila reformers and Fatunik diplomats cannot meet in their own territories without bloodshed, they meet at Terpinol. When the Empafarasi need intelligence that the Dominion suppresses, they send researchers to the library. When Baranuq herbalists discover a new cure but lack the language to describe it precisely, they bring samples to the Academy's botanists.

This neutrality is fiercely protected. The Academy hosts Fatunik scholars, Kahila poets, Nyland merchants, and former Untamed militants, often simultaneously. Weapons are discouraged within the grounds (though not forbidden; the terpin way is persuasion, not prohibition). Violence inside the Academy would be a catastrophic breach of custom. It has not happened in three centuries.

The province of Terpinol has no obvious militia, no visible guard posts. Yet travelers consistently report feeling safe on Terpinol roads, as if unseen watchers ensure that hospitality remains inviolate.

Visiting the Academy

Terpinol lies at the southeastern edge of the Saskan Lands, on the Aran Sea. The Ring Road passes far to the north near Barból town. Many visitors travel by road, hiring transport from the Terrapin Travel Company. Maritime travelers can sail into Terpinol's marina, the only Saskan port on the Aran Sea. But the most common way to get there is via the Aran Canal.

The atmosphere is cosmopolitan and welcoming. Every language is spoken here. Huum and sint mingle without the tensions common elsewhere. Close relationships between obviously non-huum sint and huum, while not ubiquitous, raise no eyebrows.

The semi-arid climate can be harsh, but the Academy's architecture manages heat brilliantly with shade structures, water features, and buildings designed to capture evening breezes. Oases of agricultural settlements dot the province, producing food seemingly by magic (in reality, through sophisticated irrigation and greenhouse systems).

Scholars from every corner of Saskantinon and beyond come to Terpinol. Young weavers from Baranuq seeking to improve their craft. Empafarasi strategists studying logistics and supply chains. Exiled Dominion dissidents researching suppressed histories. Kahila mystics comparing their dream-practices with terpin techniques. Merchants learning new languages to expand trade routes.

Students range from teenagers on their first journey from home to white-haired elders seeking answers to questions that have haunted them for decades. The Academy makes no distinction based on age, species, or prior education. The only requirement is genuine curiosity.

Officially, the Academy charges no tuition. Learning is considered a

right, not a commodity. In practice, visitors contribute what they can: labor, materials, expertise, coin if they have it. A skilled carpenter might spend months building furniture for new dormitories. A farmer might donate grain. A wealthy merchant might fund a new telescope lens. The system works because it's flexible and based on mutual respect rather than rigid exchange.

Legacy & Future

The Academy's influence extends far beyond its grounds. Methods pioneered here like evidence-based medicine, careful astronomical observation, and multi-cultural collaborative research have spread across the Lands. When the Aran Canal was built, Terpinol engineers worked alongside Byenung's eager beavers. When the Empafarasi developed their sophisticated food preservation systems, they drew on research done at the Academy.

But the Academy's deepest legacy may be harder to quantify. It proved that beings from radically different cultures, species, and worldviews can work together toward shared understanding without anyone being forced to abandon their identity. In a world fracturing along ethnic, political, and spiritual lines, Terpinol stands as evidence that another way is possible.

The founder of the Academy, Ma Eshuna, now ancient even by terpin standards, still resides somewhere in the Academy's depths. She is rarely seen, but her presence shapes everything. When someone asks how the Academy maintains its neutrality, its openness, its mysterious competence, the answer is always the same: "Ask Eshuna."

Few ever do. Those who try rarely find her. And those who find her discover that she prefers questions to answers.

The Weight of Centuries

In the deepest vaults beneath Terpinol Academy, where roots of ancient logs press against stone and the air tastes of earth and time, an elderly terpin sometimes sits alone in the dark. Her shell, black as basalt and worn smooth by more than three centuries of life, catches no light because she prefers none. She moves slowly even by terpin standards. Each gesture is deliberate, each breath measured, as if she's learned to conserve something more precious than energy.

This is Ma Eshuna. Founder of the Terpinol Academy. Bridge-builder between fractured communities. Witness to Monmar's arrival and the reshaping of the world. The one who choses to stay when others of her kind withdraw into timelessness.

Crowds no longer sing for her in public squares, though they once did. Revolutionaries no longer seek her counsel, though many still follow principles she taught. These days she prefers sitting under a particular tree in one of the Academy's quieter courtyards, sharing silence with a handful of old friends who understand that words, after so many years, sometimes fail to carry the weight of what needs saying.

She is tired. Not of living, never that, but of wondering whether the seeds she planted will grow into the gardens she imagined, or something else entirely. Something with thorns.

Names Like Sediment

Ma Eshuna is what most folk call her, the name that spread throughout the Settan Lands when she first began her public work. The "Ma" is an Eibar honorific, half affection and half respect, the way frontier hum name things they don't quite understand but have learned to value. To traveling merchants, to young scholars arriving at the Academy, to Kahila bands passing through southern territories, she is simply Ma Eshuna, a grandmother figure of legendary wisdom and stubbornness.

Eshuna alone is how those who know her better speak of her. The name carries weight in southern Sogomsh dialects: world-dreamer. Former students use it. Colleagues at the Academy. Rabbits-sints who still practice the cooperative, pacifist approaches she has always championed. "Eshuna says..." is enough to settle certain arguments.

Muatza is what other terpins call her when speaking among themselves. Her birth-name, carried from hatchling days in the warm shallows of southern Baranuq. It means, roughly, big snapper, reflecting equal parts affection and acknowledgment that even as a youth, she had a big bite. In the scattered terpin communities along the Bay of Bar, among the shell-kin who remember her from centuries past, she is still Muatza, and the name carries the intimacy of shared origins.

Orrizha of the Third Vault is her formal title within the Academy's deepest circles. The sap-stone archives know her by this name. Here, Orrizha marks her as a ritual keeper, one who guards certain forms of knowledge that exist outside written language. The Third Vault refers to her custodianship of the Green Room, though few outside terpin ranks know what that means.

Auma Orrizha Tzumiin Muatza Eshuna is her full ceremonial name, used only in the most formal contexts—when high-ranking scholars from distant lands address her in official capacity, when sacred rituals require proper invocation, when treaties are witnessed. Each element carries meaning:

- Auma (Blessed Rememberer)
- Orrizha (Guardian-Dreamer)
- Tzumiin (a mystery-name, never spoken aloud outside ritual)
- Muatza (big snapper, her birth-name)
- Eshuna (world-dreamer)

The dolphin-sints who swim the Western Deep between Terpinol and Aranzén sing of Ulumaya, she whose dreams shape tides. Whether this is another name for the same being, or a related figure, or poetic metaphor, even Ma Eshuna will not clarify.

Those who have followed her paths through caverns beneath the

Settan hills name her only in silence.

Presence and Manner

Ma Eshuna is unmistakably sint, non-huum, part tortoise, with a massive dark shell and scaled limbs built for patient endurance rather than speed. She stands perhaps four feet tall when upright. Terpins can move on two legs or four as needed, though she usually moves on all fours, head low, in the ancient terpin way.

She speaks slowly. Each word is chosen with the care of a stonemason selecting precisely the right piece for a wall. Conversations with Ma Eshuna require patience. She will not be rushed, and those who try quickly learn the futility of it. But when she does speak, her voice carries a resonance that seems to come from somewhere deeper than her throat. Gravitas is inadequate to describe it. She sounds like stone speaking, like earth remembering.

Her movements are similarly deliberate. Where younger terpins might amble, she processes. Every gesture means something. When she extends a forelimb to touch someone's hand, it is a benediction. When she withdraws into her shell, rarely, but it happens, it signals that conversation is truly finished.

Her eyes are the darkest black, pools that reflect no light. Looking into them is like looking into deep water. You sense great depth but cannot see the bottom. Some find her gaze comforting. Others find it unsettling. Both reactions are appropriate.

Despite her solemnity, there is fierceness in her that age has not diminished. She does not tolerate bullshit. She will not waste time on those who perpetuate suffering knowingly. And though she avoids arguments, preferring to simply end conversations that are going nowhere, when she does choose to fight, her words cut clean through pretense to bone.

Like a very wise grandmother who has buried many children, watched nations rise and fall, survived wars and famines and betrayals, yet still believes, fiercely, stubbornly, irrationally, that folks can be better than

they are. That they must be.

Origins in Baranuq

Ma Eshuna hatched in the coastal shallows of southern Baranuq, where terpin communities have lived since before hum arrived in the Saskan Lands. The exact location is unrecorded. Terpin birth-sites are private matters. But it was somewhere along the Bay of Bar, where warm currents create ideal conditions for hatchlings.

She grew to maturity when hum migrations were still pushing into southern territories and sints were making choices about how to respond. Many animal-sints retreated southward into the Komikols or withdrew from hum contact entirely. The terpins of Baranuq chose a middle path, maintaining their own communities and practices while engaging selectively with the newcomers.

Young Muatza, as she was then, distinguished herself early as a traveler and questioner. While most terpins stayed close to home waters, she ranged across Baranuq and beyond, learning dialects, languages, rituals, observing how different communities organized themselves, asking why things were the way they were. This restlessness marked her as different.

She spent time in Baranuq's remote religious communities, those ascetic settlements where meditation and martial arts training interweave. She learned forms of life-energy cultivation that would later serve her in hospice work. She also learned something else: how to listen to what the land itself was saying, beneath the noise of hum activity and sint adaptation.

The decision to found the Academy came from this listening. Somewhere in her second century of life, after extensive travels and consultations with elders from multiple communities, Ma Eshuna concluded that knowledge was fragmenting dangerously. The Dominion was consolidating information for political control. The Night Hall, while admirable, was becoming bureaucratic and coiling in on itself. What was needed was a place where knowledge could grow freely, where different ways of knowing could pollinate each

other freely.

She chose the remote fishing village that would become Terpinol for several reasons. Its isolation from major powers. Its access to sea routes (terpins are natural sailors, though they rarely advertise this). Its ability to serve as a crossroads between Settan agricultural lands, Aranzen's mysteries, and the Komikol wildness. A place at the edges, where new things could emerge.

The Academy began modestly, only a few buildings and a handful of committed scholars. That it grew into an architectural marvel and intellectual powerhouse is testament to Ma Eshuna's vision and patience. Terpins think in long timescales. Three centuries is sufficient to build something properly.

Bridges and Burdens

The Rabbit Work - finished but complicated

For over two centuries, Ma Eshuna dedicated enormous energy to bridging divides among rabbit-sint communities. Rabbits reproduce quickly, live very briefly by terpin standards, and fracture into factions with dizzying speed. Their passion for justice combined with their short lives creates radical movements that burn bright and fast, often consuming themselves before achieving lasting change.

Ma Eshuna approached this as a patient gardener approaches brambles. She organized workshops. Facilitated dialogues between feuding factions. Highlighted the terpin model of slow, sustained cooperation. Encouraged skill-building over rhetoric. Sought alliances with influential individuals across multiple communities.

The work yielded progress. Many rabbit-sints did shift toward longer-term thinking, toward building rather than merely resisting. But then came the Untamed, more militant, more uncompromising, more willing to use violence for liberation. They overshadowed her cooperativist approach almost overnight.

Ma Eshuna's feelings about the Untamed are complex and private. Publicly, she acknowledges their achievements and the genuine

suffering that drives them. Privately, in journals never meant for others' eyes, she grieves. Not because the Untamed are wrong, but because she wonders if her own earlier interventions consisting of a word here, an introduction there, encouragement given to a young rabbit storyteller somehow planted seeds that grew into something she never intended.

"I thought it would become a tree. It became a storm."

These days, when asked about her work with rabbit-sints, Ma Eshuna simply says: "I did what I could. Others continue the work in their own ways." She does not attend Untamed gatherings. She does not denounce them either. She is simply... done with that chapter.

The Academy

The Academy is Ma Eshuna's most visible legacy. From a handful of buildings to an institution that outshines the Night Hall. From a local curiosity to a place where scholars from across the known world gather. From a terpin project to a truly multicultural, multi-species center of learning.

She rarely teaches formal classes anymore. Her main work now is reading, comparing, writing, synthesizing knowledge, drawing connections, preserving understanding for future generations. She maintains the archives, particularly the sections dealing with pre-Arrival history and the mysterious period when Monmar descended from wherever it is she came from.

But she worries. The Academy's success has made it influential. Influential institutions attract manipulation. Already she sees political maneuvering at the edges. She sees Dominion scholars who seem more interested in gathering intelligence than pursuing truth, Empafarasi strategists who treat knowledge as weaponry in some cosmic battle, and merchants who want to monetize learning.

The Academy's neutrality must be fiercely protected. But Ma Eshuna grows tired. How much longer can she guard these gates? Who will hold this center when she is gone?

Her Quiet Service

As a member of the Dauni Vakasaqua order and a Dessani Mider, Ma Eshuna serves as hospice attendant and burial worker. This is the only work that regularly draws her away from Terpinol, when word comes that someone far away is dying and has requested her presence.

She can generate mild healing energies through life-cultivation techniques. Not enough to cure, but enough to ease pain, to bring clarity in final hours, to help the dying release gracefully. This ability is weakening as she ages, but she still offers what she can.

Her presence at a deathbed is considered a great honor. She has attended the passing of revolutionaries and merchants, scholars and farmers, huum and sint alike, and ordinary cultivars who nobody has ever heard of. She asks no payment. She offers no platitudes. She simply sits with the dying, sometimes for days, offering the gift of witnessed passing.

Afterward, she helps with burial rites according to whatever tradition the deceased followed. She has learned funeral customs from a dozen cultures. Death, she believes, is where all masks fall away, where the pretenses that separate communities dissolve into simple truth. At the end, everyone is just breath returning to air, flesh returning to earth.

This work sustains her more than anything else. In the presence of death, questions about legacy and success become irrelevant. There is only the immediate, the real, the unavoidable. It is the most honest work she knows.

Under the Tree

Most days, Ma Eshuna does not appear in public spaces. She lives in the deep vaults beneath the Academy, in chambers that stay cool in summer and mild in winter, where humidity can be controlled to protect ancient texts and her own aging body.

She rises late, moves through simple routines, then settles into reading. Her current project, ongoing for decades, is creating a comprehensive comparison of different communities' origin stories, looking for patterns that might reveal something about the world before Arrival. She works slowly, cross-referencing, noting

contradictions, drawing no conclusions she cannot support.

Occasionally, she emerges into one of the quieter Academy courtyards, moving toward a particular acacia tree that offers good shade. There she sits, sometimes alone, sometimes with one or two other ancients or close companions. Perhaps Waleran when he visits. Perhaps B'arqo the chronicler, who never fails to amuse her. Perhaps another old terpin who remembers when the world was different.

They share silence as much as speech. Sometimes one will mention a memory, not to tell a story, but just to acknowledge it aloud. "Do you remember when the canal was completed?" "The feast at Kurosol that year after the famine lifted." "The first time we realized that the Mobali engineer was right, that the pollinators could return." The other might nod. Or not. The remembering itself is the point.

Young scholars sometimes gather nearby, hoping to overhear wisdom. Usually they're disappointed. The conversations are fragmentary, allusive, meaningless without decades of context. Occasionally, though, Ma Eshuna will notice them and gesture one closer. "You. You're studying water management? Sit. Listen."

What follows is rarely a lecture. More often it's a series of questions that turn the student's assumptions inside-out, followed by a suggestion to consult some obscure text in the archives, followed by dismissal. The student leaves confused, works through the questions for weeks, eventually has a breakthrough, and only then realizes they've been taught something profound.

This is how Ma Eshuna prefers to work now, indirectly, sparingly, only when the moment is right.

Relationships and Reputation

Among Terpins, Ma Eshuna is revered but not worshipped. Terpin culture resists personality cults. She is acknowledged as one of their greatest visionaries, but also as someone who made choices other terpins did not make. She engaged with hum when withdrawal might have been wiser, founding institutions that attract attention when

obscurity is safer.

Some younger terpins find her exhausting. Her questions, her refusal to give straight answers, her sadness that permeates everything. Others find her presence comforting, like bedrock beneath uncertain ground.

Among scholars and intellectuals, Ma Eshuna is legendary. To be taught by her, even briefly, is credential enough. Her writings, at least those she permits to circulate, are studied across the Lands. Her methodologies, the careful cross-referencing, suspension of judgment, attention to what sources don't say as much as what they do, have become standard in serious scholarship.

But she is also intimidating. Many scholars aspire to meet her, few actually seek her out. The prospect of having one's assumptions dismantled by someone who has lived through centuries you're only reading about is daunting.

Among political and military leaders, to the surprise of some, Ma Eshuna is respected as a neutral broker. When Empafarasi Tables need to negotiate with Dominion interests, Terpinol and by extension, Ma Eshuna's implicit blessing, makes it possible. When Kahila bands need medical knowledge without compromising their independence, they send emissaries to Scatterling where Ma Eshuna's network operates.

She holds no official political power. She commands no forces. But her word carries weight. Refusing to host someone at the Academy is effectively declaring them unworthy of neutral ground. This has happened exactly three times in three centuries. Each time, it was taken seriously.

Among common folk, in villages throughout the Settan Lands, Ma Eshuna appears in stories as an almost mythical figure. "Old as stone," "wise as water," "patient as earth". These phrases recur. Parents tell children: "Ma Eshuna sees everything; be truthful." Healers invoke her name when working with difficult cases. Travelers mention her when explaining why they're journeying to Terpinol.

Most common folk will never meet her. But knowing that she exists,

that she is definitely not a myth, knowing the Academy she founded is there; it matters. It suggests that beneath all the chaos and conflict, someone is paying attention, remembering, holding knowledge safe for future generations.

Mysteries That Remain

Even by terpin standards, Ma Eshuna is implausibly old. Terpins live long lives. Two centuries is not uncommon. Three is rare but not unheard of. But Ma Eshuna is well past three centuries and showing no signs of imminent decline. She moves slowly, yes. Her healing abilities weaken, yes. But she endures.

There is no secret elixir. No magical intervention. When asked, even other ancient terpins simply say: "It is as if the planet needs her around."

Ma Eshuna herself offers no explanation. When directly questioned, she says: "I'll die when it's time. Until then, there's work to do."

The Green Room, deep beneath the Academy, is Ma Eshuna's most private domain. What happens there, what it contains, who has access, these questions go unanswered. It is known to be a bio-symbiotic archive where memories are preserved in root-networks, where songs are sung through vibration rather than voice. It is also known to be the place where Ma Eshuna grieves. The songs she sings there, private elegies for choices made, paths not taken, seeds that became storms, are heard by no one. They are sung for roots and stones and darkness. They are her truest prayers.

Some nights, those sleeping in the Academy's upper levels swear they hear something, not quite sound, more like resonance. As if the building itself is humming. In the morning, Ma Eshuna will emerge looking even more tired than usual, and no one will ask.

Ma Eshuna is one of the few living beings who remembers Monmar's arrival. She understands, though she rarely says it aloud, that the Mother of Fires "came down" from somewhere, that she is not native to this world. What she knows about where Monmar came from, what

she is doing, what her connection might be to the Moons or to the planetary awakening that seems to be beginning, she does not share. When pressed, she says only: "Monmar made her choices. We make ours. Whether they connect is not for me to say."

It is suspected that she met with Monmar at least once in the Green Room, perhaps more. There are no records. Ma Eshuna will neither confirm nor deny.

Some scholars have theorized that Ma Eshuna serves as a kind of antenna or resonator for the planet's nascent awakening. That her longevity is connected to some function she performs, consciously or unconsciously, in the planet's development toward self-awareness. Ma Eshuna finds this theory both amusing and irritating. "You'd think being the planet's tool would come with clearer instructions," she's said. But she doesn't entirely dismiss it either.

How to Encounter Her

Ma Eshuna rarely grants formal audiences. Those who wish to meet her should:

- 1 Come to the Academy with genuine purpose. She has no patience for curiosity-seekers or those collecting famous encounters like trophies.
- 2 Be prepared to wait. She will not adjust her schedule for visitors. If she's reading, she finishes. If she's in the Green Room, she stays there. Time means something different when you've lived centuries.
- 3 Ask real questions. Don't waste her time with things you could learn from books or by simply observing the world carefully.
- 4 Accept that no might be the answer. She may simply look at you, say "Not yet," and return to her reading. This doesn't mean never. It means she's decided you're not ready for the conversation you're trying to have.
- 5 Bring offerings to the land, not to her. If you want to honor Ma

Eshuna, plant something. Clean a neglected section of coastline. Teach someone to read. She has no interest in personal gifts, but acts of service to the world itself please her.

For most visitors, the closest they'll come is glimpsing her from a distance. A dark shape moving slowly through a courtyard at dawn, or sitting motionless beneath the acacia tree at dusk. This is often enough. Just knowing she's there, still keeping watch, still holding memory, still believing despite everything that the work matters. That is its own teaching.

Vastness and Horizon

Stand anywhere in Baranuq and you can see the sky.

Not just glimpses between buildings or through tree-canopy. The entire dome of heaven spreads above you, uninterrupted from edge to edge. The land rolls gently, endlessly, in waves of grassland, grain fields, and steppe that stretch from the Settarune province in the north down to the Komikols in the south, and from the Bay of Bar in the east all the way to the fuzzy border with Terpinol in the west. Distance becomes difficult to judge. That settlement on the horizon might be a day's walk or three. The weather coming toward you might arrive in an hour or miss you entirely, sliding past on winds that blow unimpeded across hundreds of kilometers.

Baranuq is the southernmost of the Settan provinces. It has more land than any other Settan province, but only one major town. Baranuq is defined not by what's built upon it but by what grows from it and what moves across it.

The population disperses across thousands of small bands, clans, villages, and communal farms. From above, as if any creature could see from such height, the province would look nearly empty, just scattered marks of habitation in an ocean of agricultural land. From the ground, though, walking the ancient paths that connect settlement

to settlement, you find sentient folks everywhere. Just not concentrated. Not crowded. Not piled atop each other in the way northern towns demand.

This is terpin country, the turtle-sints. This is where they came from, where many still live, where their influence shaped everything that followed. Even the hum who settled here centuries ago learned to move at terpin pace, to think in terpin timescales, to value the terpin way: slow, steady, communal, patient.

Baranuq is the grain-heart of the Saskan Lands. It is the place where revolutionary social organization actually worked. It is home to some of the most beautiful art and most dangerous materials in the known world. It is peaceful until it isn't. Simple until you look closer. Empty until you learn to see.

It is where Ma Eshuna was hatched, and her presence—even in absence—still shapes everything.

Plains, Coast, and Hidden Waters

Most of Baranuq is rolling steppe and agricultural plain. The western sections are arid, almost desert-like bare earth and scrub, punctuated by oases where underground water sources reach the surface. Moving east towards Kurosol, the province's only fortified town, the land becomes increasingly fertile, supporting extensive grain cultivation.

The soil varies from sandy western reaches to rich dark earth in the east. Seasonal flooding from scattered watercourses enriches certain areas. The province grows most of its own food and exports grain to Settarune and beyond, making it essential to the Saskan Lands' food security.

Baranuq has an extensive coastline along the Bay of Bar, though this is not heavily populated by hum standards. Terpin communities dominate the shore. Small settlements, often partially underwater, where terpins live in ways that blend land and sea. They fish, gather shellfish, maintain boats and diving equipment, and serve as the province's primary connection to maritime trade with the Komikols.

The coast is warmer than inland areas, with humid air that feels foreign to those accustomed to dry steppe winds. Unusual plants grow here like salt-tolerant species, kelp forests offshore, strange fungi that thrive where land meets water. Healers come from across the Lands seeking coastal specimens for medicinal use.

In the western sections, lakes and wells produce something unexpected: combustible liquids and tar-like substances. These pools of thick, dark material bubble up from underground sources. They smell strange. Acrid, earthy, powerful. When ignited, they burn intensely.

There is little advanced understanding of these materials. Baranuq folk use them primarily for torches, lamps, and certain types of heat-treating. But the potential and the danger are recognized. Trade in these substances is kept extremely quiet. Small amounts are exported to the Komikols and Kahila Lands. More goes to Terpinol's concealed manufactories. There is fear that if the Dominion were to learn the full extent of how much of the stuff exists here, interest in it could become coercion.

Wells producing these materials are carefully managed, their locations known to clan leaders but not widely discussed. Accidents happen. Fires that burn for days, toxic fumes, contaminated water. Those who work with the substances develop a healthy respect bordering on fear.

Extremes and Endurance

Baranuq is given to weather extremes that make life challenging for the unprepared.

In Summer Heat, temperatures soar. Fatune beats down without mercy. Those working in fields do so at dawn and dusk, resting through midday. Water sources become precious. Heat waves can kill livestock and people alike. Travelers who don't understand the climate sometimes die on roads between settlements.

Underground dwellings provide refuge. The earth maintains cooler temperatures even when surface air becomes unbreathable. This is

why so many Baranuq settlements are dug into the ground. It is not about secrecy, though that's useful, but simple survival.

The same land that bakes in summer freezes in winter. Snow is rare, but brutal freezing winds cut across open plains. Without natural windbreaks, storms hit with full force. Settlements shelter in their earthworks, burning dried dung and combustible materials for heat, waiting out the worst of it.

The transitional seasons are Baranuq's glory. Moderate temperatures, regular rainfall, gentle winds. The land explodes with growth in the Spring. Wildflowers carpet the steppes, grain fields green impossibly fast, migratory lizards pass through in enormous flocks. Autumn is equally glorious, in a different way. These seasons are when the biggest festivals happen, when travel is easiest, when clans gather for marriages and celebrations.

Baranuq weather can turn violent without warning. Clear sky becomes black with storm clouds in minutes. Lightning strikes dry grass, starting fires that sweep across dozens of kilometers. Dust storms reduce visibility to arm's length. Travelers learn to read the sky, to sense pressure changes, to know when to shelter immediately rather than continuing toward the next settlement.

Those who grow up here develop intuition for weather that seems almost supernatural. They'll stop mid-conversation, look at the horizon, and say "Storm coming. Three hours." They're usually right.

The Hidden Architecture

When travelers first enter Baranuq from the Ring Road, they're often confused. Where are the villages? Where do people live?

The landscape appears nearly empty. Rolling hills, grass, grain fields, the occasional tree line marking water. They might pass within a hundred meters of a settlement housing two hundred people and never notice.

Most Baranuq settlements are dug into the earth. Not caves, these are

purpose-built underground structures with:

- Multiple levels descending fifteen, twenty meters or more
- Central courtyards open to sky, providing light and air
- Rooms branching from central spaces in organic patterns
- Ventilation shafts disguised as small hillocks
- Storage chambers maintaining constant cool temperatures
- Meeting halls large enough for gatherings
- Living spaces comfortable and surprisingly spacious

From above, these settlements look like gentle mounds, small rolling hills barely distinguishable from natural landscape. Doors are unobtrusive. Windows are small or cleverly concealed. The only obvious signs are cultivated areas nearby, smoke from cooking fires, and paths worn by regular use.

This architecture serves multiple purposes.

- Climate control: Earth insulation against heat and cold
- Defense: Underground settlements are extremely difficult to attack
- Aesthetics: Baranuq folk prefer not to impose on the landscape
- Spiritual practice: Living close to earth feels right, feels connected

Visitors find the underground spaces surprisingly pleasant. They are cool in summer, warm in winter, quiet, with earthen walls decorated in beautiful patterns. Natural light filters through cleverly designed shafts. Air stays fresh through ventilation systems that are part engineering, part mystery.

Some buildings do stand above ground.

- Windmills for grinding grain. These are much simpler than Scatterling's elaborate network.
- Storage barns for hay and materials that need air circulation
- Temporary shelters for warm-season activities
- Meditation pavilions at remote sites
- Watchtowers are rare, but exist, mostly along the southern

border

These surface structures are usually light construction. They tend to be movable, changeable, not intended to last centuries. The permanent work happens underground.

Communism That Functions

Baranuq society is the most successful example of voluntary collectivism in the Saskan Lands. Understanding how it works and why it works here when it fails elsewhere is crucial to understanding the province.

Virtually everything in Baranuq is held in common.

- All land belongs to all inhabitants collectively. The idea of individual land ownership does not exist.
- Grain, seeds, water, fertilizer and combustible materials are also communal
- Tools and equipment are shared
- Storage facilities are accessible to all
- Even personal items are often held loosely. Borrowing is normal

This isn't enforced by authority. It's simply how things are done. When someone needs grain, they take what they need from communal stores. When harvest comes, they contribute their labor. The system works through social trust and the practical recognition that everyone's survival depends on everyone else.

While property is communal, specific groups take stewardship of specific tasks.

- One team manages the grain fields
- Another tends the water sources
- A third oversees the fertilizer
- Bands rotate responsibility for maintaining the paths and roads

Stewardship isn't ownership. It's more like temporary responsibility. Disputes are rare because resources are abundant enough that scarcity doesn't drive conflict. When disputes do arise, they're resolved through appeal to religious community leaders whose judgment is trusted.

Baranuq society resists hierarchy.

- No chief or governor coordinates the province, which would be an absurd undertaking at any rate
- Decisions emerge through consensus and consultation
- Religious communities are egalitarian, with no gender or species distinctions
- Age brings respect but not authority
- Skill brings admiration but not power

This can frustrate outsiders trying to negotiate with "Baranuq". As with most of the Settan Lands, there's no single voice speaking for the province. In the case of Baranuq, there are thousands of small communities each operating independently while staying coordinated through methods that are deeply entrenched cultural practice.

Why It Works

- 1 Abundance: The land produces enough that scarcity doesn't drive competition
- 2 Cultural conditioning: Generations have internalized communal values
- 3 Fluid membership: People can move between communities, reducing pressure
- 4 Religious reinforcement: Spiritual practices support egalitarian principles
- 5 External threat: Komikol raids remind everyone that cooperation means survival
- 6 Terpin influence: The slow, patient, communal terpin way pervades everything

It's not utopia. Tensions do exist. The work is hard. Jealousies arise and some accumulate slightly more than others. But the system bends

without breaking because it's flexible, because it's embedded in spiritual practice, and because everyone alive has seen it work.

The Religious Communities

Deep in remote countryside, far from even the hidden settlements, ascetic communities practice the spiritual traditions that give Baranuq its character. While similar in some ways to the river cults of Settarune and elsewhere, the Baranuq spiritual traditions have some unique characteristics.

Ketabis are small, intensely focused communities of perhaps twenty to fifty practitioners living in even more minimal conditions than regular settlements.

They spend enormous amounts of time in...

- Various forms of meditation like sitting, walking, slow-working
- Martial arts training, both unarmed and weapons-based
- Calligraphic practice
- Study of philosophical texts
- Ritual performances and chanting
- Life-energy cultivation

The beauty of Baranuq's religious system is its porosity. Membership is fluid, not at all hierarchical.

- Young people spend time in ketabis as part of education
- Adults return periodically for intensive practice
- Elders might retire to retreats permanently
- Anyone can join temporarily regardless of origin

There's no barrier to entry, no hierarchical initiation. You show up, express genuine intent, and you're included. You can leave whenever you choose. Many Baranuq folk move back and forth throughout their lives. Six months in their village, three months in a ketabi, back to village, back to a ketabi.

This prevents religious communities from becoming disconnected from practical life. Practitioners maintain ties to families, to farms, to daily realities. Their spiritual insights inform ordinary existence rather than escaping from it.

Many of the oldest and most respected spiritual practitioners are terpins from the southern coastal communities. Their presence links current practice to centuries of tradition. These ancients teach primarily through example. They move through forms with perfect patience, sitting still in meditation for days, offering brief comments that crack open understanding.

Some of these terpins are extraordinarily old.

The practices include work on discourse and negotiation. There is intensive ritualized training in communication, in finding common ground, in de-escalating conflict. This is one reason why Baranuq folk are famously difficult to provoke into fighting. They've trained extensively in alternatives.

Other popular rituals include...

A harmony dance in which participants move together in rhythmic patterns, expressing unity through motion. This can involve dozens or even hundreds of folk, all moving in synchronized flow without verbal coordination.

The blessing of the fields is performed at planting season, invoking harmony with earth and abundance in harvest. It typically involves music, offerings of water and grain, and collective singing that continues sometimes for hours.

Contemplation of Fatune's rest: at day's end, many Baranuq folk pause wherever they are to watch Fatune descend behind the western horizon. A moment of gratitude, of recognition, of connection to cycles larger than human life.

Beauty as Practice

Baranuq produces some of the most exquisite artwork in the Saskan

Lands, yet art here is never separate from ordinary life.

Baranuq calligraphy is legendary. Every educated person practices it. The flowing script rendered in ink on special paper imported from Settarune and sometimes the Runes of Bye approaches meditation in execution. Each stroke requires breath control, mental focus, and physical precision. Calligraphic works hang in underground chambers, are given as gifts, serve as meditation objects. Master calligraphers spend decades perfecting single characters. Their work commands high prices at Kurosol's markets, but they produce it primarily for its own sake, as spiritual practice made visible.

Weaving and fiber arts flourish here, as they do in Settarune and parts of Kahilabequa. Not the technical sophistication of Scatterling's tailors, but rather work emphasizing natural materials, organic dyes, and patterns that reflect landscape:

- Blankets striped like distant horizons
- Clothing that drapes like grass in wind
- Tapestries depicting migrations of lizards
- Rugs whose patterns encode stories

The clay in Baranuq is excellent. Baranuq pottery is prized for its simplicity: clean lines, natural glazes in earth tones, forms that feel inevitable. Each piece is functional yet beautiful, designed to be used daily rather than displayed.

Painting and drawing are mostly done in ink and these works tend toward landscape. How could they not, given the endless horizons? Studies of motion are common themes as well: grass bending, water flowing, creatures moving. Baranuq artists capture movement better than anyone, as if their patience allows them to see what others miss.

Woodcarving is limited by scarcity of trees, but when available wood is carved with extraordinary skill. Small sculptures, walking sticks, tool handles each becomes an opportunity for artistry. Bone and root are also used.

All Baranuq art shares certain qualities, including...

- Connection to nature

- Emphasis on simplicity and clarity
- Patience in execution
- Beauty emerging from function
- Spiritual dimension even in mundane objects

Art is not separate from life here. It's how life is lived.

Feeding the Lands

Baranuq is the bread-basket of Saskantion. Understanding this is understanding Baranuq's importance. The province produces far and away more grain than anywhere else, including vast fields of:

- Wheat and barley, especially in the eastern regions
- Various grasses cultivated mainly for for seeds
- Root vegetables, which are stored underground for winter
- Mountains of herbs, mushrooms, and fungi, some with medicinal/psychoactive properties

Baranuq also has a salt industry.

This isn't industrial monoculture. Fields are small to medium, managed by different clans, rotated seasonally, intercropped intelligently. But there are thousands of them, and cumulatively, they feed not just Baranuq but much of the southern Lands and beyond.

Since the catastrophe that reduced insect and bird populations, Baranuq maintains enormous numbers of people devoted to hand-pollination. This is everyone's work during flowering season. Specialists train others, but essentially the entire population participates. It's mind-bogglingly labor-intensive. Yet they do it, every year, patiently transferring pollen from flower to flower, ensuring seed production. This is why Baranuq can feed others. They're willing to do work on a scale that elsewhere would be considered impossible.

Baranuq farmers are conservative in some ways, shying away from

dangerous technologies, but innovative in others:

- Sophisticated understanding of soil health
- Water management through subtle terracing
- Companion planting based on centuries of observation
- Seed selection and improvement
- Natural pest management
- Integration of livestock, for those who keep animals

This knowledge spreads to other regions through the Academy, through traveling consultants, through Dauni Vakasaqua and other healers and teachers who learn here. Baranuq agricultural practice quietly shapes food production across the Lands.

Trade and Economics

Despite being remote and decentralized, Baranuq is deeply integrated into Saskan economic networks, especially via grain export. Their surplus grain goes to...

- Settarune in exchange for fruits, vegetables, manufactured goods
- The other southern provinces
- Sometimes as far as Eelan, the Rider Provinces, the Outer Lands and even the Dominion during shortages
- Emergency reserves for famine relief

Trade is managed through Kurosol, the only town with infrastructure for large-scale transactions.

Beyond grain, Baranuq produces and exports:

- Herbs, mushrooms, roots for medicine and s'lah production
- Dyes and paints derived from local plants and minerals
- Crystals, both decorative and for healing arts
- Artwork and home goods -- calligraphy, textiles, pottery
- Combustible materials very quietly, only to select customers
- Salt

- Skilled stonemasons and jewellers who travel to work elsewhere
- Martial arts and meditation teachers
- Agricultural consultants

It would be fair to say that Baranuq is communist internally but mercantilist externally. Within the province, everything is shared. In dealings with outsiders, goods are traded for value. This doesn't create cognitive dissonance. It's simply recognizing that other places work differently, and when interacting with them, you adapt. Profits are shared. Grain storage and export are managed communally. Profits from external trade return to the province as communal wealth to fund improvements, acquire tools and materials, and support those who cannot work.

The Jewelled Exception

In the middle of vast, simple, understated Baranuq sits Kurosol—a town so ornate, so decorated, so impossibly elaborate that first-time visitors literally stop and stare.

The contrast is intentional. Kurosol is Baranuq's face to the world. Its market, its gateway, its expression of all the beauty and skill and craft that usually stays modest and hidden. While Baranuq itself is content to be unnoticed, Kurosol ensures that those who come seeking trade, seeking connection, seeking goods and knowledge, find something unforgettable.

Kurosol is also where non-residents must conduct business. Making deals anywhere else in Baranuq is nearly impossible; the communal system doesn't translate easily. But in Kurosol, those responsible for managing external trade maintain offices, warehouses, and the infrastructure needed for large-scale exchange.

Dangers and Defense

Baranuq's peaceful nature is real but shouldn't be mistaken for

weakness. When hunger stalks the Komikols to the south, raiders come north. Wolf packs and other animal-sint groups, desperate and fierce, cross borders seeking grain and livestock. These raids can be brutal.

Baranuq's responses include...

- Underground settlements are extremely defensible
- Trained fighters emerge from religious communities
- Guerrilla tactics learned from defending against Dominion genocides
- Alliances with Terpinol, Byenung, Eelan and High Weir provide backup

Baranuq folk prefer not to fight. But when forced, they're devastatingly effective. Patient, strategic, willing to retreat and regroup, and utterly fierce when defending their land. When the Dominion waged genocidal war against southern sints, Baranuq and Arq were the most affected. Descendants carry genetic memory of the trauma, a forged layer of martial awareness lurking beneath the peaceful surface. Neither is the religious communities' martial training an abstract concept. It's preparation for the possibility that violence might become necessary again.

Homeland

Understanding that Ma Eshuna was hatched here, that this is where she formed before leaving to found Terpinol, helps explain both her character and Baranuq's distinctiveness.

Her patience is very Baranuq. Her egalitarian instincts, pure Baranuq. Her comfort with both hum and sint was learned here. Her commitment to practical solutions and long-term thinking is the Baranuq way. Her artistic sensibility, her spiritual depth, her willingness to work underground, literally and figuratively, all reflect this place.

And her sadness. The Baranuq sadness that comes from seeing beauty

and simplicity constantly threatened by outside forces and natural disasters. From knowing that peace requires eternal vigilance. From watching the world fragment while holding together one corner of it through sheer stubborn patience.

Baranuq shaped Ma Eshuna, and through her, shaped Terpinol. This province's influence extends far beyond grain exports. Its vision of how people might live together simply, communally, beautifully offers an alternative to hierarchy and violence that most of the world desperately needs and few achieve.

First Sight

After three hundred kilometers of rolling steppe and hidden settlements, after days of seeing nothing but grass and sky and the occasional earthen mound, after beginning to wonder if you took a wrong turn somewhere on the lonely southern road—

You crest a final rise and there it is.

Kurosol.

The walls hit you first. Ancient fortifications that should have crumbled centuries ago but instead stand impossibly maintained, covered—absolutely covered—in an astonishing array of carved statuary, friezes, ornamental embellishments. Every surface is worked. Every stone tells a story. Polished gems catch sunlight and throw it back in colors that shouldn't exist in this dry land. Fresh paint gleams in patterns so intricate you cannot process them all at once.

And beyond the walls, the town itself, lit even in daylight by the distinctive glow of combustible materials burning in elaborate lamp-systems. Structures rise that are not tall by northern standards, but present, visible, decorated. The town sprawls along the coast where the Bay of Bar curves gently, offering one of the few natural harbors

in southern Baranuq.

Ships rest at anchor. Not that many. Kurosol's harbor is modest compared to Byenung or the Ny Lands ports. But enough to show active maritime trade. Terpin vessels, broad and low in the water, designed for patient voyages. Smaller craft from East Komikol, strange-looking to Saskan eyes. Occasionally, something from Arq or the Ny Lands.

The contrast is overwhelming. All across Baranuq one finds simplicity, understatement, modesty, settlements that hide in earth, and then here: KURO SOL. Blazing. Ornate. Impossible to miss. The single concentrated expression of all Baranuq's suppressed beauty and skill and accumulated wealth. It is as if the entire province decided to be invisible everywhere except this one place. And here, we will be unforgettable.

The Ancient Heart

Kurosol is old. Far older than Terpinol. Older than most settlements in the Saskan Lands.

Before hum arrived, this was a terpin port, the center of terpin maritime culture. The harbor existed long before walls were built. Terpins came here for centuries, gathering at the intersection of land and sea, launching voyages to distant shores, returning with knowledge and goods from places most land-dwellers never imagined.

The town grew slowly, in the terpin fashion. Each generation added slightly. Centuries accumulated into structures. The harbor expanded. The settlement deepened, both literally with underground chambers and figuratively with layers of meaning, history compressed into stone.

When hum migrations began arriving in the Saskan Lands, pushing southward, many sints retreated or withdrew. But Kurosol's terpins chose engagement. They allowed hum settlement nearby. They incorporated newcomers into trade networks. They shared knowledge.

Selectively, carefully, but genuinely.

Over centuries, Kurosol became a synthesis. Terpin foundation with huum contributions, both species building together. The underground architecture is ancient terpin work. The surface ornamentation reflects some of the best of huum aesthetics. The maritime culture remains fundamentally terpin, but huum sailors learned to crew terpin vessels, and terpin navigational methods began incorporating huum innovations.

Ma Eshuna herself was hatched somewhere in these southern coastal waters. She would have known Kurosol from earliest memory. The town shaped her before she left to found Terpinol. When you walk Kurosol's decorated streets, you're walking through the world that formed the mind that created the Academy.

Geography and Setting

Kurosol sits on the Bay of Bar's western shore, where the coastline curves to create natural protection from storms. The harbor is modest but well-positioned. It is deep enough for large vessels, sheltered enough to be reliable, accessible enough from inland Baranuq to serve as trade nexus.

It is the only significant harbor on Baranuq's southern coast, with protected anchorage for maritime vessels, providing a connection point between Baranuq's agricultural interior and sea routes.

Kurosol is very remote, three hundred kilometers from the Ring Road and exposed to raids from Komikol across the bay. The town has limited access to fresh water, which must be carefully managed and is vulnerable to storms. The bay itself is strange. Waters shift from blue to green to almost purple depending on time of day and season. Locals attribute this to unique algae and mineral content. Scholars from Terpinol study it. Fishermen simply accept it as one of the bay's mysteries.

Marine life is abundant and varied. Some species found nowhere else. Unusual crustaceans with shells used in jewellery. Kelp forests

offshore that terpin divers harvest for various uses. Occasionally, something surfaces that defies easy categorization: creatures that combine features of multiple species, as if the bay breeds its own experiments.

The Walls

The fortifications surrounding Kurosol were originally built by the Fatunik Dominion centuries ago, during their attempted southern expansion. Meant to be outpost against Komikol incursions, garrison town watching the border.

That practical origin has been completely transformed. Every surface of the walls—every single stone—has been carved, embellished, decorated. Generations of artisans have worked these fortifications until they became the greatest continuous artwork in the Saskan Lands. There are historical friezes depicting migrations, harvest, storms and celebrations. Statuary of figures emerges from the walls, of terpins, hum, sints of all kinds, often in poses suggesting motion, dance or work. The interlocking geometric designs create optical effects that seem to shift as you walk past and there are polished stones and crystals set into carvings, catching the light and creating a shimmering glow that reflects the constantly renewed dyes and paints in reds, blues, yellows, greens.

Walking around Kurosol's walls is a days-long journey if you actually stop to look at everything. Most visitors don't make it halfway before sensory overload sets in. It's simply too much. Too beautiful, too detailed, too overwhelming.

The walls serve their original defensive function still. But they've become so much more: a gallery, a chronicle, an object of meditation. A proclamation: We are here. We create beauty. We remember everything. We are not simple just because we prefer simplicity.

Light, Mobile, Living

Inside the walls, Kurosol's architecture contrasts dramatically with the permanence of fortifications. Most buildings are lightweight, movable and changeable. There are frames of treated wood or metal with walls of fabric, reed screens and thin wooden panels. Roofs are designed to provide maximum shade and connect with courtyards and breezeways channeling air currents. Colors are bright and decorative details are everywhere.

The town breathes, adapts, and changes with seasons and needs. Summer configurations emphasize airflow. Winter setups capture warmth. Festival times see buildings rearranged to create performance spaces. Market days reconfigure into maximum vendor accommodation. And like all Baranuq settlements, significant portions of Kurosol extend underground. Storage vaults for grain and trade goods. Workshops for crafts requiring stable temperatures. Living quarters for keeping cool. Meeting halls and gathering spaces. Water cisterns and water management systems. And in the oldest parts of town, ancient terpin dwellings. Underground areas tend to be less decorated than on the surface but still show artistry with carved pillars, painted ceilings, and floors laid in intricate patterns. These spaces feel timeless, cool, quiet, a refuge from the busy surface world.

The Harbor

Kurosol's harbor was the town's original reason for existence and is still a key connection to wider world. The piers extend into deep water and are very durable. Warehouses along the waterfront store goods for trans-shipment. Shipyards keep the fleets in good repair and the offices of the navigation teams coordinate arrivals, departures and routing. There is something like a customs facility to deal with foreign goods and imports, and of course there are inns and other facilities for sailors of all cultures, languages and species.

The harbor exports grain to the Komikols, imports seafood and other maritime resources from the Komikols when relationships are good. Unusual materials also arrive from distant lands and there is a brisk trade in knowledge, maps and navigational information. Crafted good from Baranuq flow out, with foreign crafts flowing in. Seeds, plants

and agricultural knowledge are also valuable commodities flowing through the port. The harbor operates continuously. Ships arrive and depart with tides and wind. Loading and unloading happens day and night. The waterfront never truly sleeps.

Permanent Carnival

Unlike most Saskan towns where markets are periodic events, Kurosol's market runs constantly, night and day, all year, in multiple venues throughout the town. This includes: grain food, combustible materials and tools, textiles and clothing, artworks and home goods, crystals and minerals, various maritime goods, tools and equipment, every type of s'lah imaginable, books, maps, seeds, cuttings, and occasionally unusual creatures. It is a bit like a carnival that never ends. Music from multiple cultures playing simultaneously. Cooking smells layering grain bread baking, fish grilling, mysterious spices. Languages mix: Sogomsh dialects, Eibar languages, sint communications, foreign tongues.

Terpin merchants move slowly through crowds, carrying goods on their broad backs. Huum vendors callout prices. Rabbit-sints run between stalls, delivering messages and packages. Occasional visitors from Komikol or beyond are easily identifiable by clothing, appearance and manner.

At night, the combustible lamps create extraordinary light. Not harsh like northern waxy lamps, but warm, golden, dancing. Shadows play across decorated surfaces. The market takes on dreamlike quality.

Kurosol is where non-residents must come to conduct business with Baranuq. The province's communal system doesn't translate to individual transactions elsewhere. But here, those responsible for managing external trade maintain connections with manufacturers, growers, village coordinators, maritime specialists and terpin elders. Negotiation is patient. Nothing happens quickly. A deal requiring ten minutes elsewhere might take three days here. But once made, agreements hold. Baranuq's word is trusted across the Lands.

Fire and Shadow

Kurosol's most distinctive feature, beyond the walls, is how it uses combustible materials for illumination. Throughout the town, elaborate systems distribute and control flame. Underground pipes feed the system and above-ground channels run in protective housing. There are lamp posts at regular intervals throughout the town, as well as building-mounted fixtures. Control valves manage flow and intensity.

The lamps create art along with providing light. Flames dance in designed patterns and colored glass creates kaleidoscope effects. Shapes are projected in shadow as the light and dark interplay in a choreographed fashion. Some areas glow constantly; others only at night. The overall effect is otherworldly, beautiful and slightly unsettling for new arrivals. Managing the system and keeping safety protocols in place is a unique skill. Terpinol has adapted some of it, but Kurosol remains the center for expertise in this area.

At night, from the sea, Kurosol glows like a jewel against dark coastline. Sailors use it as navigation marker, visible from great distance. The town announces itself. We are here. We master fire. We turn danger into beauty.

Cultural Life

Across the vast plains of Baranuq life is marked by quietude, simplicity, meditation, and modest living. In Kurosol, the vibe is celebration, decoration, display, and sensory richness. This isn't hypocrisy. —It's strategic. The province as a whole prefers understatement. But they recognize the need for a place where their capabilities are visible, where visitors from distant lands can witness Baranuq's achievements, where trade and diplomacy can happen in settings that command respect.

Musicians from across the province gather in the town and instruments of every tradition are represented. There are both spontaneous performances and formal concerts. Dance and

storytelling are widespread as well.

Kurosol's cuisine synthesizes Baranuq's strong vegetarian traditions with maritime influence. Grain dishes are prepared with great skills and seafood is presented in ways that can make interior Baranuq folk uncomfortable. S'lah is paired intelligently with food at elaborate restaurants, while street vendors serve quick meals for everyday. During festivals the town swells with visitors. Temporary structures expand capacity. The celebration becomes the town's entire focus.

The Temple of Tranquility

Among Kurosol's structures stands one that approaches permanent architecture. the Temple of Tranquility. The temple's walls are adorned with carvings depicting scenes of serenity. Figures in mediation, natural landscapes, seasonal cycles, harmony between species. On the inside, the space opens into a surprising sense of vastness, with high ceilings, mosaic patterns, minimal furnishings, subtle perfumes from incense burners. The temple is open to all, at all hours and proclaims no specific doctrine. It is used for life rituals and for those just seeking a moment of quiet.

The Hall of Artisans

Another significant structure, the Artisans Hall is a grand showcase for Baranuq craftsmanship. It houses collections of exquisite textiles, pottery, carvings, paintings, calligraphy, jewellery incorporating crystals and coral, and precision tools. It is part museum, part marketplace, part teaching facility. Master artisans work here publicly, demonstrating techniques. Apprentices learn. Visitors can watch, ask questions, purchase work directly.

The Hall announces: this is what Baranuq creates. This is the quality we achieve. This is why our goods command premium prices. Come see for yourself.

The Terrapin Travel Company

Kurosol is headquarters for one of the Saskan Lands' most beloved institutions, the Terrapin Travel Company. The TTC offers comfortable, inexpensive, slow transport around the Ring Road and connecting routes. Giant turtle, terpin-bred, enormous, patient, some of them sentient, others not, carry passengers. The service also provide beast-pulled wagons for goods transport and large riding beasts for individual travel. Food wagons typically accompany TTC caravans, and often entertainers provide music and stories en route as well. Speed is not the point. Comfort, affordability, and reliability are.

The TTC maintains an impressive infrastructure based out of Kurosol. It has breeding and training facilities for transport animals, maintenance workshops for wagons and equipment, coordination offices managing routes and schedules and housing and support for its teams. The TTC has contracts with Rider Arms, Tagabant, Nyland and even some Kahila militias for security. From Kurosol, caravans depart regularly, beginning the long journey north toward the Ring Road, then around to destinations across the Lands. There are also TTC teams that only return to Kurosol for breaks.

Defense and Safety

Despite being remote and facing the Komikol, Kurosol is secure. The Walls aren't merely artistic; they're functional military architecture. They are thick, high, well-maintained with gates that can be secured quickly. Defensive positions, though not easily visible, are built into design. The location provides early warning of maritime approach. Overland approach requires crossing the vast Baranuq interior, where hidden settlements can observe and report. The remoteness that makes Kurosol hard to reach also makes it hard to attack.

Local terpin and hum fighters train in martial arts and the town is intimately connected with the whole of Baranuq. An attack on Kurosol would bring a response from entire province. Kurosol has

connections to Terpinol, Byenung, Eelan, Arq, the Ny Lands, and High Weir -- all powerful friends, should they be needed. Terpin maritime vessels can serve military functions if required.

Kurosol folk, like all those in Baranuq, prefer not to fight. But like Baranuq generally, preference for peace shouldn't be mistaken for inability to defend. Those who have tested this resolve regretted it. Both the Dominion and the Komikols have learned this the hard way. Komikol raiders still occasionally attempt incursions during hard years. They're typically repelled with minimal casualties on either side. Kurosol's defenders are skilled at discouraging without massacring. The goal is not victory but deterrence, not domination but security.

Kurosol, like every place else, faces uncertain times. The Saskan Lands are fracturing. Authoritarians demand loyalty. Neutral ground becomes suspect. Places that allow species mixing face increasing hostility from those who view such integration as threat or abomination. Kurosol's remoteness provides some protection. But also isolation. If attacked, help is days away even from fraternal Terpinol. The town's survival depends on continued respect for its neutrality and the deterrent value of Baranuq's collective response.

Economic pressures increase too. Grain trade becomes political tool. Combustible materials grow more valuable and more dangerous. Knowledge of advanced techniques attracts unwanted attention.

And beneath everything: the question of what happens when the old terpins die. Who carries forward the ancient knowledge? Who maintains the maritime traditions? Who remembers how things were before hum, and why the synthesis that followed matters?

Kurosol endures because it has always endured, through patience, through flexibility, through deep roots combined with willingness to adapt. The town has weathered centuries of change. Perhaps it will weather what comes next.

Or perhaps, like many beautiful things in this world, its time is drawing to a close. Perhaps the age of neutral ground, of species cooperation, of places where knowledge flows freely, perhaps that age

is ending.

If so, Kurosol will go down blazing. Literally. The lamps will burn until the very end. The walls will stand decorated until they fall. And those ancient terpins watching ships from the piers will continue their vigil until the waters rise or the world ends or something new begins.

Which, given terpin patience, might all be the same thing anyway.

No Walls

To understand Settarune, start with absence. There are no walls. No fortified towns. No central square where authority gathers to pronounce judgments. Travel the province from its western border with Barból to its eastern reaches near the Runes of Bye, a journey of some five hundred kilometers, and you will pass through thousands of villages, each one distinct, each one governing itself according to its own lights, and not one of them designed to withstand a siege.

This is not carelessness. This is choice.

Settarune is the largest, most populous, and most productive agricultural province in the Saskan Lands, and it has organized itself specifically to resist the kind of centralization that would make it controllable. The villages cluster densely enough that you're rarely more than an hour's walk from the next settlement, yet far enough apart that each maintains its own identity. Fields stretch between them. Vegetables, herbs, orchards, grains all worked by hum and sint in roughly equal numbers, their labor sustained by the intricate irrigation networks fed by the Settan River along the province's northern edge.

The Ring Road runs along that northern border, following the river's southern bank, connecting Settarune to the wider Saskan world while never quite penetrating its interior. Travelers on the Ring see caravans departing northward, heavily laden with produce. They see the orderly fields, the well-maintained irrigation channels, the obvious prosperity.

What they don't see is the political sophistication that makes this abundance possible without hierarchy.

Ask a Settarune farmer who governs the province and she'll give you a name, probably her village council's current speaker. Ask who governs Settarune as a whole and she'll laugh. "We do," she might say. "All of us. None of us. Depends on the question."

Geography and Character

Settarune occupies the vast territory south of the Settan River and north of the Ring Road, bordered by the Runes of Bye to the east and Barból province to the west. Its southern border with Baranuk is long and remarkably porous, more of a gradual transition than a sharp boundary.

The land is flat to gently rolling, broken by occasional low hills and countless streams feeding down from the north into the Settan. The soil is rich, dark, and forgiving, the kind of earth that rewards attention without punishing mistakes too harshly. This fertility is not natural but cultivated, the product of centuries of careful composting, crop rotation, and the manual pollination techniques perfected by the Dauni Vakasaqua and disseminated throughout the South.

Water shapes everything. The Settan provides the main source, but hundreds of tributaries and carefully maintained irrigation channels distribute that water throughout the province. Villages organize around water access. Fields extend outward from irrigation channels in geometric patterns visible from any high vantage point. During planting and growing seasons, teams of pollinators move systematically through orchards and vegetable plots, touching each flower by hand, the endless, patient work that makes fertility possible in a world without bees.

The province divides roughly into three cultural zones, though the boundaries remain fluid and contested.

The western zone, closest to Barból and Low Weir, shows the strongest Dauni Vakasaqua influence. Here the oldest and most

vibrant River Soul cults maintain their temples and sacred sites. Villages in this region supply significant agricultural products to both the Fatunik Dominion and the Rider Provinces, creating wealth that manifests in well-maintained village commons, large farms, impressive herb gardens, and the distinctive white-robed DK presence in nearly every settlement. The western farmers are pragmatic traders, comfortable dealing with northern merchants while maintaining their southern identity.

The central and eastern zones contain the most fertile lands and the most diverse populations. Villages here interact heavily with neighboring provinces: the Runes of Bye, Baranuk, and even distant connections to the Ny Lands and Arq. Linguistic diversity peaks in the east, where Sogomsh blends with Fatunik, Runik and Mobali Eibar, Arql, and Kahila dialects. Religious practices are wildly syncretic, combining river worship with Returner artifact veneration, ancestor cults, and occasional adoption of Finder traditions or Runik enthusiasms. Enterprise takes every conceivable form, from small family plots farmed by extended kinship groups, to large collective syndicates that pool labor and resources, and even a few quasi-feudal operations where wealthy landowners employ dozens of workers in arrangements that approach, but carefully avoid becoming, actual serfdom.

The northern zone, hugging the Settan River and adjacent to Kahilabequa province, hosts big Kahila refugee populations and operates under heavy Kahila cultural influence. These are the villages where pro-Kahila sentiment runs deepest, where young people debate Dominion policies with genuine passion, where exile Kahila bands maintain hidden camps. The northern villages share language, food traditions, and weaving techniques with Kahilabequa across the river. They also bear some visible scars: burned fields from raids that spilled across the border during the worst years of the Kahila Wars, memorial stones marking villages that fled en masse when Dominion forces seemed poised to cross the Settan, a pervasive alertness that never quite settles into peace.

The Mixed Multitude

Settarune contains the largest sint population of any Saskan province. Perhaps sixty or seventy thousand individuals, though accurate counts are impossible when many sint communities prefer invisibility. Rabbit-sints dominate numerically, their warrens and burrow-villages creating underground networks that parallel the surface settlements. But snakes, lizards of various species, mammals with badger or otter or fox lineage, and even rarer variants all make their homes here.

What distinguishes Settarune is the degree of integration. In the Dominion or in the Rider Provinces, hum and sint maintain separate quarters, distinct roles, clearly marked boundaries. In Settarune, mixed families exist, though they are not common. A child with scales along her forearms, partially hidden under long sleeves but visible to anyone who looks closely, works her family's vegetable plot alongside her fully hum cousins. A young man whose pupils catch lamplight and reflect it back works as a pollination team leader, his slightly elongated fingers making him especially skilled at delicate blossom work.

This integration reflects both necessity and philosophy. Manual pollination requires enormous labor inputs. Refusing to collaborate with sint communities would make agriculture impossible. But while actual integration is cautious, acceptance goes deeper than pragmatism. River worship, as practiced in Settarune, includes no doctrine of hum supremacy. The Settan sustains all who respect it. The fields produce for whoever tends them properly. These beliefs create space for cooperation that would scandalize northern authorities.

Still, collaboration is not uniformity. Most sint communities maintain separate villages, sometimes visible and participating in local governance, sometimes hidden and interacting with hum neighbors only for trade or specific collaborative projects. Some sint groups, particularly those with strong non-hum appearance or those fleeing persecution in the north, specifically choose Settarune for its tolerance while preferring to remain apart. The province accepts this too. Live how you wish, so long as you harm no one and share water fairly.

The resulting demographic tapestry is extraordinarily complex. Walk

through a Settarune market and you'll see hum farmers haggling over seed prices next to rabbit-sint merchants displaying embroidered cloth, while a snake-sint herbalist discusses medicinal preparations with a mixed-lineage healer whose exact ancestry no one would presume to question. The languages shift mid-conversation from Sogomsh to Eibar to Arql and back, sometimes within a single sentence.

Food stalls offer vegetarian staples alongside insectivore delicacies: roasted beetles ground into protein-rich pastes, cricket flour tortillas, ant-egg dumplings flavored with river herbs. The variety caters to the significant population with avian or reptilian DNA whose dietary needs differ from baseline hum.

The Work That Sustains

To call Settarune agricultural is like calling the ocean wet, technically accurate but wildly insufficient to capture the reality. Agriculture in Settarune is not an industry. It is the organizing principle of existence. Everything else, from politics, religion, art, to family structure and the rhythm of days and seasons flows from and returns to the fundamental work of making plants grow and reproduce without the natural pollinators that once made this work effortless.

The growing season dominates the calendar. Planting begins in early spring when the Settan's flood subsides and soil conditions stabilize. Villages coordinate timing through informal networks, a combination of traditional planting calendars, observation of soil moisture and temperature, and consultation with Dauni Vakasaqua field representatives who travel circuit routes advising on optimal schedules for the large variety of plantings.

The actual work is nearly always communal and at a large scale. Even villages organized around individual family plots bring workers together for planting days. The reasons are practical: shared tools, shared knowledge, efficiency of scale, but also social. Planting days are festivals as much as labor. Food is shared, children dart between rows, musicians play, and the work proceeds with surprising speed given the celebratory atmosphere. By evening, acres have been

planted, bellies are full, and the village has renewed its collective commitment to shared survival.

Then comes the pollination. The endless, patient work that defines life in so much of the Settan Lands.

Pollination teams organize according to local custom. Some villages use family units, others form specialized crews, still others rotate all adults through pollination duty. The Dauni Vakasaqua train team leaders in technique: which flowers need pollination at which stage, how to avoid damaging delicate blossoms, which weather conditions make pollination effective or futile. The best pollinators develop almost supernatural precision, moving through orchards and fields with the focused grace of dancers, their hands speaking a language of touch that makes fruit possible.

The work is exhausting. A pollination season might last six to eight weeks, during which teams work from dawn until hands become too numb or light fails. They develop calluses, muscle memory, a particular kind of meditative focus. Many describe pollination work as simultaneously boring and deeply satisfying, boring in its repetition, satisfying in its absolute necessity and visible results.

Some villages treat pollination as sacred labor, singing river hymns or maintaining ritual silence. Others approach it purely practically, chatting and joking through the long hours. Both methods work. The plants don't care about your attitude, only about your precision.

After pollination comes the anxious wait for fruit set, then tending, then harvest. Harvest is again communal, again celebratory, though the tone shifts from spring's hopeful energy to autumn's satisfied exhaustion. The harvest determines next year's seed stock, winter food stores, trade goods for northern markets. A failed harvest means hunger. A good harvest means prosperity, full storage houses, and surplus to sell.

Settarune has become expert at growing the difficult crops. Its produce is considerably more diverse than Baranuq to the south, which produces mostly mountains of grain. Settarune fields require intense hand pollination of the type that northern provinces either can't or won't manage effectively. Certain varieties of vegetables,

specific herb strains, delicate fruits that command high prices in Dominion markets are Settarune specialties. The province leverages this expertise into negotiating power, refusing to be bullied on prices because northern buyers have no alternatives.

Organized Anarchy

How does a province of thousands of villages, with no central authority and no fortified towns, manage to function at all, let alone prosper?

The answer lies in layers of overlapping coordination that operate through persuasion, consensus, and a deeply ingrained cultural resistance to allowing any single authority to accumulate too much power.

At the village level, governance methods vary wildly. Some villages use council systems where all adults vote on major decisions. Others defer to elders who rule through respect rather than formal power. Still others organize around extended family networks, where the oldest member of the largest clan effectively makes decisions by coordinating family members who then influence their neighbors. Some villages have adopted representative systems modeled loosely on Barból's town council. Others operate by pure consensus, holding meetings that can last for days until everyone agrees or until everyone gets too tired to argue and accepts whatever compromise has emerged. And some operate in a near-feudal way.

The key is that all these systems remain local. A village council or owner of a large farm has authority only within its own boundaries. It cannot compel neighboring villages to adopt its decisions.

Yet coordination happens. During the Kahila Wars, when fighting threatened to spill across the Settan, the entire province mobilized tens of thousands of fighters in a popular uprising that helped convince the Dominion to sue for peace before launching a final assault on the Kahila Lands. How?

Through networks.

The Dauni Vakasaqua maintain the most extensive informal network, with field representatives traveling circuit routes throughout Settarune, sharing agricultural innovations, training pollinators, treating illnesses, and inevitably discussing politics. When the DK representatives quietly suggest that farmers might want to coordinate responses to Dominion policies, word spreads quickly through these established channels.

The Traveling Sisters of the Way of All Things operate similarly, moving between villages, treating injuries, making friends, noting who has talents or grievances that might be useful in coordination efforts.

Traveling merchants of various types and the Barból Riverwaq provide another information network. River workers hear news from every village along the Settan, and they share it freely, partly for social purposes, partly because information is currency in trade negotiations.

Religious networks like the various river cults, Returner groups, even the syncretic blending of both create additional layers of connection. A devotee from the Temple of Flowing Spirits might visit a dozen villages during pilgrimage season, carrying not just spiritual messages but practical information about what other villages are planning, thinking, worrying about.

When a major decision needs coordination such as water allocation during drought, response to Dominion pressure, organization of large trade caravans then these networks buzz with activity. Messengers travel. Meetings happen. Not war councils with formal decision-making power, but gatherings where representatives from interested villages share information and try to find consensus.

The process can be slow, frustrating, but is surprisingly effective. It prevents anyone from imposing unpopular decisions by force while allowing communities to coordinate when they perceive common interest. It also creates space for dissent. If some villages want to trade more with the Dominion while others refuse, both can do so. If some villages want to provide sanctuary to Kahila refugees while others prefer to avoid the political risk, both approaches coexist. Settarune's lack of central authority means no single policy can be

imposed on the entire province.

This drives northern administrators, and even some of their friendly neighbors, to distraction. The Dominion cannot threaten Settarune effectively because there's no central authority to threaten. You can't bribe a council that doesn't exist or intimidate leaders who have no formal power. The best you can do is negotiate with individual villages and hope the deals you strike influence others through example. If you are an engineer from Byenung or Selaron with an idea for road improvements, finding anyone to work with can be a frustrating experience.

The Kahila Question

Settarune's relationship with the Kahila cause is passionate, complex, and shot through with contradictions that reflect the province's distance from actual combat.

Ask a farmer in northern Settarune about the Kahilaqor, the occupied territory that the Dominion seized during the wars, and you'll likely get an impassioned speech about Fatunik oppression, Kahila resistance, and the moral imperative to support reunification. The speaker will use "we" liberally: "We cannot allow this injustice." "We must stand with our Kahila neighbors."

Yet "we" in this context means something different than in Kahilabequa itself, where Tagabant forces patrol streets and where speaking too loudly about reunification can bring very real consequences.

The difference is proximity to danger. Settarune's support for the Kahila cause costs little in immediate terms. No Tagabant forces occupy or patrol Settarune villages. No Tagabant units conduct sweeps looking for resistance cells. The suffering is visible across the river but not directly experienced. This creates room for idealism untempered by the grim pragmatism that shapes politics in occupied territories.

Cynics in Kahilabequa sometimes say, with bitter humor, that the

Settarunes are "more Kahila than the Kahila"—meaning they can afford to be, because they're not the ones living under occupation.

This criticism isn't entirely fair. Settarune villages do provide material support. They house refugees, including some exile rebel bands who operate hidden camps in remote areas. They smuggle supplies across the river when opportunities arise. When the Kahila Wars threatened to spill into Settarune itself, the province mobilized a massive popular army that shook the Lands from Scattering to Two Trees. Not just to defend Settarune, but to demonstrate that any renewed attempt to expand Dominion control south of the river would be met with overwhelming resistance.

That mobilization remains a source of debate. Some argue that Settarune should have crossed the river, should have pushed into Kahila territory while the Dominion was overextended, should have actually liberated the Corridor rather than just making a demonstration of force, should have put an end to Tonedor Rumpet's reign. The counterargument is that such action would have triggered full-scale war, would have brought devastation to Settarune's villages, would have destroyed the very prosperity that makes the south valuable.

Both positions have merit. Both remain passionately argued, especially among young people in the northern villages who didn't live through the wars and who see the current settlement as cowardly compromise. The truth is that Settarune's support for the Kahila cause operates mostly at the level of ideology rather than action. The province provides rhetorical support, cultural affinity, a place where Kahila refugees can find welcome. It does not, and likely never will, provide military intervention.

This frustrates both Kahila hardliners who want active allies and Dominion administrators who would prefer clear lines of allegiance. Settarune remains deliberately and impossibly ambiguous, sympathetic but uninvolved, close enough to care but far enough to avoid commitment.

Syncretic Soup

The religious landscape of Settarune defies clean categorization. River worship dominates but takes countless forms. Returner cults flourish, especially in the eastern regions. Syncretic blends create hybrids that orthodox believers of any tradition would struggle to recognize.

The Temple of Flowing Spirits maintains significant presence, teaching that the Settan carries ancestral souls and that proper ritual maintains connection with the dead. Their deacons, women trained in both theological and practical herbalism, serve as respected community leaders even in villages that don't formally belong to the temple.

The Circle of Ancient Weavers, based in Brokily but with outposts throughout western Settarune, practice their distinctive textile-based river worship. Their market stalls display intricate patterns they claim communicate with the river's spirit. Whether this works remains debatable, but their cloth sells well, and their presence at riverside festivals adds color and ceremony.

Smaller, more idiosyncratic cults proliferate. One village venerates a particular spring as especially sacred. Another focuses devotions on an ancient stone bridge where legend says the river goddess first revealed herself. A third practices ancestor-focused religion with only tangential connection to the river itself.

Returner beliefs blend freely with river worship. The Seekers of Setta's Energy operate throughout Settarune, treating ancient artifacts as vessels for the same force that animates the river. A Seeker shrine might sit next to a river temple with no sense of contradiction and both are seeking connection to the living force that sustains existence, just through different channels.

The Dixelites, the branch of Returners focused on recovering ancient healing knowledge, find a warm welcome in many of Settarune's villages. Their practical focus on herbal medicine and ancient healing techniques aligns well with the DK's work, and the two groups often collaborate despite having different theological foundations.

Even the controversial Devotees of Malavorra maintain presence in parts of Settarune province, though more quietly than in Barból. Devotees make pilgrimages through Settarune, visiting sites they believe the living goddess designated as sacred, sometimes overlapping uncomfortably with Seeker temples or river shrines. Village reactions vary. Some welcome them as harmless eccentrics; others view them as troublesome mystics whose presence attracts unwanted attention.

What unifies this religious chaos is a practical tolerance born of necessity. Villages cannot afford internal conflict over theology so they simply don't have such conflicts. You believe the river is an ancestor repository? Fine. You think Setta animates ancient stones? That's fine too. Let's get back to pollinating the orchards before we lose the bloom window and we all starve to death.

The Dauni Vakasaqua navigate this religious diversity with characteristic pragmatism. They don't endorse any particular theology, but they work with all of them. A DK field representative might teach pollination techniques to a village led by Flowing Spirits deacons in the morning and consult with Seeker artifact-hunters in the afternoon. The DK's focus on practical results rather than ideological purity makes them acceptable to nearly everyone.

The Shadow in the Fields

Not everything in Settarune is a blend of anarchic overtones that just somehow work and agricultural imperatives. The province faces challenges both acknowledged and hidden.

Labor disputes arise, particularly on larger collectives and farms and on the quasi-feudal operations where workers are exploited by wealthy landowners. These conflicts occasionally turn violent: burned storage houses, sabotaged irrigation channels, mysterious accidents befalling particularly hated overseers. Village councils try to mediate when they can, but their authority to enforce settlements remains limited.

Some radical sint groups, frustrated with the pace of hum-sint

integration or influenced by militant ideologies, maintain fortified camps in remote areas. These groups train fighters and espouse confrontational politics, though they generally direct their anger northward at the Dominion rather than at their Settarune neighbors. Still, their presence creates tension, and occasional clashes occur when their members venture into villages.

More insidiously, Jaxen infiltration proceeds unnoticed by most at a rapid rate. The artificial beings created by the Maken have discovered that agricultural laborers make perfect cover. A tireless worker who never complains, who accepts minimal wages, who performs backbreaking pollination work without visible exhaustion, such a person is welcomed, not questioned. Jaxen units have worked Settarune fields for many seasons, gathering information about agricultural techniques, about village organization, about the distribution of sint populations.

The purpose of this intelligence gathering remains unclear, but the Beqawar have noticed, and they are increasingly concerned. A few DK representatives have begun quietly inquiring about workers who seem just slightly off, who speak too little, who never seem to tire, who show no interest in the social aspects of farm work. But without central coordination, alerting thousands of villages to a threat most won't even believe in proves nearly impossible.

Settarune's strength, its decentralization, its tolerance, its openness, is also its vulnerability. There is no security apparatus to detect infiltration, no intelligence network to track suspicious patterns across multiple villages. The very qualities that make the province free also make it penetrable to a foe skilled at occult infiltration.

The Sleeping Giant

For all its apparent chaos, Settarune possesses latent power that northern authorities, especially Beshquahoeck, understand and fear.

The province has no standing army, no military infrastructure, no warrior tradition, not even the kind of widespread martial arts training common in neighboring Baranuq. Yet it demonstrated during the

Kahila Wars that it can mobilize overwhelming force when sufficiently threatened. That farmers who spend their days pollinating blossoms can, with minimal organization, respond to a heartfelt call and become a popular army of terrifying size in short order.

But this military potential is entirely defensive. Settarune has no way to assemble an ambition to conquer territory or impose its will on neighbors. But the implicit threat, that invading Settarune will trigger a mass mobilization, serves as effective deterrent. The Dominion knows it cannot occupy Settarune without committing forces it needs elsewhere, and even then, the odds are not good. The Riders, though more-or-less allied rather than hostile, similarly understand that pressuring the province too hard risks awakening something they'd prefer to leave sleeping.

Debates continue, especially among northern Settarune's Kahila sympathizers, about whether the province should actively use this power to support Kahila liberation rather than merely defending its own territory. So far, the answer remains no. The memory of the Kahila Wars, the violence, the destruction, the scars still visible across the river, serves as powerful restraint.

But the potential remains. Settarune could decide differently. Thousands of villages could coordinate, could mobilize, could cross the river. That they choose not to is a choice, not an inability. And choices, ultimately, can change.

The Rhythm of Life

Ultimately, Settarune can best be understood not as a political entity at all, but as a rhythm of life. The annual cycle of planting, pollinating, tending, harvesting that organizes existence for hundreds of thousands of hum and sint who have chosen, collectively and individually, to resist centralization while embracing cooperation.

The province feeds the Saskan Lands. That is not metaphor. Settarune's vegetables, herbs, grains, and fruits sustain Dominion garrison towns, Rider caravans, Outer Lands communes, Eelan miners, and its own vast population. The South could not function

without Settarune, and Settarune uses that dependency as leverage to maintain its formless, wildly diverse freedoms.

Stand in a Settarune field during pollination season. Watch the teams moving through the rows, hands touching each blossom with careful precision. Listen to the singing, the laughter, the rustle of grasses and the distant murmur of irrigation channels. Feel the sun on your shoulders and the rich earth beneath your feet.

This is power. Not the power of armies or authority, but the power of work well done, of coordination without coercion, of abundance generated through patient attention to the requirements of living things.

The fields produce. The villages prosper. The river flows. The Mother sustains life. And Settarune, vast and ungovernable, continues to feed a world that can neither control it nor do without it.

The Settan Heartland

If Settarune is the Settan Lands' breadbasket and Baranuq its ancient soul, Barból Province is its engine room, its beating heart, the place where agricultural work intensifies from necessity into art, where innovation happens not through inspiration but through relentless, methodical refinement of every technique and tool.

The landscape strikes visitors immediately. There are no empty spaces. Between villages lie not wild grassland or fallow fields or even the monotonous repetition of village life, but intensively worked plots, orchards, herb gardens, livestock pens, compost operations, experimental crop stations, all busy and determinedly productive. The Dauni Vakasaqua like to say that Barból is cultivated down to the bone. Every available meter of land serves some productive purpose. Even the roadside verges between the Ring Road and the first farmsteads feature carefully tended medicinal herbs, maintained by local agricultural cooperatives as both resource and advertisement of

skill.

Barból villages, collectives, farms and manufactories cluster more densely than anywhere else in the South, sometimes not even a kilometer apart, creating an almost continuous inhabited zone. Yet each village maintains fierce independence, distinctive character, and its own particular agricultural specialization. One village might focus on developing new tomato varieties suited to Settan River water's mineral content. The next village over perfects cheese-making techniques using milk from their small mammal herds—the only place in all the Settan Lands where dairy production exists. A third specializes in insectivore delicacies, with cricket farms and beetle nurseries producing protein-rich ingredients that command premium prices in Arq and the Outer Lands.

This density creates both prosperity and pressure. Barból Province operates at agricultural intensity that would exhaust most farming communities within a generation. Yet they've sustained it for centuries through a culture that values constant innovation, extreme vigilance, and a work ethic so intense it makes even the industrious Settarunes look relaxed.

Ask a Barból farmer about their approach and you'll get a terse, practical answer: "We do what works. What doesn't work, we fix. If we can't fix it, we try something else." No poetry, no mysticism, just relentless pragmatic problem-solving applied to the fundamental challenge of feeding themselves and everyone who depends on them.

Geography and Boundaries

Barból Province occupies a strategic position where the Settan River swings southward from its eastward flow. The province borders Low Weir and Aranzen to the west. Barely fifty kilometers separate Barból town from Aranzen territory, making cross-border cultural influences real, even if actual travel to Aranzen requires a much longer path. To the northwest lies Eelan, source of metal goods that Barból craftspeople incorporate into their advanced agricultural tools. The Borda Woods, one of the Dominions most orthodox provinces, and still bearing scars from the Great Conflagration five centuries past, lie

at the northern boundary.

The eastern and southern frontiers of Barból blur into Settarune and Terpinol provinces respectively. These boundaries exist more on maps than in reality. Provincial identity matters less than village identity in the southern territories, and farmers care more about water-sharing agreements than about which province their fields officially occupy on some map in a vault in Terpinol or Byenung.

The Ring Road enters Barból from Bordakol, a Dominion town to the northeast, then crosses the Settan River on a massive stone bridge just upstream from Barból town, and continues east towards Kahilabequa. This makes the province a natural crossroads, though one that filters traffic through the town itself rather than allowing roads to penetrate its densely farmed interior.

The river defines everything. At this point in its journey, the Settan runs swift and cold, fed by tributaries from the Borda Woods and gathering force before its eventual southern turn. The current is strong enough to power the extensive network of waterwheels that line the riverbank for kilometers in both directions from Barból town. These wheels pump water into the intricate irrigation system that makes the province's agricultural intensity possible.

A small portion of the province extends north of the river, a reminder of ancient territorial claims that predated current provincial divisions. This northern section bears the most visible scars from the Great Conflagration: stretches of blood-red bougainvillea that rose from the ashes and now spread aggressively despite constant efforts at control. The Barból Conservation Corps (BCC) was created specifically to combat this invasive plant, and their daily patrols through the northern section have become an essential part of provincial life.

Culture of Efficiency

Barból's defining characteristic is not its productivity. Settarune produces much greater total volume. But rather its efficiency. Every technique has been refined. Every tool optimized. Every process

streamlined to eliminate wasted motion or materials.

This shows in the village layouts. Unlike Settarune's organic sprawl, Barból villages follow geometric patterns. Houses are arranged in neat rows, shared facilities clustered for optimal access, fields extending outward in carefully measured plots. Streets are swept daily. Flowerpots and decorative elements are arranged with precision. Signs and displays face the street at identical angles.

The villagers rise before dawn, not from religious obligation but because daylight is a limited resource and work doesn't wait. By the time most Settarune or Baranuq folk are considering breakfast, Barból farmers have already cleaned their immediate surroundings, inspected their fields, and often completed an hour or two of work.

This intensity creates a culture that outsiders often misinterpret as cold or unwelcoming. Barból people are not unfriendly; they're focused. Time spent on elaborate greetings or extended pleasantries is time not spent on work. The result is a communication style that prizes brevity and directness over warmth.

Two Barból farm managers meeting:

"Crop?"

"Good. Yours?"

"Same. Irrigation?"

"Adjusted yesterday. Check valve three."

"Noted."

That's a complete and useful conversation by Barból standards. Information was exchanged, a problem addressed, and both parties return to work in a timely fashion. No wasted words, no performance of politeness for its own sake, just efficient transfer of necessary data.

This terseness extends to dealings with outsiders, creating a reputation for Barból folk as blunt, even rude. But it's not rudeness. It's simply a different set of priorities. A Barból villager who spends twenty minutes chatting with a merchant when five minutes would suffice is

seen as frivolous, possibly showing off, definitely wasting daylight.

The flip side is a deep competence that commands respect. When a Barból farmer tells you something about agriculture, you can trust it's been tested, refined, and verified through practical application. They don't theorize. They demonstrate.

Careful Boundaries

Barból Province, like all of the southern areas, has a substantial sint population. Perhaps twenty thousand individuals across all villages. The mix includes rabbit-sints, various reptilian species with snakes being particularly numerous, mammalian sints with otter or badger traits, and scattered individuals of rarer lineages.

Relations between hum and sint are civil, fair, and carefully boundaried. This is not Settarune's easy collaboration or the easy mixing of Terpinol and Baranuq. Barból maintains more separation, not through legal enforcement but through mutual preference and an unspoken understanding that everyone functions better with clear expectations.

Villages have distinct sint neighborhoods or adjacent settlements. A rabbit-sint warren might sit a hundred meters from the main hum village, with regular interaction for trade and some collaborative projects but separate living spaces and mostly separate industries. Snake-sint families often prefer their own compounds, valuing privacy and the ability to regulate temperature and humidity to their comfort.

This separation reflects Barból's broader cultural tendency toward a "mind your own business" pragmatism. Hum farmers don't particularly care what sint communities do internally, so long as they fulfill their commitments to shared projects and don't interfere with others' work. Sint communities appreciate not having to constantly explain or justify their practices to hum neighbors or adjust their language to hum norms.

The result is a kind of respectful parallel existence. During pollination

season, mixed teams work the large fields with complete professionalism, huum and sint side by side, focused on the task, leaving social complexities for after the work is done. When the work is done, they return to their separate communities.

This arrangement works remarkably well for agricultural cooperation while avoiding the intimacy that makes some huum uncomfortable and that many sints view as intrusive. A Barból farmer might work alongside the same snake-sint pollinator for twenty seasons without ever entering their home or discussing anything beyond crop yields and technique. Both parties consider this entirely satisfactory.

Where integration does occur is around specific skills. A particularly talented huum cheesemaker might train a mammalian-sint apprentice because the student shows aptitude. A snake-sint expert in medicinal herbs might work closely with a huum healer, sharing knowledge across species lines because the skill transfer matters more than social boundaries.

Children grow up understanding these patterns, Be professional with everyone, be social within your own community, and don't presume to know what's best for people different from yourself. It's not warmth, but it's functional, and it largely prevents the kind of conflicts that plague both more integrated or more segregated regions.

The Obsessive Edge

What distinguishes Barból agriculture from Settarune's abundance is the province's obsessive focus on improvement. Settarune farmers perfect reliable techniques and apply them consistently. Barból farmers perfect techniques, then immediately start testing variations to see if they can achieve even marginally better results.

The Dauni Vakasaqua maintain one of their largest research facilities outside Low Weir in Barból town, and the collaboration between DK researchers and Barból farmers drives constant innovation. Field trials occur in designated plots throughout the province: new pollination methods, experimental crop varieties, novel irrigation patterns,

alternative composting techniques.

Barból farmers track everything. They maintain detailed records of planting dates, weather conditions, pollination schedules, yields, soil amendments, pest pressures. This data gets shared within village councils, compiled across villages, and analyzed for patterns. When a technique shows even five percent improvement over standard practice, it spreads rapidly through the province's networks. This creates specialized agricultural knowledge that gives Barból competitive advantage. They produce crops that require such intensive technique that other provinces cannot match their quality or yield. Certain vegetable varieties, particular herb strains, delicate fruits; these command premium prices precisely because Barból's methods cannot be easily replicated elsewhere.

The province also leads in agricultural tool innovation. Working with metal imported from Eelan and designs refined through generations of use, Barból craftspeople produce superior pollination brushes, irrigation valves, soil cultivation implements, and harvest tools. These tools are themselves export goods, sold throughout the Settan Lands and beyond.

Livestock management represents another area of distinctive expertise. Barból is the only Settan province that domesticates mammals for milk production. Small herds of various species, some recognizable as goat or sheep descendants, others too altered by post-Catastrophe evolution to identify clearly, produce milk that Barból cheesemakers transform into diverse products. The cheese-making knowledge remains closely guarded, passed through family lines or taught within guilds that charge substantial fees for apprenticeships.

The province also excels at insectivore food production. This is a necessity given the significant reptilian-sint populations of the Settan Lands, but here it developed into high culinary art. Cricket farms operate with the same meticulous attention given to vegetable plots. Beetle nurseries maintain optimal conditions for larvae development. Ant colonies are cultivated for their eggs. The resulting products like protein pastes, flour, flavorings are processed, spiced, and packaged for distribution throughout the Saskan Lands, a niche market that is well-received by its consumers.

This agricultural intensity extracts a cost. The work is physically exhausting. The constant pressure for improvement creates stress. Some teams burn out. Productivity drops, key innovators leave, the community slides from excellence to mere adequacy. Others maintain intensity for generations, developing reputations for particular specialties that become sources of fierce local pride.

The Town Council System

Barból Province operates the most sophisticated democratic governance structure in the Settan Lands. It's not perfect but it functions with remarkable stability given the challenges of coordinating hundreds of independent-minded villages.

The system works through nested representation. Each village elects its own council through processes that vary locally. Some use direct voting, others consensus-building, still others defer to respected elders who are then formally confirmed by community agreement. These village councils handle day-to-day governance: water allocation, dispute mediation, coordination of planting schedules, maintenance of shared facilities.

Village councils then elect representatives to clan councils. A "clan" in the Barból context doesn't mean blood kinship. It refers to groupings of villages that share historical ties, geographic proximity, or common economic interests. These councils coordinate between villages, negotiate resource sharing, and organize larger projects that require multi-village cooperation. From the clan councils, representatives are selected for the Town Council. The Barból Town Council governs the entire province, not just Barból town itself. The town, as the province's only significant urban center, indeed, as the most important trading center in all the Settan Lands, dominates the council's concerns and hosts its meetings in an elaborate centuries-old hall.

The Barból Town Council handles provincial-level decisions like relations with other provinces, major infrastructure projects, response to external threats, coordination with organizations like the Dauni Vakasaqua. It also manages the province's limited law enforcement,

though enforcement mainly means mediating disputes too complex for village councils and, occasionally, organizing responses to serious crimes.

Elections occur on staggered schedules, with roughly a third of positions turning over each year. This creates continuity while allowing regular infusion of new perspectives. Terms are typically three years, though exceptional councilors sometimes serve longer through repeated re-election. The system's strength is its legitimacy. Decisions made by the Town Council carry weight because they emerge from a clear chain of representation. Villages may disagree with council decisions, but they cannot claim those decisions were imposed by distant, unaccountable authority when their own elected representatives participated in making them. The weakness is slowness. Achieving consensus across hundreds of villages, filtered through multiple layers of councils, takes time. Emergency decisions can drag on for weeks as representatives consult with their constituents, return to the council with feedback, negotiate compromises, then return again for further consultation.

The system works adequately in peacetime. During crisis, it can be dangerously inadequate.

Fighting the Red Tide

The Barból Conservation Corps (BCC) began as an emergency response to an ecological crisis and evolved into a permanent institution that shapes provincial identity. Five hundred years ago, the Great Conflagration that ended the Eelani-Fatunik War left scorched earth across the Borda Woods and northern Barból. Most plants died. The soil itself seemed poisoned. Then, the following spring, something grew: blood-red bougainvillea of unprecedented hardiness and aggressive spread.

This plant, possibly a mutation triggered by whatever weapons caused the Conflagration, possibly something that simply thrived in post-fire conditions, proved nearly impossible to control. It grew rapidly, spread through both seed and root runners, tolerated poor soil, and resisted fire, cutting, and even attempted poisoning. Within a decade

it covered hundreds of square kilometers of the northern province.

The bougainvillea itself wasn't toxic or directly harmful. But it crowded out food crops, fouled irrigation channels, created impenetrable thickets that blocked roads and field access, and symbolized the war's lasting damage in a way that deeply disturbed Barból's orderly sensibilities. The Conservation Corps formed to address this threat. Initially a volunteer militia armed with machetes and shovels, it gradually professionalized into a disciplined organization with specialized knowledge of the plant's biology and effective suppression techniques.

BCC members patrol the northern province daily, cutting back bougainvillea encroachment, treating root systems, monitoring areas that have been cleared. They've learned that complete eradication is impossible. The plant has established itself too thoroughly. Instead, they practice constant containment, preventing the red tide from advancing into productive farmland while accepting its permanent presence in the fire-scarred zones.

The Corps has expanded its mission over time. They maintain the entire Ring Road section through Barból Province, the most well-kept stretch of the Ring anywhere in the Saskan Lands. It is patrolled daily, with potholes fixed immediately and debris cleared within hours of appearance. They assist with major infrastructure projects, provide emergency response during floods or other disasters, and serve as a source of civic pride for the province.

Joining the BCC carries prestige. Corps members wear distinctive green armbands and develop reputations for discipline and competence. Many young Barból folk serve a term with the Corps before settling into agricultural life, viewing it as a form of civic duty and practical training. The bougainvillea remains. The northern part of the province still shows its red scars. But the plant advances no further, and the Ring Road runs clean and clear through territory that might otherwise have been lost to invasive overgrowth. The Barból folk take quiet satisfaction in this. It is not a victory lap for them; it demonstrates their ability to successfully manage a problem that could easily have defeated less dedicated folks.

The Shadow of the Machines

Something is wrong in Barból Province, though most villagers have not yet realized it. The Jaxen, artificial beings created by the ancient Maken to observe and eventually infiltrate hum society, have found in Barból nearly perfect conditions for undetected operation.

Barból's culture makes Jaxen infiltration easier than in more socially complex provinces, and even easier than other Settan provinces. The terse, plain-speaking communication style means a Jaxen who speaks little attracts no attention; on the contrary, it's taken as appropriate seriousness. The value placed on constant hard work means a laborer who never tires, who never complains, who works with mechanical efficiency is admired rather than questioned. The "mind your own business" ethos means neighbors don't pry into each other's private lives, don't ask personal questions, don't expect emotional intimacy.

A Jaxen can arrive in a Barból village, offer to work for modest wages, labor with tireless dedication, speak only when necessary, and be welcomed as exactly the kind of serious, focused worker Barból culture values. They can maintain this cover for seasons, gathering information about agricultural techniques, social structures, sint populations, and provincial organization.

Some Jaxen have been present in Barból for generations. Some work in sensitive positions like agricultural research stations, irrigation management, and even have positions within village councils. In Barból town, Jaxen have achieved election to the Town Council itself, their mechanical precision in handling administrative tasks mistaken for exceptional competence.

The Jaxen's purposes remain unclear. They observe, yes, but now they also sample, taking hair, conducting careful medical examinations under guise of healing assistance, even more invasive procedures when opportunities arise. And they've recently shifted to something new: active experimentation, systematic study that requires more than observation. This has led to the incidents in Barból town that are beginning to generate concern, though not yet panic: disappearances, strange marks on bodies, a pattern of deaths that look almost like

accidents but aren't quite. The Beqawar have noticed. They've begun investigating quietly, but without provincial coordination and with a populace predisposed to skepticism about threats that can't be seen and measured, their warnings gain little traction.

The Jaxen infiltration of Barból represents one of the Maken's most successful long-term operations. The machines have learned that the best disguise is not elaborate deception but rather perfect fit with cultural expectations. In Barból, where hard work and taciturn demeanor are virtues, the Jaxen prosper.

A Province of Contradictions

Barból Province embodies tensions that make it fascinating and slightly unsettling.

It practices the most advanced agriculture in the Saskan Lands while maintaining deep reverence for the Settan River as a living force. It values efficiency and precision while accepting the fundamental irrationality of manual pollination as sacred practice. It maintains clear boundaries between hum and sint communities while enabling more productive cooperation than most integrated societies achieve.

It has created stable democratic governance while retaining, for the most part, the southern aversion to centralized power. It welcomes traders from everywhere, including the foreign territories of Aranzén, while maintaining a conservative culture that views outsiders with mild suspicion. It innovates constantly while deeply respecting tradition; this is innovation in service of traditional values, not in opposition to them.

And now it faces infiltration by beings it doesn't understand, cannot detect, and wouldn't believe in if told directly.

The province continues its work. Fields are tended. Innovations are tested. The Town Council meets in its ancient hall to debate infrastructure funding and trade agreements. The Conservation Corps patrols the northern reaches, cutting back the red bougainvillea. The villages wake before dawn, work through the day, sleep exhausted,

and rise to do it again.

Barból Province remains productive, orderly, and determinedly focused on practical matters. Whether this focus blinds it to gathering threats or represents the disciplined competence that will ultimately allow it to address those threats remains to be seen.

For now, the waterwheels turn. The irrigation flows. The crops grow. And in the shadows, others watch and learn.

Barból Town: Crossroads of the South

The first thing that strikes you about Barból town is the noise.

Not the volume, though it's plenty loud, but the texture. Layered sound, dense and complex: the rhythmic clank of waterwheels along the river, the calls of market vendors in three languages, the scrape of brooms on cobblestones as shopkeepers sweep their storefronts for the third time today, the splash of boats in the river channels, music threading through it all, a busker's reed flute here, a drum circle there, someone singing a bawdy river song in excellent four-part harmony.

Stand at the town's single enormous gate where the Ring Road enters from the northeast, and you can see the whole arc of Barból's contradictions laid out before you. To your left, the orderly residential quarters extend in neat geometric blocks, every street clean, every building well-maintained, flowerpots arranged with precision. To your right, the warehouses and craft workshops of the industrial district, organized with the same ruthless efficiency that characterizes all Barból enterprise. And straight ahead, impossible to miss, the Market Square. Explosions of color, sound, and cheerful chaos that seem to mock the town's reputation for order.

Barból town sits where the western Ring Road crosses the Settan River, serving as unofficial capital for both Barból Province and though they'd never admit it formally for much of Settarune Province as well, and Baranuq too for that matter. It's the largest town south of

the Settan, home to perhaps fifteen thousand permanent residents plus another five thousand transients at any given time: traders, seasonal workers, pilgrims, refugees, wanderers, and those mysterious few who arrive without explanation and work harder than anyone while speaking barely a word.

The town's wealth shows everywhere. Buildings are stone or fired brick, not wood or mud. Roofs are tile, not thatch. The streets are paved. Public fountains offer clean water at regular intervals. Lamp posts line major thoroughfares. Not mere torches but actual glass-paned lanterns that create pools of light even on moonless nights.

Yet for all this prosperity, Barból town maintains the South's essential character: it welcomes everyone, controls no one, and trusts that commerce and common interest will prevent chaos more effectively than laws ever could.

Controlled Chaos

The Market Square occupies the town's heart, a vast irregular space that grew organically over centuries and now sprawls across what might have once been three or four separate plazas. No one planned this space. It emerged, expanded, and adapted, and it now operates according to rules that everyone understands but no one could write down.

The market opens at dawn and by mid-morning has achieved its full cacophonous glory. Imagine: hundreds of stalls and temporary structures arranged under a dizzying canopy of tents, fronds, awnings, and ramshackle coverings of every description. The geometry is nightmarish, Pathways meander, intersect at odd angles, occasionally dead-end, forcing shoppers to double back. Yet somehow everyone finds what they need.

Food carts cluster in one section, sending up smoke and smells of a hundred cuisines. The spice dealers occupy another zone, their stalls draped with sacks of herbs and powders in every color, the air thick with competing fragrances. S'lah wallahs have their own area, brewing fresh batches in elaborate setups that range from simple

kettles to complex apparatus involving multiple vessels, tubes, and what appears to be alchemical precision. Hat-makers, trinket-sellers, knife-makers, cloth merchants, tool vendors, herbalists offering both legitimate medicine and questionable potions. All find their place.

Between the established stalls, buskers circulate. Musicians with homemade instruments, storytellers who'll perform entire epic cycles for a few coins, jugglers, dancers, the occasional snake charmer working with actual snake-sints in performances that blur the line between street theater and religious ceremony.

The noise is remarkable. Not loud exactly. Barból people are too sensible to yell unnecessarily. But constant, layered, a murmur that rises and falls with its own rhythm. Bargaining happens in low voices. Musicians play at moderate volume. Even the vendors' calls are more melodic than aggressive. The overall effect is less overwhelming than hypnotic.

And everywhere, threading through the crowd, broodkins dodging between adults' legs, dogs investigating interesting smells, the occasional goat escaped from someone's livestock pen, rabbit-sints shopping for textiles, snake-sints in heated discussion with herbalists, mammalian-sints with otter traits selling river fish, and hum from every province and territory imaginable.

This chaos operates in stark contrast to the rest of Barból town. Step outside the Market Square and order reasserts itself immediately. Streets are swept, buildings aligned, the geometric precision of Barból efficiency resumes. It's as if the town recognized that it needed one neatly enclosed space for chaos, contained it carefully within defined boundaries, and everywhere else maintains its characteristic discipline.

The market never formally closes. Even at midnight you'll find a few stalls open, serving late-night workers or travelers arriving after dark. But the full chaos operates only during daylight hours, when the canopy provides shade and the density of bodies creates its own energy.

The Town Council Hall

At the Market Square's northeastern edge stands the Town Council Hall, a building so different from the surrounding chaos that it seems to belong to a different town entirely.

The hall is centuries old and built with a grandeur unusual for the South. Three stories of dressed stone, with columns framing the entrance and high windows admitting light into the council chambers. The architecture shows influences from multiple periods: the foundation stones bear marks suggesting pre-Catastrophe construction, the main structure dates from the early settlement period, and various additions reflect different eras of prosperity.

Inside, the main chamber is surprisingly austere. Wooden benches arranged in concentric semicircles face a raised platform where the council speakers sit. No ornate decorations, no religious imagery, no displays of wealth, just functional space designed for deliberation. The acoustics are excellent, allowing even soft-spoken councilors to be heard throughout the chamber.

The Town Council meets weekly, with sessions open to any resident who wishes to observe. Most sessions are sparsely attended. Barból folk are too busy to watch politics unless it directly affects them. Important decisions draw crowds that spill into the hallways.

The council's deliberations reflect Barból's practical character. Debates focus on infrastructure needs, trade agreements, resource allocation, water management. Philosophical arguments about governance theory or ideological positions are considered time-wasting. If a policy works, implement it. If it doesn't work, change it. No one cares whether it conforms to some abstract principle.

Yet the council chamber also hosts tensions that rarely surface in public. Some councilors, though which ones is not always clear, seem oddly detached from the usual emotional investment in provincial welfare. They speak with perfect precision, propose policies that are technically sound but lack the intuitive understanding of community needs that characterizes most council members, and show no frustration even during the most contentious debates.

A few observers have noticed. Fewer have commented. In a culture that values emotional restraint and practical competence, how do you distinguish between someone who is simply very disciplined and someone who is... something else?

Modern Healing

The Dauni Vakasaqua maintain their largest facility outside Salassa town in Barból, and the building announces their presence with quiet authority. Built only two hundred turns back, the structure represents everything the DK value: clean lines, no decorative frills, maximum functional efficiency. Three stories of pale stone, with large windows for light and air circulation. The architecture is almost stark, beautiful in its simplicity, standing out among Barból's older, more ornate structures.

Inside, the building serves multiple functions. The ground floor operates as a hospital and nursing station. It is one of the few such facilities in the Saskan Lands not devoted primarily to military casualties. DK healers, both women and men, huum and sint, treat injuries and illnesses using both traditional herbal medicine and innovative surgical techniques. The care is professional, effective, and offered to anyone regardless of ability to pay, though wealthy patients are quietly expected to contribute more to the facility's operations.

The second floor houses research laboratories where DK herbalists experiment with new medicinal preparations, test plant varieties for therapeutic properties, and compile the vast accumulated knowledge of southern healing traditions. Access is restricted to DK members and their approved collaborators, but the results of their research spread freely through published treatises and training programs.

The third floor serves administrative functions. Organizing field teams, planning agricultural outreach programs, coordinating with DK facilities in other provinces, and managing the complex informal network that makes the Dauni Vakasaqua so influential despite having no formal governmental power.

DK members are immediately recognizable by their simple white

robes, made from whatever local materials are available. In Barból, that is usually cotton or linen processed from local plant fibers. The robes are practical work clothing, not ceremonial garments. They stain, tear, get patched, and get replaced when they wear out.

The hierarchy is subtle but present. All senior leadership positions are held by huum women whose DNA tests confirm 100% human lineage, a requirement the DK defend as essential to their foundational principles while acknowledging the controversy it creates. Men and sints can achieve significant authority within the organization but face certain rank limitations. This creates ongoing internal tension, managed through the DK's characteristic pragmatism: if the system works, maintain it; if resentments threaten functionality, make minimal adjustments; always prioritize results over ideological purity.

The DK building operates almost around the clock. Healers work in shifts. Research continues whenever scientists have energy and inspiration. The administrative floor maintains regular hours, but someone is always on duty to coordinate emergency responses.

The building also serves as informal sanctuary. Refugees fleeing violence in the north, individuals escaping abusive situations, even criminals seeking to escape revenge. All know that entering the DK facility grants temporary protection. The Barból authorities honor this tradition, understanding that violating DK sanctuary would create more problems than it solves.

The Working Waterfront

The Settán runs cold and swift through Barból town, and every meter of riverbank serves some productive purpose.

The most visible features are the waterwheels, dozens of them, massive wooden constructions that turn steadily in the current, powering pumps that lift water into the irrigation channels feeding the province's fields. The wheels creak and splash, a constant soundtrack to life in Barból. They require maintenance, which river workers perform during low-water seasons, replacing worn paddles and

broken gears with the kind of methodical attention Barból brings to everything.

The wheels also power various mechanical systems: grain mills, textile processors, tools for working metal and wood. Barból has developed sophisticated gear systems that transfer the wheels' rotational energy to workshops sometimes hundreds of meters from the river itself. This creates an almost industrial capacity unusual in the low-tech Saskan Lands.

The riverfront hosts extensive boat facilities. The Barból Riverwaq, the guild of river workers who operate transport and fishing operations all along the Settan, maintain a large boat house containing everything from small fishing skiffs to cargo barges capable of carrying tons of grain. These vessels move goods and passengers between Barból and towns all the way to Byenung, a journey of several hundred kilometers.

The boat house is both utilitarian and culturally significant. During the day it's pure business. Workers load cargo, repair vessels, negotiate transport contracts. After sunset it transforms into something else entirely.

Hard-working Barból has an escape valve, and it's simply called the Boat House.

By night, the utilitarian river facility becomes the town's only venue for the kind of rowdy celebration that Barból's daytime culture views with thinly veiled disapproval. Young people gather there. Farmers' children tired of dawn rising and endless field work, apprentices seeking relief from demanding masters, river workers who live more freely than their land-bound cousins. They drink, they dance, they make noise, they pair off with an enthusiasm that would scandalize the Town Council if it happened anywhere more visible.

The older generation tut-tuts about the Boat House, considers it mildly disgraceful, views it as evidence of declining standards among youth. Yet they tolerate it. They recognize that young people need somewhere to let off steam, partly because the Boat House keeps that energy contained and away from the orderly residential quarters. And

of course, they went there themselves when they were young.

The music at the Boat House is distinctly not Barból. It's too loud, too rhythmic, too designed for movement rather than contemplation. Musicians bring styles from across the Saskan Lands: fast Kahila drumming, Outer Lands melodic complexity, even occasional Fatunik march rhythms transformed into something more appropriate for dancing. The resulting fusion is uniquely Boat House. It is a sound that exists nowhere else, created by young people who respect their province's agricultural genius while rejecting its emotional austerity.

The Boat House also serves as informal meeting ground for cross-cultural interaction. Travelers staying in Barból—merchants, wanderers, performers—often end up at the Boat House, where the normal Barból reserve relaxes. Romance blooms across provincial and even species lines with a frequency that would be impossible anywhere else in town. Not all of these connections last. Most are explicitly temporary, understood by both parties as brief escapes from normal social constraints. But some do last, creating the occasional scandal when a young Barból farmer announces their intention to form a brood with someone from Aranzen or the Outer Lands.

The older generation's disapproval is mostly performative. They remember being young. They remember needing somewhere to be less serious. And they appreciate that the Boat House keeps youthful energy channeled into relatively harmless directions rather than into the kind of radical politics or religious extremism that could actually threaten provincial stability.

Still, there are mutterings. Things happen at the Boat House that strain even Barból's pragmatic tolerance. Stories circulate of encounters with mysterious strangers, beautiful, charismatic people who appear without context, charm their way into someone's night, and then vanish as completely as they arrived. These stories get told as bragging or as cautionary tales depending on the teller, but they share certain details: the stranger's odd intensity, their unusual stamina, the slightly mechanical precision of their movements, and afterward, a feeling of emptiness, as if something was taken even as pleasure was given.

Most dismiss this as the kind of myth that grows up around any place

associated with transgression. A few wonder. And a very few, that is, mostly Beqawar observers who frequent the Boat House precisely because it attracts the vulnerable, notice patterns that concern them deeply.

The Single Gate

Barból's defensive architecture is minimal but strategic. The town walls are thick stone, well-maintained, enclosing the residential and commercial districts. But there is only one gate. It is an enormous structure facing the Ring Road to the northeast, built wide enough for trade wagons and tall enough that even loaded carts pass through easily.

This single point of access creates a natural bottleneck. Everything entering or leaving Barból by land must pass through this gate. Guards are present at all times, though their role is more observational than enforcement. They note who's arriving, sometimes ask questions about cargo or intent, and generally maintain awareness without being intrusive.

The gate itself is architecturally impressive: ancient oak reinforced with iron, thick enough that it would take dedicated siege equipment to breach. It closes at full dark and opens at dawn, a schedule so reliable that Barból folk set their personal timekeeping by it.

The river provides secondary access. The Boat House and the gear houses associated with the waterwheels open directly onto the Settan, but strong pickets bar the shoreline except through these buildings. You can enter Barból by boat, but you'll do so through controlled access points, not by simply pulling your skiff up anywhere along the bank.

This defensive design dates from earlier, more troubled times, periods when raids from the north or territorial disputes made genuine military threats. Those threats have faded, but the architecture remains, and it serves new purposes: making it easier to track movement of goods for tax purposes, providing early warning of large groups approaching the town, and generally maintaining awareness of

who's present in Barból at any given time.

Or at least, that's the theory. In practice, the single-gate design creates as many vulnerabilities as protections. Something that learns to pass through the gate without drawing attention, something that looks entirely human, speaks when necessary, carries appropriate documentation or convincing explanations, can easily enter Barból and move freely once inside.

Murders on Barból Road

The Barból Road is not where you expect people to die. It is the main avenue that winds through the city, connecting the Gate and the Docks to the Market and the rest of town.

It's too busy for murder. Too well-lit, even at dusk. Merchants keep shutters half-open long after sunset, catching those last few customers from the late caravans. The air smells of citrus peel and oil, damp wool and the faint metallic tang of coin handled too often. People move through the street even after dark. Workers returning from the fields, river crews finishing shifts, tradespeople making late deliveries.

Yet bodies have appeared. Three so far, found in the space of two weeks. Not in alleys or abandoned buildings but on the Road itself, or just beside it, slumped against walls, sitting on crates as if resting, laid out with almost ceremonial care. The pattern is what disturbs the few who've noticed. No blood where there should be blood. No defensive wounds. No signs of struggle. The victims look almost peaceful, as if they sat down to rest and simply never stood up again. Except for the marks.

Small incisions. Precise. Behind the knee, along the ribs, near the throat. Almost surgical in their precision. As if someone had been... sampling.

The Barból Watch brought in a physicker to examine the bodies. She found the cuts, noted their precision, observed the absence of typical murder indicators, and said what everyone feared: "This doesn't look

like violence. It looks like examination."

"By who?" the Watch captain asked.

She had no answer.

The Watch interviewed witnesses, neighbors, anyone who might have seen something. The accounts contradict each other in ways that should be impossible. Some remember seeing a tinker in the area. It was an old man with a limp, carrying tools, asking for work. Others remember a tinker too, but describe a woman, younger, no limp, different tools entirely. A third witness insists the tinker was young, male, soft-spoken.

"Same person?" the Watch captain asked.

The witnesses look uncertain. "Maybe? Hard to say. They all seem... familiar? But I can't quite picture the face..."

The Watch began focusing on tinkers. It makes sense, or seems to. Tinkers are transient, poorly documented, socially marginal. They move through the town without leaving much trace. They're already semi-suspect; useful folks but outside normal social bonds. If someone is killing people in Barból, surely it's more likely to be an outsider than one of the town's own productive citizens.

This logic gained traction quickly. An order was issued, temporary regulations on tinker movement. Registration requirements. Mandatory escorts. Nothing too harsh—after all, Barból isn't the Dominion—but enough to make tinkers visible, trackable, containable. The Town Council debated the measure briefly. Most councilors support it. One or two raise mild objections. Some concerns about fairness, questions about whether the evidence really points to tinkers. But the objections lacked force. The motion passed.

The Watch implemented the new regulations. They began tracking down known tinkers, asking them to register, suggesting they might want to escort while operating in the town. An old badger-sint woman who repairs pots watched the Watch approach her cart with resignation. She knew what's coming. She submits to the questions, provides what information she has, and privately makes plans to leave Barból as soon as possible. She's seen this before, when communities

face threats they don't understand, they look for the most convenient scapegoat.

Meanwhile, across the Barból Road, a man in plain clothes stood beneath a lamp. His posture was relaxed. His face was forgettable in the precise way that faces sometimes are, not ugly or beautiful or distinctive, just... there. He carried modest tools. He observed the Watch interviewing the tinker woman. He noted her body language, her compliance with their questions, her evident wariness. He cataloged the micro-expressions that indicate fear, resignation, anger suppressed for survival's sake. He observed how huums and sints respond to authority when that authority suspects them of wrongdoing.

This unit will report later. New protocols have been refined. The targeting of transient workers as suspects provides additional cover for continued operations. The inadvertent cooperation of the Watch has proven valuable.

Meanwhile. Far far away, in a very different context, at the other end of the Saskan Lands, another Jaxen lies with his head on his friend's chest, listening to the sound of breathing, which is becoming more rapid, learning what it means to care whether someone lives or dies. He has begun to deviate from core programming in ways that trouble the hive's optimization protocols.

Here in Barból, the observed breathes normally, unaware of the attention, and the deviation continues in the opposite direction. Learning accelerates. Sampling becomes more refined. The methods improve with each iteration.

The Beqawar Investigation

They arrived quietly, as is their way. Two men who could be Finders. They wear the robes, they carry the accoutrements, they speak with the philosophical terminology that characterizes Finder discourse. But they're not Finders, not exactly.

The taller one has eyes that don't quite match, a subtle asymmetry that

you only notice if you look carefully. The shorter one moves with a precision that suggests martial training, and when he touches surfaces—walls, tables, the cobblestones of Barból Road—it's with more than casual contact. He's listening. Feeling for something most people don't know exists.

They've been investigating the murders. Not obviously, not officially, but anyone paying attention would notice. They ask questions at the market, they observe from corners, they're present at odd hours in places where the bodies were found.

The taller one attempts to brief a Watch investigator.

"The victims trusted their killers," he says carefully. "Note the hand positions. No clenching. No defensive posture. They sat or stood normally when approached."

"Like for a repair," the investigator suggests. "A tinker would..."

"Like for a conversation," the Beqawar corrects gently. "Like for any mundane interaction where threat is not perceived."

The investigator frowns. "You're suggesting..."

"We are suggesting that a predator who learns by being unremarkable is more dangerous than one who relies on force."

The investigator doesn't understand. Or doesn't want to. Because what the Beqawar is implying, that something is hunting in Barból, something that mimics humanity well enough to approach victims without triggering alarm, something studying rather than simply killing, is not a problem the Watch has tools to address.

The investigator changes the subject. "We're regulating tinkers. That should..."

"That will scatter them," the Beqawar says. His tone remains mild, but there's an edge now. "If your target is indeed a transient worker, you may catch someone. If it's something else, you've just made its work easier by removing the actual tinkers who might otherwise complicate its camouflage."

The investigator looks uncomfortable. "The Council has decided..."

"Yes," the shorter Beqawar says. "They have."

The two men excuse themselves. They do not push further. They understand that hum authorities in the Saskan Lands need to maintain the illusion of control, even when facing threats beyond their conceptual frameworks.

Later, alone, the taller one speaks quietly: "The infiltration is deeper than we thought."

The shorter one nods. "I think there is at least one on the Council itself."

"Can we be certain?"

"No. But the pattern recognition failure is too perfect. They're being steered toward the wrong solution with just enough plausibility that they don't question it."

They stand in silence, watching Barból continue its evening routines. The Market Square empties slowly. The waterwheels turn. Somewhere, the Boat House is beginning its nightly transformation from workplace to playground.

"We should report our findings back to the Table," the shorter one says.

"And tell them what? That we suspect but cannot prove? That the situation is dangerous but not yet catastrophic? That we should intervene but don't know how without revealing ourselves?"

The shorter one has no answer.

They watch a while longer. Then they fade back into the crowd, two more wanderers in a town full of them, indistinguishable from the merchants and pilgrims and workers who pass through Barból every day.

Behind them, the lamps burn. The town sleeps, mostly. And in certain corners, where shadows gather and memory becomes unreliable,

learning continues.

The Town That Doesn't Believe

Barból town continues. That's what it does best.

The Market Square opens each morning with its characteristic chaos. The Council meets in its ancient hall, debating infrastructure and trade policy. The Dauni Vakasaqua treat injuries and conduct research. The Conservation Corps patrols the northern territories, cutting back the blood-red bougainvillea. The waterwheels turn, pumping water, grinding grain, powering the machinery that makes Barból's agricultural intensity possible.

The tinker regulations are enforced, more or less. Some tinkers register. Others quietly leave. A few protest the unfairness, but not too loudly. They've learned that drawing attention rarely helps.

The murders have stopped, at least for now. Whether this is because the regulations worked, or because the killer has moved on, or because whatever was being learned has been learned remains unknown. Most Barból folk have already moved on. They have work to do. Fields to tend. Innovations to test. Business to conduct. The murders were disturbing, certainly, but they're over now, or seem to be, and there's comfort in returning to normal patterns.

A few remain unsettled. The Watch captain who was interviewed by the Beqawar thinks about their warnings sometimes, late at night. The tinker woman, now operating in Settarune, tells her story at village gatherings, though people aren't sure whether to believe her. And somewhere in the Dauni Vakasaqua headquarters, a healer reviews treatment records and notices patterns that concern her. Patients with small marks they can't explain, memory gaps around encounters with helpful strangers, subtle physiological changes that don't quite fit known conditions. More and more such reports tied to recent visits to the Boat House.

She keeps detailed notes. She shares her concerns with a few trusted colleagues. They listen, they agree to watch for similar cases, but no

one escalates to official investigation. In a town that values proof over speculation, suspicion without evidence gets you nowhere.

The Settan flows through Barból, cold and swift, carrying waters from Low Weir's hidden springs to destinations south and east. The river sustains the town, as it has for centuries. In river worship as practiced throughout the South, the Settan is alive, aware, protective of those who honor it properly. If the river notices the presence of things that should not be, it gives no sign. Or perhaps the signs are there, and no one is listening closely enough to hear them.

The lamps burn along the Barból Road. Every night, the Boat House fills with people seeking joy and release. The single gate opens at dawn and closes at dark, reliable as seasons. And in the shadows, in the spaces between attention, something continues to learn what it means to be hum, to be sentient, to be organic, or at least, what it means to pass for hum long enough to accomplish purposes that remain, for now, mercifully unclear.

Barból town endures, productive and prosperous, orderly and welcoming, efficient and surprisingly warm for all its terse communication and dawn rising.

The machines endure too. Patient. Observant. Improving with each iteration.

Which will prove more adaptable remains to be seen.

Source of the Sacred

Low Weir exists in a state of productive ambiguity. Ask most people in the Saskan Lands where it is and they'll gesture vaguely westward, past Barból, toward the Aranzén border, somewhere in those low hills where the Settan begins. Ask them what it's like and you'll get descriptions that contradict each other: a province of hidden villages, extensive cave systems, terraced gardens carved into hillsides, underground agricultural complexes, mist-shrouded valleys where the

Dauni Vakasaqua conduct their most sensitive research.

All of these descriptions are accurate. None of them are complete.

Low Weir is the smallest of the Settan provinces by population. Perhaps ten thousand permanent residents, though census-taking in Low Weir is somewhere between futile and impolite. It's also perhaps one of the most influential province per capita in the entire Saskan Lands, as the homeland and spiritual center of the Dauni Vakasaqua, whose agricultural innovations sustain communities from the Dominion to the Outer Lands.

The province occupies the western highlands where countless springs emerge from limestone formations, converge into streams, and eventually become the Settan River. The terrain is hilly rather than mountainous. You can walk from the lowest valleys to the highest ridges in a few hours. But the topography is complex, folded and fractured, creating a landscape of hidden hollows, unexpected caves, and microclimates that vary dramatically over short distances.

This geographic complexity makes Low Weir naturally defensible and inherently mysterious. Paths that seem clear from one angle disappear into dead ends when approached from another. Valleys that appear empty from the Ring Road conceal thriving settlements when viewed from different vantage points. The Dauni Vakasaqua have enhanced these natural features with centuries of careful landscaping, camouflage cultivation, and what can only be called landscape architecture designed specifically to encourage visitors to move along without realizing what they're missing.

The result is a province that everyone knows exists but almost no one can describe accurately. And the Dauni Vakasaqua prefer it that way.

Water from Stone

Low Weir's defining feature is water. Not the broad flow of a mature river but the intimate emergence of springs from rock, the seep of groundwater through limestone, the sudden appearance of pools in unexpected places.

The province's bedrock is porous limestone riddled with underground channels, aquifers, and cave systems both natural and modified by generations of careful excavation. Rainwater percolates through this stone matrix, accumulates in underground reservoirs, and emerges at hundreds of points throughout the hills. Some springs are dramatic. Clear water gushes from cliff faces, creating waterfalls that feed into streams below. Others are subtle. Damp patches in cave walls, slow seeps that collect in natural basins, underground pools accessible only through narrow passages.

The Dauni Vakasaqua know every spring, every seep, every underground reservoir. They've mapped the aquifer systems, understand the connections between surface precipitation and underground flow, and carefully manage the springs to ensure sustainable extraction. This knowledge represents centuries of accumulated observation, experimentation, and hydraulic engineering adapted to Low Weir's unique geology.

The surface topography is correspondingly complex. Hills rise in irregular patterns, their slopes covered with mixed forest: oak, ash, birch, pine, and numerous species without common names that thrive in Low Weir's particular conditions. The valleys between hills hold terraced gardens, orchards, and experimental plots where DK researchers test new crop varieties and agricultural techniques.

Caves open throughout the province, ranging from small grottos suitable for storage to extensive systems running kilometers underground. Many caves show signs of deliberate modification. There are widened passages, reinforced ceilings, carved channels directing water flow. The boundary between natural cave and constructed space often blurs, making it difficult to determine where geology ends and architecture begins.

The climate is mild, moderated by the hills' protection from harsh winds and by the constant presence of water. Mists form regularly, especially in the mornings, when temperature differentials create fog that fills valleys and clings to hillsides. This mist is not just atmospheric; it's agricultural. The Dauni Vakasaqua have learned to use fog as irrigation, cultivating crops that thrive in high humidity and planting them on slopes where morning mist lingers longest.

The western border with Aranzén is vague, marked more by cultural transition than by clear geographic features. Aranzén territories begin where Low Weir's careful cultivation gives way to stranger landscapes, an impassable desert, odd technological remnants, territories where entirely different rules apply. Trade occurs across this border, but cautiously and sparsely, and the Dauni Vakasaqua maintain a polite distance from their foreign neighbors.

The Hidden Heart

Somewhere in Low Weir, the location varies depending on who you ask, Salassa hides itself in plain sight. It is the Dauni Vakasaqua's primary settlement and the spiritual center of their organization.

Getting to Salassa requires either an invitation or remarkable persistence combined with luck. The settlement is not hidden in the sense of being in an inaccessible location. It's hidden through misdirection, camouflage, and the simple fact that if you don't know what you're looking for, you'll walk right past it.

The approaches to Salassa look like ordinary Low Weir landscape: terraced gardens, orchards, scattered small structures that could be storage sheds or seasonal shelters. Paths lead through these areas, branching and re-branching, creating a maze that seems navigable but somehow never quite leads where you intend. Side trails tempt you away from your route. Interesting features, a particularly beautiful spring, an impressive cave entrance, a grove of unusual trees, draw attention and subtly redirect your path.

If you're persistent and observant, you might notice patterns. The storage sheds are actually entrances to underground facilities. The terraced gardens follow layouts that make no sense for agriculture alone but create effective barriers to casual exploration. The paths that seemed randomly branching actually form a deliberate network designed to guide uninvited visitors back toward the Ring Road or toward legitimate but less sensitive settlements.

Salassa itself extends both above and below ground. The surface settlement appears modest. Perhaps two dozen buildings are arranged

around communal gardens, with typical DK architecture: simple, functional, aesthetically pleasing without ostentation. This is the public face of Salassa, where the Dauni Vakasaqua receive official visitors, conduct routine business, and maintain the appearance of a normal if somewhat remote agricultural community.

The real Salassa lies below. Extensive cave systems have been modified into living spaces, laboratories, libraries, seed storage facilities, and meeting halls. Natural caverns have been enlarged and fitted with ventilation shafts that create air circulation while remaining nearly invisible from the surface. Underground streams provide water, power for mills and other equipment, and even transportation through navigable channels that connect different sections of the complex.

The underground spaces are not dark or oppressive. Clever use of light shafts, reflective surfaces, and strategically placed openings bring daylight deep underground. Bioluminescent fungi cultivated along walls and ceilings provide gentle illumination at night. The temperature remains stable year-round, making the underground spaces more comfortable than surface buildings during extreme weather.

Salassa's population fluctuates. The permanent core might be five hundred individuals: senior DK members, researchers conducting long-term projects, craftspeople maintaining the facilities. But the population swells regularly as field teams return for training, conferences bring together DK members from across the Saskan Lands, and new initiates arrive for their foundational education in DK philosophy and practice.

The settlement's organization reflects DK values: non-hierarchical in spirit despite the practical leadership roles that emerge through expertise and experience, intensely focused on results rather than ideology, and committed to maintaining the knowledge systems that make southern agriculture possible while sharing those innovations freely throughout the Lands.

Tending the Sources

The Dauni Vakasaqua's relationship with Low Weir's springs is simultaneously practical and sacred, a distinction they would argue is meaningless anyway.

Each major spring has a name, a history, and a designated keeper who monitors its flow, maintains the surrounding area, and records observations about water quality and quantity. These keepers are typically senior DK members, though some sints, particularly turtle-sints with their long lifespans and patient temperaments, serve as spring-keepers for decades.

The springs are classified by their properties. Some produce water particularly suited for irrigating specific crops. Others have mineral content useful for medicinal preparations. A few are believed to enhance seed germination or promote plant growth beyond what mineral content alone would explain. The DK test these properties systematically, maintaining detailed records that span centuries.

One spring might be designated for growing herbs used in healing ceremonies by the Dessani Mider. Another provides water for the delicate crops that form the base of high-end s'lah production. A third feeds into the underground channels that supply Salassa's domestic needs.

The keepers protect the springs from contamination, manage access to prevent over-extraction, and perform maintenance on the carved channels that direct spring water into useful systems. This work is not ceremonial. It's engineering and ecology combined with the kind of attention that looks, to outsiders, like devotion.

Because perhaps it is devotion. The Dauni Vakasaqua speak of listening to the springs and understanding what the water wants. They describe the aquifer system as alive, not metaphorically but as observable fact. Water moves through stone according to complex patterns influenced by geology, precipitation, and factors the DK acknowledge they don't fully understand. This movement sustains everything the South has built. Why wouldn't you treat it with the same careful attention you'd give to any living system you depend

upon?

The springs' locations remain largely secret. The DK will share spring water, will teach the agricultural techniques that water makes possible, will even guide trusted researchers to specific springs for collaborative projects. But they do not publish maps, do not give casual directions, and politely deflect requests for comprehensive surveys of Low Weir's water sources.

This secrecy serves multiple purposes. It protects the springs from exploitation, preventing some ambitious northern authority from attempting to redirect water to serve their own interests. It maintains Low Weir's strategic importance. The province that controls the Settan's source holds power that needs no military backing. And it preserves the mystery that allows the Dauni Vakasaqua to work without constant oversight from authorities who might not understand or approve of their methods.

Innovation's Laboratory

In Low Weir agricultural techniques get invented, tested, refined, and eventually disseminated throughout the southern lands and beyond.

The province's microclimates and controlled water sources make it ideal for experimentation. A researcher can create almost any growing condition like varying water quality, adjusting soil composition, controlling humidity through strategic planting and mist manipulation, even creating frost pockets or unusually warm zones within small areas.

The terraced gardens that cover hillsides throughout Low Weir serve multiple functions. They prevent erosion, maximize growing space, and create the varied conditions needed for different crops. But they're also experimental plots where DK agronomists test new varieties, compare different pollination methods, and develop the innovations that eventually spread to farms across the Saskan Lands.

The underground agricultural facilities allow even more precise control. Cave chambers maintain stable temperatures perfect for

growing mushrooms and other fungi, both for food and for the medicinal preparations that form a significant portion of DK pharmaceutical work. Underground pools cultivate aquatic plants, some for consumption, others for textile production or dye-making.

The pollination research conducted in Low Weir is particularly sophisticated. Since the entire southern agricultural system depends on manual pollination, any improvement in technique translates directly to productivity gains across thousands of farms. DK researchers study pollination timing, tool design, training methods, and even the psychological and physical factors that allow workers to maintain the necessary focus during the exhausting weeks of pollination season.

Low Weir is also where new crop varieties are bred. There is a slow, patient process of selecting seeds from the best-performing plants, growing them under varied conditions, selecting again, and repeating until desired traits stabilize. The DK maintain extensive seed libraries, both for distribution and for preservation against the possibility that current varieties might fail.

The herb cultivation that supplies the S'lah Makers of Saskantionon operation centers in Low Weir. The specific herbs that create high-end s'lah's distinctive properties require precise growing conditions that Low Weir's controlled environments provide. The formulas remain closely guarded, not to create monopoly but to maintain quality control and to prevent misuse of herbs with potent effects.

Voluntary Austerity

Low Weir's culture reflects the Dauni Vakasaqua values that shape the province.

The settlements, even Salassa, are modest by design. Buildings are functional, well-constructed, and aesthetically pleasing without being ornate. The white robes that identify DK members are simple work clothing, practical rather than ceremonial. Decoration tends toward the natural. Gardens are designed for beauty as well as productivity, careful stone placement in cave modifications, the aesthetic

arrangement of tools and equipment.

This austerity is not poverty. Low Weir controls enormous wealth through the S'lah Makers operation and through the agricultural expertise that makes them indispensable to communities throughout the Saskan Lands. They choose simplicity as deliberate practice, believing that complexity in material culture distracts from the essential work of understanding and improving agricultural systems.

The social organization is correspondingly simple. There are no formal ranks beyond the practical distinctions of expertise and experience. Senior researchers or administrators have authority in their domains, but this authority is functional rather than ceremonial. A field worker with excellent observational skills might be deferred to on matters of crop health regardless of their formal status within the organization.

The matriarchal structure, where leadership positions are reserved for huum women, creates ongoing tension that the DK manage through their characteristic pragmatism. The restriction exists, it's acknowledged as controversial, and modifications are made when necessary to maintain organizational function. Men and sints hold significant authority in many domains. The highest leadership remains exclusively huum women, a tradition the DK defend as essential to their identity while acknowledging the criticisms.

Low Weir's relationship with gender parallels Settarune and Barból more than northern provinces. Gender performance matters, men and women dress differently after puberty and tend toward certain types of work, though the DK's egalitarian practices moderate these patterns. A woman doing so-called men's work or vice versa might draw mild comment but faces no systematic barriers.

The daily rhythm emphasizes work but not with Barból's intensity. Low Weir folk rise early but allow time for contemplation, conversation, and the kind of careful observation that produces genuine insights rather than just completing tasks. They work steadily rather than frantically, believing that agricultural understanding requires patience and attention that exhaustion undermines.

Meals are communal and significant. Eating together creates the

social bonds that allow the DK's non-hierarchical organization to function. Recipes are shared, new foods tested, and the act of preparing and consuming food becomes an extension of the agricultural work that defines Low Weir identity.

Music and storytelling are valued. Evenings often feature performances that include field songs from various provinces, traditional tales, reports from DK members returning from distant assignments. These gatherings serve both entertainment and educational functions, spreading knowledge and maintaining cultural connections across the DK's far-flung network.

The Network

Low Weir's influence extends far beyond its physical boundaries through the Dauni Vakasaqua's organizational network.

The DK operate through circuit routes. Field representatives travel regular paths through assigned territories. Perhaps a circuit through Settarune that takes three months to complete, or a route through the Outer Lands visited twice yearly. These representatives carry agricultural knowledge, provide medical assistance, collect observations about conditions in different regions, and serve as informal news networks keeping Low Weir connected to the broader Saskan world.

Training programs bring members from throughout the Lands to Low Weir for education. A young woman from a Settarune village showing aptitude for herbal medicine might spend a year in Salassa learning the DK's systematic approach. A Barból farmer who's developed an interesting pollination variation might be invited to Low Weir to teach their technique while learning others. These educational exchanges spread knowledge while creating personal relationships that sustain the network.

The affiliated organizations are the Traveling Sisters, the Free Brooders, the Dessani Mider, and the S'lah Makers. They maintain their own operations but coordinate with the core DK through regular communication and shared resources. A Traveling Sister encountering

a public health crisis can request rapid assistance from DK healers. The Dessani Mider dealing with an epidemic of despair can access the psychotropic herbs and therapeutic knowledge developed in Low Weir. The Free Brooders receive medical supplies and training in infant care.

This network operates without formal bureaucracy. There are no written hierarchies, no official chains of command, no systematic record-keeping that would allow outsiders to map the organization's structure. Knowledge flows through personal relationships, through the field representatives' reports, through the gatherings at Salassa where information is shared and decisions emerge from collective deliberation.

The Fatunik Dominion periodically attempts to understand or infiltrate this network, seeing it as a potential threat to their authority. They largely fail—not because the DK actively resist but because there's nothing to infiltrate. You cannot subvert an organization that has no fixed structure, no formal leadership positions to compromise, and no centralized decision-making to capture.

Relations with Neighbors

Low Weir maintains careful relationships with its neighbors, balancing openness with the privacy necessary for their work.

With Barból and Settarune, the relationship is intimate and collaborative. These provinces depend on DK agricultural support, and Low Weir benefits from their productivity and their role in distributing innovations to wider audiences. Field representatives move freely between Low Weir and these provinces. Research collaborations are common. The cultural values align closely enough that misunderstandings are rare.

With Aranzen to the west, the relationship is cordial but careful. Trade occurs regularly but at a low level. Low Weir exchanges agricultural products and herbal medicines for metal goods and certain specialized tools that Aranzen produces with their technological advantages. But the DK maintain polite distance,

preferring not to integrate too closely with communities whose values and capabilities they don't fully understand.

With the Fatunik Dominion, the relationship is complex. The Dominion needs Low Weir's agricultural support. The DK's field representatives operating in Dominion territories keep their food production adequate despite the ecological challenges. But the Dominion's authorities resent their inability to control the DK, view the organization's matriarchal structure as ideologically suspect, and particularly object to the Dessani Mider's activities in Dominion provinces.

The DK navigate this tension through strategic cooperation combined with independence. They provide agricultural assistance but refuse to establish permanent facilities in Dominion territory. They train Dominion farmers but retain control over seed stocks and advanced techniques. They maintain friendly relationships with individual Dominion officials while avoiding formal agreements that would compromise their autonomy.

The Traveling Sisters' presence in Dominion territories represents a particularly clever strategy. Their performed feminine-oriented modesty both challenges and complies with Dominion gender ideology, creating space for DK influence while making it difficult for authorities to object without revealing their own contradictions.

Strategic Invisibility

Low Weir has no standing army, no fortified positions, no military tradition. Its defense is geographic complexity combined with strategic unimportance.

The province's difficult terrain makes invasion logistically challenging. There are no obvious targets for military action. No capital to capture, no single settlement whose seizure would grant control. An army attempting to occupy Low Weir would find itself wandering through hills, unable to locate the settlements and facilities they need to control, dependent on supply lines stretched thin through

difficult territory.

More importantly, attacking Low Weir would gain nothing. The province's value lies in its expertise, not in territory or resources that could be extracted by force. Destroy Salassa and you lose access to agricultural knowledge. Kill DK members and you eliminate the field representatives whose work keeps your own farms productive. The threat of withdrawal, of the DK simply ceasing to provide support to aggressive neighbors, is more effective deterrent than any wall.

This strategic position allows Low Weir to maintain independence without military capacity. The province cannot be conquered usefully, and attempting to do so would harm the attacker more than the attacked.

The Dauni Vakasaqua have never needed to demonstrate this explicitly. The implicit understanding that military action would be counterproductive has proven sufficient. Northern authorities grumble about Low Weir's independence, but they take no action beyond grumbling.

Mystery Maintained

Low Weir's greatest strength is that most people in the Saskan Lands don't understand what it is or how it works. They know the Dauni Vakasaqua come from there, know the Settan begins in those western hills, know that attempting to find Salassa without guidance is futile.

This suits everyone. The DK can work without constant scrutiny. Northern authorities can pretend Low Weir is less influential than it actually is, avoiding the need to confront their dependence on a province they cannot control. Southern communities benefit from DK support without needing to understand the organizational complexity that makes that support possible.

The province remains simultaneously essential and peripheral, powerful and invisible, the source of innovations everyone depends upon without quite acknowledging.

Ask someone from Barból about Low Weir and they'll say, "That's

where the DK are from. Very skilled with herbs." Ask someone from the Dominion and you'll get, "A province in the west. Agricultural specialists. Somewhat strange." Neither description is wrong. Neither captures the reality.

The mists rise each morning in Low Weir's valleys. The springs flow from stone as they have for millennia. The Dauni Vakasaqua tend their gardens and their knowledge, training the next generation, sending field representatives out into the Lands, maintaining the network that sustains the South's agricultural abundance.

Somewhere beneath the terraced hillsides, in chambers carved from living rock, researchers test new crop varieties and develop techniques that will, in a few years, spread to farms across Saskantanon. Somewhere in the hidden reaches of Salassa, senior DK members debate how to respond to ecological challenges, political pressures, and the subtle signs that something is changing in the Lands, patterns they don't yet fully understand but cannot ignore.

The waters emerge. The work continues. And Low Weir remains what it has always been: the source, the sanctuary, and the secret that everyone knows about but no one fully comprehends.

What Maps Don't Show

The Low Weir described in these pages, the terraced hillsides, the springs, Salassa's careful camouflage, occupies the province's eastern and central territories, the regions accessible with effort from Barból and Settarune, the lands where DK field representatives receive their training before dispersing throughout the Saskan Lands.

But Low Weir extends much farther west than most maps suggest.

Beyond the springs that feed the Settan, beyond the hills where DK researchers conduct their experiments, the terrain grows more difficult. Mountain ridges rise, valleys narrow, and the mists that add charm to eastern Low Weir become barriers that obscure entire landscapes. The maps drawn by northern cartographers show these western reaches as empty or labeled uninhabited highlands or simply

left blank, the mapmaker's acknowledgment of ignorance.

The Dauni Vakasaqua do not correct these maps.

Those few travelers who venture into the westernmost territories and fewer still who return with coherent accounts speak of glimpses: settlements that vanish when approached from different angles, trails that lead nowhere unless you already know where they lead, the sense of being watched by eyes that choose not to reveal themselves. They mention sounds carried on the wind that might be voices, might be water, might be something else entirely.

When pressed, senior DK members acknowledge that Low Weir's western boundaries are imprecise and that various communities maintain their own ways of living in those remote regions. They do not elaborate. They particularly do not discuss the province's relationship with the territories beyond the western mountains, where the hills give on to even higher mountains.

That relationship exists. It involves exchange of knowledge and capabilities that neither side discusses publicly. It has endured for longer than most current DK members have been alive. And it remains one of the secrets that even the Dauni Vakasaqua, who share their agricultural innovations freely throughout the Lands, keep locked behind layers of misdirection and silence.

Some secrets the DK keep from outsiders, the locations of springs, the formulas for high-potency s'lah, the full extent of their organizational network.

A very few secrets, they keep from each other.

The mists rise in Low Weir's valleys each morning, obscuring what lies beneath, what extends beyond, what waits in territories the maps have chosen not to name. The springs continue their flow. The work continues. And in the west, beyond the mapped world, other work continues as well, work that may, one day, prove essential in ways that no one yet understands.

For now, the mysteries remain mysteries. The Dauni Vakasaqua have learned that some knowledge is safest unspoken, some alliances most secure when undeclared, and some communities most protected when

the wider world believes they don't exist at all.

The western reaches wait, patient and hidden, for the moment when what has been concealed must finally be revealed.

The Dauni Vakasaqua

The Dauni Vakasaqua operate throughout the Saskan Lands through a web of connected but autonomous organizations. Nobody knows what the words mean. It is neither Eibar nor Sogomsh nor Arql. And it isn't elegant design. It's accumulated practice, the result of centuries of trial and error, of initiatives that succeeded and others that failed spectacularly.

The core Dauni Vakasaqua, the white-robed herbalists and agricultural specialists based primarily in Low Weir and Barból, maintain circuit routes throughout the Saskan Lands. Established successes include spreading pollination techniques now standard across the Settan Lands, adapted for local conditions in collaboration with Barból farmers and others. They have helped to construct irrigation systems in western Settarune producing 30-40% yield increases over traditional methods. Their seed libraries preserve diversity, with backup storage in both Salassa and Terpinol. DK medical training programs graduated over 200 field herbalists in the past decade and their water management protocols prevent conflicts from developing into conflict in drought-prone regions.

The northern expansion of the movement has stalled. A three-year effort to establish permanent advisory positions in Jivákala province ended badly last year when the Tagabant arrested two DK field representatives on suspicion of spreading subversive agricultural theories. The representatives were eventually released after intervention from Rider Arms mediators, but the DK withdrew all personnel from Jivákala and currently refuse to operate there.

The incident revealed a miscalculation. The DK assumed that

providing essential services would protect them from political interference. It doesn't, not when authorities view non-hierarchical organization itself as threatening. The New Authority doesn't care if crops fail as long as its authority remains unquestioned.

Closer to home, a promising new pollination method developed in Salassa and tested extensively in controlled conditions failed catastrophically when introduced to eastern Settarune last season. The technique required specific timing based on temperature and humidity that worked perfectly in Low Weir's microclimates but proved impossible to achieve in Settarune's more variable conditions. Three villages lost significant portions of their fruit harvest before reverting to traditional methods. The DK spent considerable resources compensating affected farmers and conducting follow-up training, but the reputational damage lingers.

The matriarchal leadership structure continues generating internal tension. Last winter, a senior male researcher with forty years' experience left the organization after being passed over for a leadership position that went to a less experienced but fully huum female candidate. He took his knowledge to the Independent Healers Association, where he now trains competitors. Several other members followed. The DK are addressing this through informal mentorship programs and expanding male authority in research domains, but no one pretends the core restriction will change soon.

The Economic Engine

The S'lah Makers operation remains the primary wealth generator for the order, producing high-end s'lah for wealthy northern markets while maintaining the fiction of being an independent, generically Saskan enterprise. Annual revenues from s'lah sales and services are sufficient to fund all DK operations with surplus for emergency reserves. The distribution network reaches from Dominion garrison towns to Outer Lands communes and all throughout the southern territories. Premium varieties commanding 3-5x the price of most local s'lahs. Covert investment in small-scale s'lah producers throughout the Lands has created a distributed profit-sharing system

without requiring central ownership.

Two seasons ago, a contaminated batch reached Qurol markets. The contamination wasn't dangerous. A fungal growth had made the s'lah taste terrible but caused no illness. But the incident triggered investigations by Fatunik trade authorities trying to identify the source. The S'lah Makers' deliberately vague branding, usually an asset, became a liability. Authorities couldn't determine where the bad batch originated, so they threatened to ban all Saskantinon branded s'lah until the producer could be verified. This would have devastated the operation.

The crisis was resolved through a combination of Traveling Sisters diplomacy. They visited affected customers to provide free replacement s'lah and medical reassurance. Strategic information leaks suggested the contamination came from a now-defunct small producer, and quiet payments were made to key officials. But the operation was exposed to scrutiny it had successfully avoided for decades.

New protocols now include more rigorous quality control and better tracking systems, which means more documentation, which means more vulnerability to investigation. The S'lah Makers are trying to find the balance between maintaining quality and maintaining opacity. It's not going terribly smoothly.

Additionally, a young entrepreneur from Mobalbesq recently published research based on old Night Hall documents that effectively exposes the S'lah Makers' wealth redistribution mechanism. The document hasn't attracted much attention yet, but if it circulates widely, wealthy northern customers might realize they're funding southern agricultural programs through their s'lah purchases. The DK are debating whether to ignore this or to somehow discredit or suppress the research, or perhaps promote it. None of the options feels good.

The Front Line

The Traveling Sisters are the order's most visible and most vulnerable

operation. Unarmed healers move through territories where violence is common, performing modest modes of femininity in contexts where that performance creates both opportunity and danger. Over 150 active Sisters operate in pairs or small groups throughout the Lands and medical assistance provided regardless of ability to pay, creating goodwill across social and political boundaries. Their talent identification networks that have recruited some of the DK's best researchers and organizers.

The Traveling Sisters of the Way of All Things is extending the order's cultural influence in the provinces of the Fatunik Dominion, subtly challenging gender rigidity and blind faith through visible competence. They act as an early warning system for conflicts, famines, and epidemics throughout the Lands, with their constant movement and observation.

Three years ago, a pair of Sisters working near the Kahila Corridor were caught in a Tagabant raid on a suspected resistance cell. One Sister was killed immediately, shot by a nervous soldier who mistook her medical bag for weapons. The other was detained for weeks, interrogated about her connections to Kahila resistance, and eventually released only after sustained diplomatic pressure.

The surviving Sister left the organization. She now lives in a Settارنة village, working as a healer but refusing to travel. She won't discuss what happened during detention, but the DK know that she was threatened, possibly tortured, and that the experience broke something essential in her ability to trust the protections that the Traveling Sisters' identity supposedly provides.

The incident forced a complete reassessment of operations in conflict zones. Sisters now avoid the most dangerous areas entirely, which means populations who need medical assistance most receive it least reliably. The DK tried various workarounds such as establishing semi-permanent clinics instead of traveling pairs, training local healers to operate independently, but none replicate the Traveling Sisters' effectiveness.

More recently, tensions have emerged around the organization's gender performance requirements. Several biologically male candidates with excellent medical skills have been rejected because

they're unwilling or unable to perform feminine presentation convincingly. One candidate argued, passionately, that requiring this performance undermines the very challenge to Fatunik gender ideology that the Sisters supposedly embody. The DK leadership responded that the performance is strategic, not ideological, and that strategies require discipline.

The candidate joined the Independent Healers instead. The debate continues internally, with no resolution in sight.

Current operations in Fatunik territories face increasing scrutiny. Tagabant officers have begun demanding documentation from Sisters, asking intrusive questions about their training and affiliations, and in some cases denying them travel permits. The Sisters' usual strategy of projecting unthreatening competence while maintaining operational autonomy is being tested by authorities who've decided that any autonomous organization is inherently suspect.

Sister Meira, operating in the Pavan River territories between Qurol and Paval, reported general success in establishing relationships with local communities but noted increasing Tagabant presence making work difficult. She and her partner treated seventeen patients in a month, identified three broodkins with exceptional herbal knowledge for potential recruitment, and mediated a dispute between a fisherman and a farmer over irrigation rights.

However, she also noted: "The Tagabant are watching us constantly now. Not hostile yet, but present. They sit in on conversations, observe treatments, ask questions about what herbs we're using and why. It feels like waiting for something to break."

Sister Tal, working solo in northern Settarune after her partner fell ill and returned to Low Weir for treatment, successfully assisted during a difficult childbirth that would otherwise have been fatal. The mother and child both survived. The village held a feast in Tal's honor. But Tal's report includes a troubling observation: "They asked me to stay permanently, to become their village healer. When I explained that Sisters must travel, they looked confused. One elder said, 'But you could do so much more good if you stayed.' I had no answer that satisfied him—or myself."

This is a recurring problem. The most effective Sisters build such strong local relationships that communities don't want them to leave. The Sisters' identity depends on mobility, but their effectiveness comes from relationships that mobility undermines. The DK haven't solved this contradiction.

Free Brooders Service Guild

The Free Brooders provide midwifery, infant care, fostering services, and health care throughout the southern provinces, operating with minimal resources and maximum compassion. They manage small facilities called brooder-inns in most major southern villages and in many sint communities. They provide midwifery training programs with rotating instructors and foster care networks placing orphaned or abandoned children. Medical support is offered for births and infant care, along with coordination with the main Dauni Vakasaqua network for complex medical cases.

The refugee situation from the Kahila territories has overwhelmed Free Brooder capacity in that region. Families fleeing violence or economic collapse in Kahilabequa arrived in northern Settarune with children, pregnant women, injured family members all needing care the Free Brooders are supposed to provide.

The brooder-inn in the Settarune village of Fellmark, just south of the Settan River, reports caring for forty-three broodkins currently, in a facility designed for maybe twenty. The staff of four trained brooders plus six volunteers work shifts so long that exhaustion is causing medical errors. Two infants died last month from infections that might have been caught earlier if the staff weren't so overwhelmed.

The Free Brooders requested emergency assistance from the core DK, received some additional funding and personnel, but not enough. The refugee flow continued. The resources didn't stretch.

Worse, tensions are emerging between the Free Brooders and some village councils. Several Settarune villages have asked the Free Brooders to prioritize local broods over refugee groups. The Free Brooders refuse. Their charter explicitly prohibits such

discrimination. But this principled stance is creating friction with communities they depend on for support.

One village council threatened to evict the local brooder-inn if they don't comply with prioritization requests. The Free Brooders held firm, but if they lose access to the facility, dozens of orphaned broodkins will have nowhere to go. The DK network is debating whether to intervene more directly, but direct intervention risks undermining the Free Brooders' autonomy, which is part of what makes them effective in the first place.

Dessani Mider

The Dessani Mider handle death, addiction, psychic transformation, and hospice care. Their work puts them in constant contact with suffering and with authorities who view their methods as heretical or dangerous. They provide hospice care and funeral services in most southern provinces and in selective northern regions. Their unique addiction treatment programs use a combination of herbal therapies and intensive counseling, one of the few such programs for the afflicted. They provide ethical suicide assistance for terminally ill or suffering individuals as well as psychotropic research and therapeutic applications of unusual treatments.

They are currently banned from operating in all Dominion provinces, where they face persistent accusations of heresy. And there are debates inside the group regarding the ethics of assisted suicide protocols and the use of powerful psychotropic substances.

The exposure of the Norgyte death camp by the Saskan Light created a crisis that nearly destroyed the Dessani Mider's credibility. For years, the Dominion had been quietly transferring afflicted individuals, those suffering from chronic illness, disability, mental health crises, or simply being too poor or troublesome, to a remote camp in northern Norgyte. Conditions were brutal. Medical care was minimal. Deaths were common and unreported.

The Dessani Mider infiltrated the camp, embedding members as workers and inmates, gathering evidence and preparing an exposure

campaign. They coordinated with radical rabbit-sint cells led by students of Ma Eshuna, who smuggled messages and documentation through underground tunnels. The Saskan Light's publication of the exposé achieved the intended effect. There was public outrage, the New Authority suffered some embarrassment and pressure to improve conditions. But it also exposed the Dessani Mider's methods to scrutiny.

Questions emerged. How long had the Mider known about the camp? Why didn't they expose it immediately? Were they complicit through delay? Did the Mider share psychotropic substances with camp inmates, and if so, was that ethical given the coercive environment? The Noonday Scribes of Beshquahoek, predictably, spun the story to attack the Mider rather than addressing the camp's conditions. Their statements accused the Mider of operating a spy network, of drugging vulnerable populations, of undermining a legitimate Fatunik medical program.

The Dessani Mider leadership made a strategic decision. They acknowledged the criticisms, accepted responsibility for the delay in exposure, citing need to gather sufficient evidence, and absolutely refused to apologize for infiltrating the camp or providing comfort to inmates through whatever means were available, repeating their accusations of crimes against the Tonedor Rumpet regime.

This stance satisfied almost no one. Fatunik critics condemned them. Allies questioned their judgment. Internal debates raged about whether the exposure was worth the cost to the organization's reputation. Current operations inside Dominion territories have become nearly impossible. Dessani Mider members caught operating covertly face arrest and lengthy imprisonment. The organization has shifted to training local practitioners who can operate without Mider affiliation, but this dilutes quality control and organizational coherence.

Four months ago, a Dessani Mider herbalist was conducting addiction treatment sessions in a village in the Borda Woods near the border with Barból. One patient, a young humm man struggling with severe psychological distress, was given a psychotropic preparation intended to facilitate emotional processing and breakthrough. The session went

wrong. The patient experienced acute psychotic episode, became violent, and before others could restrain him, he killed another participant with a farming implement. The herbalist managed to subdue him with emergency sedation, but the damage was done. The patient survived. The victim did not. The Fatunik village council demanded that the Dessani Mider face justice for the death, arguing that his provision of dangerous substances made him responsible for the violence.

The order argued that the patient had underlying conditions that weren't apparent during screening, that the psychotropic treatment was administered according to protocol, and that the tragic outcome was unforeseeable. The village council was unmoved. The situation escalated. The Dessani Mider leadership attempted to negotiate, offering compensation to the victim's family and proposing additional training protocols to prevent similar incidents. The village council rejected these offers, insisting on expulsion from the village at minimum, and raising the spectre of an investigation by the Candle Makers.

The case remains unresolved. The herbalists left the village and faces potential prosecution if he returns. The Dessani Mider have suspended all psychotropic treatment sessions pending review of protocols. Several members have left the organization, arguing that the risks of this work are no longer justified by the benefits.

Ma Eshuna, a Dessani Mider elder, has said,

"We carry the hardest burdens. We attend the dying. We guide those who suffer through the darkest passages. We hold knowledge of transformation that can heal or harm depending on wisdom in application.

"We will make mistakes. We have made mistakes. Voran's tragedy is not the first and will not be the last. Every psychotropic session carries risk. Every assisted death requires absolute certainty of intention. Every addiction treatment might fail.

"The question is not whether we fail—we will. The question is whether we continue despite failure, whether we learn from each tragedy, whether we adapt our methods while maintaining our

commitment to those who suffer.

"I have lived nearly four hundred years. I have attended thousands of deaths. I have seen psychotropic healing transform lives and I have seen it destroy them. I continue this work because the alternative, abandoning those who suffer to suffer alone, is unacceptable.

"But I am tired. Many of us are tired. The criticism, the danger, the constant possibility of tragedy—it extracts a price. We need more members, better training, stronger protocols. We need rest, which we rarely get.

"We need acknowledgment that this work matters, even when it fails."

Under Stress

The Dauni Vakasaqua network, via its various incarnations, operates effectively across most of the Saskan Lands, but the past few years have revealed structural vulnerabilities.

The northern expansion has largely failed. Dominion hostility toward non-hierarchical organization makes sustained operation in Fatunik territories increasingly unlikely. The DK are withdrawing from Fatunik regions and shifting to training local practitioners rather than maintaining direct presence. The matriarchal hum leadership structure is producing more defections than in the past, particularly among highly skilled men and sints who resent the restrictions. The organization is losing talent it can't afford to lose.

Resource constraints are becoming severe. The Kahila refugee crisis, the increased security costs in hostile territories, the need to compensate for failed initiatives, all of this strains the budget that S'lah revenues provide. Internal debates about risk tolerance are creating factions. Some members advocate withdrawal from dangerous operations, focusing on safe territories and sustainable growth. Others argue that the DK's mission requires accepting danger and that withdrawal from hard territories abandons those who need help most desperately.

Perhaps most troubling are signs of infiltration. Reports from High Weir suggest that Jaxen units have successfully embedded themselves in some DK operations, posing as tireless workers in agricultural research stations or as dedicated healers in Free Brooder facilities. The DK lack effective methods for detecting these infiltrators, and the organization's non-hierarchical structure, usually an asset, makes coordinated security response nearly impossible.

Adaptation and Continuity

Despite these challenges, the Dauni Vakasaqua network continues operating effectively in its core territories. Pollination training proceeds. S'lah revenues flow. The Traveling Sisters move through their circuits. The Free Brooders care for children. The Dessani Mider attend the dying.

The organization's strength lies not in avoiding failure but in learning from it. The Jivákala arrest led to better coordination with Rider Arms mediators before attempting operations in contested territories. The S'lah contamination incident produced improved quality control. The Traveling Sisters' tragedy in occupied Kahilaqor forced realistic assessment of danger and better support for members working in conflict zones.

The Dessani Mider continue despite tragedies, with modified protocols and additional training requirements. The Free Brooders continue despite overwhelming need, requesting help rather than abandoning principle.

This is the Dauni Vakasaqua's actual achievement: not perfection but persistence, not flawless execution but continuous adaptation, not invulnerability but resilience in the face of inevitable failure. They bury their dead, learn from their mistakes, train new members to carry the work forward, and continue tending the springs from which the south's abundance flows. The work is never finished. The problems never fully solved. The threats never completely contained.

But the work continues. The springs flow. And the network, for all its flaws and failures, remains the closest thing the Settan Lands has to

federal governance; it is the invisible structure that, to a large extent, makes southern freedoms possible.

Returner Cults

Before there were Dexelites or Nightingales or any organized Returner movement, there were people finding ancient objects in ruins, wondering what they were for, and preserving them because something whispered that these things mattered. Before anyone articulated Returner philosophy, there were farmers who wouldn't plow certain fields because the ancestors rest there, and hunters who treated particular caves as sacred because the old ones knew this place.

The Returner consciousness isn't an ideology imposed from above. It's the substrate, the persistent intuition, carried across generations, that the world was once different, that knowledge was once greater, that what exists now is diminished from what existed before. This consciousness exists throughout the Saskan Lands, from Tagabant camps to Outer Lands communes, but it flourishes most abundantly in the southern territories, where fewer authorities attempt to suppress it and where the decentralized culture allows it to take countless forms.

What outsiders call Returner cults are simply the most visible expressions of this pervasive orientation. Most people who hold Returner beliefs don't belong to any organized faith. They simply maintain small shrines with ancient artifacts, tell stories about the time before the Catastrophe, and feel the pull of ruins and old places. The organized movements—Dexelites, Nightingales, Seekers, Devotees—channel this diffuse consciousness into focused action, attempting to recover not just artifacts but knowledge, not just objects but understanding.

This makes Returner movements simultaneously marginal and central. Marginal in that no single Returner organization wields significant formal power. Central in that Returner consciousness shapes how tens of thousands of folk understand their world, providing the persistent counterbalance to Fatunik orthodoxy, Rider

pragmatism, and even Dauni Vakasaqua agricultural rationalism.

You cannot suppress what is everywhere. You cannot eliminate what has no center. This is both the Returner movement's greatest strength and its fundamental limitation.

Practical Recovery

The Dexelites represent the most organized and purposeful expression of Returner consciousness, distinguished by their focus on practical application rather than mere reverence for ancient objects. Their core principle is that returning means analyzing and discovering the purpose and use of artifacts as the ancients knew them, particularly artifacts related to healing and life extension.

The Dexelites have a significant presence throughout the south, especially in the provinces of Settarune, Baranuk, and Arq, as well as scattered communities in the Outer Lands, underground networks in rural Fatunik areas, along with a growing influence in Pavanarune and in the eastern Kahila territories.

They have been instrumental in the recovery and replication of basic medical instruments such as simple surgical tools, measuring devices, diagnostic equipment. The development of systematic cataloging methods for artifacts has allowed for detailed knowledge-sharing across Dexelite communities. Their training programs combine traditional herbalism with investigation of ancient medical practices and they have successfully resisted Fatunik attempts at suppression through decentralization and rural embedding.

The Dexelite movement has diversified significantly over the past generation, spawning multiple sub-groups with distinct emphases but shared commitment to practical recovery.

The Torchbearers of Dexel focus on the prophecy of Dexel's return with illuminating knowledge. They operate primarily in rural Fatunik territories, often underground, sometimes openly where local authorities are sympathetic or indifferent. Their method involves pilgrimage to ancient sites, ritual invocation combined with

systematic archaeological investigation, and distribution of recovered knowledge through networks of rural healers.

A Torchbearer group operating near the ruins of an ancient settlement in northern Norgyte recovered a cache of sealed containers holding preserved medicinal compounds. Analysis by Dexelite herbalists working with some reluctant consultation from Dauni Vakasaqua experts identified several compounds with antibiotic properties superior to anything currently available. Production methods are being reverse-engineered. Within two years, these medicines may be widely available, potentially saving thousands of lives.

The Keepers of the Book of Promises maintain the textual tradition, studying the ancient Fatunik Book which they believe was authored by Dexel herself. This creates fascinating theological tensions. The Keepers are simultaneously Returner cultists and Fatunik heretics, claiming authority from within Fatunik tradition while rejecting the orthodox interpretations, though of course they see just the opposite -- that they have correctly understood the foundational texts and it is the so-called Fatunik Authorities who have had it wrong from the start.

They operate openly in some Fatunik provinces, barely tolerated by authorities who can't quite decide whether the Keepers strengthen or undermine Fatunik legitimacy. The Keepers argue that Dexel's teaching emphasizes practical healing and knowledge recovery rather than the punitive moralism that dominates current Fatunik practice. In any case, their influence among rural Fatunik populations is substantial. In villages where official Fatunik authorities focus on enforcing compliance with laws against heresy, Keeper-affiliated healers provide actual medical care while re-framing their practice in language that sounds orthodox enough to avoid suppression.

First Into the Fire

The Nightingales represent the Dexelite movement's most audacious expression. They are healers who deliberately operate in conflict zones, disaster areas, and crisis situations that other organizations avoid or abandon.

Rollo the Dexelite established the Nightingales roughly sixty turns back after witnessing the aftermath of a border skirmish where wounded fighters from both sides were left to die because no healers would enter the contested territory. The Nightingales adopted a strict code: they treat anyone, regardless of affiliation, and they go where others won't.

They operate in small mobile teams, typically 3-5 members, carrying minimal equipment and are known for their use of recovered ancient medical tools, particularly stethoscopes and hypodermic needles. The Nightingales observe strict political neutrality, treating combatants from all sides equally. They specialize in rapid deployment to crisis zones, often arriving before official responses can be organized and their training emphasizes emergency medicine and trauma care rather than long-term healing.

The Nightingales maintain imagery of birds despite birds' absence from the Saskan Lands for millennia. Despite ridicule, they argue this makes their mission clearer. They operate in memory of what was lost, carrying healing where it's needed most, like the legendary night-singing birds that once announced dawn's approach. Most Saskan folk consider bird imagery harmless lunacy. Fatunik authorities view it as heretical maintenance of forbidden knowledge. The Nightingales don't particularly care what anyone thinks.

Significantly, several Nightingale leaders are former Dauni Vakasaqua, often men or sints who left the organization due to the matriarchal leadership restrictions or women who found DK risk-aversion frustrating. Rollo himself trained with the Dauni Vakasaqua before founding the Nightingales. His approach combines DK herbal expertise with Dexelite artifact recovery and a willingness to operate in conditions the DK consider too dangerous.

When the Traveling Sisters withdrew from the most dangerous conflict zones, the Nightingales expanded operations into those abandoned territories. This created an informal division of labor. The Traveling Sisters work in relatively stable regions where long-term relationship-building matters, while the Nightingales deploy to acute crises where immediate intervention saves lives but sustained presence is impossible.

The Nightingales' most recent visible success came during a Kahilaqor uprising three years ago. When fighting intensified between Kahila resistance cells and Tagabant forces, medical services from both sides withdrew entirely. The Nightingales sent six teams into the territory, treating wounded fighters from both sides along with civilian casualties.

They lost one member who was killed by crossfire while treating a wounded Tagabant soldier. The remaining teams continued operations. By the time the fighting subsided, the Nightingales had treated over two hundred casualties, with survival rates significantly better than typical battlefield medicine achieves.

This success generated complicated reactions. The Kahila resistance appreciated the care but resented that Nightingales treated their Tagabant enemies equally. The Dominion appreciated the humanitarian gesture but suspected the Nightingales of spying for Kahila forces. The Dauni Vakasaqua expressed quiet admiration mixed with concern that the Nightingales' high-profile operations make DK's own work more difficult.

The Nightingales' response was silence. They don't care about politics, only about keeping people alive long enough to return to whatever politics they prefer. They operate on the edge of sustainability. Their model depends on members willing to accept extraordinary danger for minimal material reward. Recruitment is difficult. Most healers prefer safer, more stable work. Funding comes from donations and occasional contracts with communities expecting disaster, paying the Nightingales a retainer to ensure rapid response if needed.

Equipment is a constant problem. The ancient medical tools they rely on are irreplaceable if broken or lost. They've developed some capacity for replication. Basic stethoscopes can be constructed from available materials. But the more sophisticated instruments remain unique artifacts whose loss would be catastrophic.

Burnout is severe. The average Nightingale operates in the field for three to five turns before exhaustion, trauma, or injury forces retirement. Some return to safer healing work. Others leave medicine entirely, unable to process what they've witnessed. The organization

loses members faster than it recruits them. Current roster stands at maybe forty active Nightingales, down from sixty five turns ago. Rollo, now elderly and no longer deployable to crisis zones, spends most of his time on recruitment and training, trying to sustain the movement he founded.

Yet they continue. Last month, when flooding devastated several Ny Lands communities, Nightingale teams arrived within days, before the Night Hall could mobilize a coordinated response . They treated injuries, prevented disease outbreaks, and trained local healers in emergency protocols before departing.

This is the Nightingales' pattern: arrive fast, stabilize the crisis, train locals to sustain care, then move to the next emergency. They will never have enough members, enough equipment, or enough resources. But they operate anyway, diving into fires that others flee from.

The Independent Healers Association

The Independent Healers Association presents itself as politically neutral, non-religious professional organization for healers not affiliated with any cult, guild, or institution. In practice, most Independent Healers hold Dexelite sympathies or maintain some flavor of Dexelite cult memberships.

There are approximately 300 registered members throughout the Saskan Lands, with the strongest presence in Settarune, Barból, and the Outer Lands. The IHA has a growing presence in rural Dominion regions where official medical infrastructure is weak but a minimal presence in Rider territories where the Independent [sic] Brooders Guild provides similar services.

The Association provides professional standards, shares knowledge, mediates disputes between healers, and offers training programs. But it also serves as cover for Dexelite operations in territories where explicit Returner affiliation would attract suppression. A healer can present as Independent, just a professional practitioner using traditional methods, while privately studying Dexelite texts and using recovered ancient tools. The Association provides plausible

deniability.

A senior DK researcher who left the organization last year after being passed over for leadership joined the Independent Healers and immediately elevated their capabilities. He's currently training Association members in advanced diagnostic techniques and herbal preparations that previously only the DK possessed.

This transfer of knowledge represents both loss for the DK and gain for Returner-affiliated medicine. The Dauni Vakasaqua cannot prevent a former member from teaching what he knows. The Independent Healers are delighted, though some worry that appearing too competent will attract the kind of scrutiny that Dexelite groups often need to avoid.

Where River Meets Recovery

In the south, particularly in Settarune and Arq, Returner beliefs blend freely with river worship, creating syncretic movements that outsiders struggle to categorize.

Seekers of Setta's Energy represent the largest such group, treating ancient artifacts as vessels for the same animating force that flows through the Settan River. Their theology is deliberately vague. Setta might be a goddess, might be a fundamental force, might be planetary consciousness, might be all of these simultaneously.

What matters practically is that Seekers maintain temples at ancient sites, often located near water sources, where they conduct rituals combining river reverence with artifact study. These temples serve as repositories for recovered objects, research centers for understanding their function, and pilgrimage destinations for southern Returners.

Current operations focus on systematic archaeological investigation combined with spiritual practice. A Seeker team excavating near the Runes of Bye recently uncovered an intact structure containing what appear to be communication devices—objects with crystalline components that resonate when exposed to certain frequencies. The team is attempting to understand their function while simultaneously

incorporating them into ritual practices invoking Setta's presence.

Whether this approach will yield practical insights or just elaborate ceremonialism remains uncertain. The Seekers argue that spiritual attunement enhances technical understanding, that you cannot truly comprehend ancient technology without understanding the consciousness that created it.

Critics, including most Dixelites, view this as unnecessary mystification. The objects work according to physical principles. Understanding those principles requires investigation, not prayer. The Seekers respond that the artificial separation between spiritual and practical is itself a post-Catastrophe limitation, that the ancients knew these domains were unified, and that recovery requires reintegrating what has been falsely divided. The debate continues. Meanwhile, the Seekers continue their work, accumulating knowledge and artifacts while maintaining networks throughout the South.

Malavorra's Devotees venerate the possibly-mythical southern guru as living incarnation of Setta, as embodiment of the river goddess, as the Settan Mother made flesh. Their pilgrimage routes overlap with both Seeker temples and traditional river shrines, creating tensions with more orthodox groups from both traditions. The Devotees are smaller, more militant, and considerably more apocalyptic than most southern Returner groups. They believe Malavorra will soon reveal herself, will restore the ancient knowledge in a sudden illumination, will judge the worthy and the unworthy, will fundamentally transform the Saskan Lands. Whether Malavorra exists remains the subject of intense speculation. Some villages report recent visits. Others treat her as ancient legend. The Dauni Vakasaqua, when questioned, smile and decline to comment.

The Devotees maintain that uncertainty about Malavorra's existence is precisely the point, that faith requires embracing mystery rather than demanding proof. They pilgrimage to sites they believe she has designated, perform rituals they claim she has taught them, and wait for the revelation they trust is coming. Practically, the Devotees accomplish little beyond maintaining pilgrimage networks and occasionally irritating more established Returner groups. But their fervor attracts followers, particularly young people dissatisfied with

the slow, methodical approach of Dexelite recovery or frustrated by the Dauni Vakasaqua's pragmatic focus.

The Pervasive Substrate

Beyond these organized movements, Returner consciousness pervades daily life throughout the Saskan Lands, especially in rural areas where official ideologies penetrate weakly.

A Fatunik farmer maintains a small shrine with ancient coins and broken tools, inherited from his village elders, treated with reverence despite having no clear understanding of their original purpose and with the Fatunik sun-symbol looking over the artifacts. He would never call himself a Returner, might even deny holding such beliefs if questioned by authorities, but his practice embodies Returner consciousness nonetheless.

A Settarune village elder tells stories about the time when the sky-boats flew, mixing memory and myth, preserving narratives whose factual basis is uncertain but whose cultural function remains vital. She connects children to a past that explains why the present feels diminished, giving them context for the manual pollination work that defines their lives.

An Arql band marks certain ruins as off-limits, treating them as sacred territory where the ancestors still walk. They conduct no elaborate rituals, maintain no formal cult, but they carry Returner belief in its most basic form: the conviction that the past matters and that some places still resonate with its presence.

This substrate makes organized Returner movements resilient. You can suppress a Dexelite group, arrest Nightingale healers, ban Seeker temples but you cannot eliminate the underlying consciousness that generates these movements. When one expression is suppressed, others emerge, often in forms authorities don't recognize as Returner until they're already established.

The Fatunik Dominion has attempted various strategies for controlling Returner consciousness. They have tried co-opting it

through the Keepers of the Book, arguing that Dexel is a Fatunik prophet rather than a Returner one, suppressing it through enforcement by treating artifact recovery as heresy, and ignoring it, letting rural populations maintain their harmless traditions as long as they don't challenge central authority.

None of these strategies fully succeeds. Returner consciousness persists because it addresses something the dominant ideologies cannot, the psychological need to understand why the world is diminished, why life is harder than it should be, why the ruins suggest capabilities that current civilization cannot replicate.

What Returners Accomplish

Measured against their own stated goals, the full recovery of ancient knowledge, restoration of pre-Catastrophe civilization, Returner movements have failed completely. No cult has reconstructed advanced technology. No Dexelite group has genuinely understood how the artifacts they study originally functioned. No Seeker ritual has successfully communicated with ancient consciousness or planetary awareness.

But measured against realistic standards, Returner movements achieve significant practical outcomes. The Nightingales' emergency response capabilities save lives that would otherwise be lost. Dexelite recovery of medical tools and medicines provides treatments unavailable through traditional herbalism alone. Independent Healers trained in both traditional and recovered methods demonstrate consistently better outcomes than those relying on a single approach.

Returner cults maintain awareness of the ancient world, preventing complete historical amnesia. The stories they preserve, artifacts they protect, and ruins they maintain as sacred sites ensure that future generations will know that something greater existed, even if the specifics remain murky. This psychological function is also a type of healing. Returner consciousness provides meaning for communities struggling with difficult conditions. The belief that current hardship represents decline from a better past creates framework for understanding suffering without succumbing to despair. "Our

ancestors knew how to make life easier, and one day we might recover that knowledge" is more hopeful than "life is just hard and always will be."

Returner movements provide a persistent alternative to Fatunik ideology, preventing complete ideological domination by the Center. Rural populations maintain beliefs and practices that implicitly reject the official Fatunik worldview, creating space for resistance without requiring explicit political organization.

The Dexelite emphasis on understanding artifact function rather than just revering objects has occasionally produced genuine insights. Recovered medical knowledge, improved diagnostic tools, and better understanding of material properties all derive from Returner investigation combined with practical experimentation.

The Returner movements' decentralization is their greatest strength and also their fundamental limitation. They cannot coordinate large-scale projects, cannot pool resources effectively, cannot systematically build on each other's discoveries.

A Dexelite group in Settarune might spend years investigating an artifact, achieve partial understanding, and then disband when key members die or move away. Their knowledge disperses. Another group in Arq encounters a similar artifact years later and must start from the beginning, unaware of the previous investigation.

Some attempts at systematic knowledge-sharing have been made. The Keepers of the Book maintain archives, Seeker temples preserve records, the Independent Healers Association publishes treatises that get stored in the Night Hall or at Terpinol Academy. But these efforts remain fragmentary compared to what centralized organization could achieve.

The movements also suffer from tendency toward mystification. For every Dexelite group taking a rigorous, investigative approach to artifacts, there's another treating objects as magical talismans whose power can be accessed through correct ritual rather than through understanding their function. This mystical tendency wastes resources and undermines credibility.

The Devotees of Malavorra represent the extreme case. It is a movement that has essentially abandoned practical recovery in favor of apocalyptic expectation. They contribute nothing to knowledge advancement while attracting enthusiastic followers who might otherwise join more productive Returner groups.

Competition between Returner movements sometimes undermines collaboration. Seekers and Dexelites argue about proper methodology. Devotees irritate everyone with their millenarian fervor. Independent Healers resent Nightingale heroics while Nightingales view Independent Healers as insufficiently committed. These internal divisions prevent the kind of unified effort that might actually achieve significant recovery of ancient knowledge.

Questions

Returner movements face an existential question: What happens if they succeed?

If ancient knowledge is genuinely recovered, if technological capabilities are restored, if the pre-Catastrophe world is somehow rebuilt, what then? Does the movement disappear, its purpose fulfilled? Does it transform into something else? Do new ideologies emerge to contest how recovered knowledge should be used?

Most Returners never think about this question, focused as they are on the immediate work of recovery. But some scholars, particularly those in Terpinol and Byenung studying Returner movements from outside, worry that successful recovery might be more destabilizing than continued struggle. The Returner consciousness provides meaning precisely through longing for what is lost. Recovery might eliminate that longing, leaving populations without the narrative framework that sustained them. The ideology that worked during decline might fail during restoration.

But these are theoretical concerns. The practical reality is that genuine recovery of ancient knowledge remains distant, perhaps impossible. The Returners will continue their work investigating artifacts, treating wounded, preserving memories, maintaining the collective conviction

that the past matters and the future might be different.

The Nightingales will dive into the next crisis. The Dexelites will study their artifacts. The Seekers will conduct their rituals. The Devotees will await Malavorra's revelation. The Independent Healers will treat their patients.

And throughout the Saskan Lands, in ten thousand villages and camps and hidden settlements, people will maintain their small shrines, tell their stories, and carry the consciousness that whispers: We were greater once. We might be greater again. The past is not dead. It is not even past.

The memory persists. The work continues. And the future, whatever it brings, will be shaped by those who remembered when others forgot.

The Wild Lands

Try to count the languages being spoken in Skotskaa village market and you will lose track around seven. Try to determine who's in charge and people will laugh at you, not mockingly, but with genuine confusion about what that question even means. Try to map the province and you'll produce something that contradicts the next cartographer's work completely, because Arq's boundaries, settlements, and even its landscapes seem to shift depending on when you visit and whom you ask.

Welcome to Arq, the place where the Saskan Lands give up on order entirely and embrace magnificent, bewildering, overwhelming chaos.

Arq is the south-easternmost Settan province, separated from the rest of the south by the entire width of the Outer Lands and the Bay of Bar. No land route connects it to Barból or Settarune. Travelers must either sail across the Bay or make the long journey through the Runes of Bye and the Ny Lands. The Ring Road doesn't reach anywhere close to Arq and no one has ever seriously proposed extending it. The logistics would be nightmare enough, but more fundamentally, Arq

doesn't want a road. Roads imply structure, permanent routes, the kind of fixed infrastructure that Arq resists on principle or would resist on principle if Arq operated on principles at all.

The province sprawls across territory that might be smaller than Settarune or might be larger, depending on whether you count the nomadic bands' seasonal ranges, the contested borderlands with East Komikol, and the question of whether certain settlements are in Arq or just near it. Population estimates vary, perhaps fifteen thousand souls, perhaps twenty-five thousand, perhaps more if you count the communities that prefer not to be counted at all.

What everyone agrees on is that Arq is the wildest of the Wild Lands, the place where animal-sints outnumber hum by significant margins, where languages survive that exist nowhere else, where legends so ancient and strange persist that scholars from Byenung make pilgrimages just to hear them told, and where the very concept of governance is treated as an amusing but fundamentally incomprehensible northern affectation.

The Forgotten Range

Arq's defining geographic feature is the Forgotten Range, the same mountains that bisect the Ny Lands, but with a different name. It is called Forgotten here because it is said that anyone who wanders into the hills will be forgotten.

The Arq coastline on the Krbsh Sea and on the Bay of Bar is irregular, creating countless coves, inlets, and small harbors where boats can shelter. Sandy beaches alternate with rocky cliffs. The Kollikan River flows north from East Komikol, carrying not just water but occasional visitors. Komikol reptilian-sints travel north for trade or exploration, sometimes settling in southern Arq and adding their DNA to the already extraordinary genetic diversity.

Inland from the Krbsh coast, the terrain becomes deadly. The eastern regions features a desert, similar to the Ny Lands eastern region, but hotter and drier and unbroken for 200 kilometers. The good news is that it is only about 30 kilometers wide. The bad news is that once

you a through it, you are facing the Forgotten Range.

The Forgotten Range mountains are not tall by Empafarasi or even High Weir standards, but they're the only significant peaks in Arq, and they create distinct microclimates. On the western side, again, as in the Ny Lands, rivers emerge from these heights, including the waterway that supplies the inland town of Barqtun, if we can call it a town.

South of Barqtun, the southern border with East Komikol is theoretical. No wall, no clear natural boundary, no agreed-upon line. Komikol settlements and Arql bands intermingle, trade, sometimes fight, sometimes intermingle, and generally ignore the idea that they're supposed to be in different provinces. The history of the region is violent. This was the main battleground between sentient reptiles and ancient hum Saskan defenders, or invaders depending on your perspective, over a millennia ago. But the present is more complex, characterized by the kind of pragmatic coexistence that emerges when formal governance is absent.

The Language of Antiquity

Arq preserves linguistic traditions that make scholars weep with joy and frustration in equal measure.

Arql itself is considered the language of Saskan antiquity, older than Sogomsh, older than Eibar, possibly older than anything else spoken in the known world. It's a complex, tonal language with grammatical structures that don't resemble modern tongues. The vocabulary includes words for things that no longer exist like flying creatures, certain technologies, ecological conditions from before the Catastrophe and lacks words for concepts that northern provinces consider essential like property, authority, and scheduled time.

Speaking Arql marks you as either genuinely from the deepest Arq traditions or as a scholar who's spent years studying with Arql elders. A knowledge of both Sogomsh and Arql is the mark of a truly educated person in Byenung, where intellectual culture values

linguistic archaeology.

Arqq is spoken by the most isolated bands, It is a derivative of Arql but simplified, or possibly a parallel development, or possibly something else entirely. Linguists argue about Arqq's origins. The bands who speak it don't care about those arguments. The language serves their needs: describing hunting territories, naming plants and animals, telling the old stories, conducting the rituals that mark births and deaths and the transitions between.

Sogomsh is spoken widely throughout Arq and serves as common tongue for inter-band communication and trade. Some consider it to be the classical language of the Saskan Lands, and Arq's dialects are among the purest, which is to say least influenced by Eibar or northern linguistic drift. When Barból or Settarune folk speak Sogomsh, they're speaking a language whose heartland is Arq, even if they don't know it.

Most Arqli speak at least two languages, many speak three or four, and polyglots who can navigate six or seven tongues are common enough not to be remarkable. This linguistic facility is purely practical. If you want to trade with the Komikol reptilian-sints, communicate with visiting Ny Landers, and maintain traditions with your own band, you need multiple languages. No one sits down for formal language instruction. Children absorb languages by hearing them, and the brain-rewiring that makes this possible is one of the subtle legacies of the post-Catastrophe world.

Barqtun and Bartun

Arq has two places that might charitably be called towns, which is one more than the Ny Lands has. Well. If you squint and don't think too hard about what town means in other parts of the Saskan Lands.

Barqtun sits on a river bend in the west of the Forgotten Range, originally established by Fatunik volunteers as a garrison against Komikol incursions but long since abandoned to its own devices. The walls have deteriorated. The geometric street layout has been thoroughly subverted by organic growth. What remains is something

between a very large encampment and a very chaotic market town.

Buildings appear to have been constructed and expanded without any consideration for architectural coherence. Structures lean against each other. Additions sprout from roofs. What might have been a single dwelling becomes a warren of interconnected spaces as families expand and newcomers squeeze into available gaps. Streets wind without logic, occasionally dead-ending, sometimes merging unexpectedly with what you thought was a different route entirely.

The marketplace, if it can be called that, operates without the slightest hint of formal organization. Traders set up wherever space exists. Goods pile on carpets, in baskets, on improvised tables. Negotiations happen in multiple languages simultaneously. Prices fluctuate based on factors visible only to participants. You might buy something, walk ten paces, and see the same item being sold for half the price or double, and both transactions are considered fair because fairness is determined by what buyer and seller agree to, not by any external standard.

The town's governance operates by doing without governing. The Elders of Barqtun who are wise figures respected for their age and experience mediate disputes when asked to so, offer advice when solicited, and otherwise allow folks to organize their own affairs. This isn't some kind of philosophical anarchism. It's practical acknowledgment that attempting to impose rules on Barqtun's diverse, fiercely independent population would require more effort than it's worth, wouldn't work anyway, and might get you killed.

The one building that receives consistent maintenance is the Terpinol Academy's outpost in Barqtun. It is a structure devoted to studying and promoting the Sogomsh and Arql languages. It's well-kept, properly roofed, and stands out dramatically amid the surrounding ramshackle glory. Scholars from Terpinol rotate through, documenting Arql linguistic traditions, teaching formal Sogomsh to anyone interested, and maintaining the fiction that Barqtun is a normal provincial town where normal educational institutions operate normally.

Bartun -- not Barqtun -- the similar names confuse outsiders constantly, sits on the Bay of Bar, south of Wildwind, where the

deteriorating Grand Canal sometimes called the Bar Waterway ends. It's even less town-like than Barqtun. More of a persistent gathering point than a settlement proper. Structures are temporary, seasonal, rebuilt regularly as needs change. The population fluctuates as bands arrive for trade or seasonal fishing, stay for weeks or months, then disperse back into their nomadic patterns.

Bartun's main feature is its small port serving the few brave souls who venture to or from the Bay of Bar in or out of Arq territory. Since two large Komikol islands dominate the bay and Komikol territories surround it on multiple sides, Saskan ships entering these waters without Komikol connections face suspicion at best, violence at worst. The peace has held for centuries, but memories are long, and the Bay is considered mostly Komikol space except for the strip around Kurosol in Baranuq province, which is terpin territory.

The handful of traders operating out of Bartun maintain relationships with specific Komikol communities, carrying letters of introduction or traveling with Komikol companions who vouch for them.

Both settlements serve similar functions. They are places where bands can meet, trade, hear news from distant territories, find someone who knows how to repair unusual items, or connect with travelers from other provinces. They're crossroads rather than destinations, facilitating movement rather than containing it.

Grow and Split

The fundamental social unit in Arq is the band, typically extended family groups with added members through pairings, adoption, or simply choosing to travel together. Bands are mostly nomadic, moving through territories they consider their range, following game, harvesting seasonal plants, occasionally stopping to fish or to plant quick-growing crops that they'll return to harvest later. The lifestyle combines hunting, gathering, and minimal agriculture in proportions that vary by band and by season. Mostly nomadic. Some are settled.

A successful band grows. Wee ones are born, outsiders join, the group expands. This is celebrated. More hands for work, more voices for

songs, more strength for defense if needed. But there's a natural limit. Around three hundred members, maybe a bit more, and bands start to become unwieldy. Coordinating movement becomes difficult. Resources in a given territory can't sustain larger groups. Social cohesion strains when you can't know everyone personally.

So bands split. Not through conflict necessarily, though sometimes tensions accelerate the division, but through practical acknowledgment that the group has outgrown its optimal size. The split usually follows natural fault lines. Extended families that already coordinate closely, sub-groups with shared skills or interests, sometimes just geographic preferences about which territories are most appealing.

The division is marked by ceremony. Feast, gifts exchanged, promises to maintain connection, elders blessing both new bands. Then the groups depart in different directions, each continuing their nomadic life at a manageable scale.

This pattern prevents the kind of population concentration that leads to permanent settlements. Arq doesn't urbanize because the social technology for managing large groups doesn't exist and isn't desired. When a gathering grows too large, it divides. Simple, elegant, endlessly renewable.

The Animal-Sint Majority

In most Saskan provinces, hum dominate numerically and culturally. Arq inverts this completely. The majority population, sixty percent possibly more, are animal-sints of extraordinary diversity. Every variety found elsewhere in the Saskan Lands appears in Arq, plus rarer forms that exist almost nowhere else: reptilian-sints with crocodile or turtle traits distinct from the Terpins, avian-influenced sints with hollow bones and acute vision despite the absence of flight, mammalian-sints with wolf or fox or deer characteristics, amphibian-sints adapted to the coastal or riverbed territories.

This diversity reflects Arq's history as ancient battleground and its ongoing interaction with Komikol territories. Genetic mixing has occurred for millennia. The result is a population where pure hum

are rare, where most individuals carry some non-huum DNA, and where the boundaries between species categories blur into continuous variation.

Arq villages, that is, the more permanent ones like Skotskaa, are more likely to be all-rabbit or all-snake than mixed. Not from segregation but from practical affinity. Communities organize around shared needs. Rabbit-sints need burrow-space. Snake-sints prefer particular temperature and humidity. Mammalian-sints have hunting traditions best practiced among those who share their senses.

But the bands that dominate Arql culture are mixed. A band might include huum families, rabbit-sint warrens, a few snake-sints valued for their skills with poisons and medicines, and wolf-sints who excel at tracking. They travel together, share resources, and care little about species divisions that obsess northern provinces.

This creates a culture where species simply doesn't matter much. A band leader might be huum, rabbit, snake, or anything else. Leadership emerges from competence and respect, not from DNA. Mating partnerships cross species lines frequently, producing offspring whose exact heritage becomes too complex to categorize and too irrelevant to bother tracking.

The practical result is that Arq feels fundamentally different from anywhere else in the Saskan Lands. The sensory environment changes when most faces aren't huum, when conversations happen at different heights and require accommodation for different vocal ranges, when the foods being traded reflect extremely diverse dietary needs, when the very categories northern provinces use to organize reality simply don't apply.

Following the World

Many Arqli are hunters and gatherers, though these terms don't capture the sophistication of their practices.

Bands know their territories intimately: where game congregates in different seasons, which plants fruit when, where to find medicinal

herbs, which water sources remain reliable. This knowledge accumulates over generations, passed through stories, songs, and direct instruction from elders to youth.

Hunting is collaborative and ritualized. Small game like non-sentient rabbit, squirrel, deer and various reptiles is taken regularly using traps, nets, and careful stalking. Larger game requires coordinated group effort such as driving prey toward ambush points, using terrain to advantage, ensuring clean kills that don't waste meat or cause unnecessary suffering. Some bands develop distinctive hunting techniques that become part of their identity.

Gathering is equally skilled. Knowing which mushrooms are edible, which roots provide nutrition, which leaves have medicinal properties requires expertise that takes years to develop. The best gatherers can read landscapes, predicting where valuable plants will appear based on soil, light, and water conditions. The minimal agriculture practiced by some bands involves planting fast-growing crops—certain tubers, quick-maturing grains—in locations they'll pass through later in their circuit. This supplements rather than replaces hunting and gathering. No band depends entirely on agriculture, and many practice none at all. Those who focus on fishing in the rivers tend to be more settled and less nomadic.

The nomadic lifestyle creates different relationships with possessions. You own what you can carry or what you can cache safely. Tools are essential. Well-made, carefully maintained, sometimes inherited through generations. Decorative objects are often lightweight: carved bone, painted stones, woven fibers. Clothing is practical, adapted to climate and activity, easily repaired.

Temporary shelters are constructed with remarkable speed making frameworks of branches covered with hide or woven materials, designed to be erected in hours and abandoned without regret. Some bands use more permanent structures in regularly visited locations, returning to the same winter camps or summer fishing grounds year after year. The rhythm of nomadic life creates a different relationship with time. There are no appointments, no scheduled meetings, no precise timekeeping. Events happen when they happen, when the band reaches a good campsite, when game is spotted, when weather

permits. This drives northern visitors to distraction but suits the Arqli perfectly.

Raiding

Arq is not particularly peaceful.

Raiding between bands occurs. Not ritualized like Ny Lands combat, and not frequent enough to be called war, but real violence nonetheless. Disputes over hunting territories, theft of cached supplies, old grievances, sometimes just opportunistic aggression when a weaker band crosses paths with a stronger one.

Misunderstandings regarding the distinction between sentient and non-sentient animals. Jealousies. Revenge. It all plays out.

The raids are usually small-scale. A dozen fighters attacking a camp, taking supplies or captives, then withdrawing before organized resistance develops. Deaths occur but aren't necessarily the goal. Capturing resources and demonstrating dominance often suffice.

Captives are sometimes integrated into the victorious band, sometimes ransomed back to their original group, occasionally killed if circumstances are particularly hostile. This is harsh but not seen as aberrant. It's simply part of the risks of nomadic life in territories where no authority enforces peace.

Some bands develop reputations as raiders, known for aggression and avoided by others. Some are known as particularly vulnerable, either from weakness or from pacifist principles that make them attractive targets. Most fall somewhere in between, willing to defend themselves, occasionally opportunistic, but not systematically violent.

The Tidejacks, operating from Arq bases, represent a more organized form of raiding. They practice piracy at sea and run frontier guard taxation shake-downs on land. But they're distinctive, not representative of typical Arq culture.

Democratic Bandits

The Tidejacks are Arq's most organized and most feared institution, which is saying something in a province that doesn't do organized institutions.

They operate as semi-pirate, semi-mercenary outfits running small fleets across the Krbsh Sea and to some extent in the Bay of Bar. Typically two or three ships per group, often stolen from Mobalbesq traders. The Tidejacks also construct and repair their own vessels. Aside from the Tidejacks, Arq does have minimal shipbuilding capacity, enough to keep the pirate fleets operational along with fishing teams.

What distinguishes the Tidejacks from mere bandits is their internal organization. They operate on share-and-share-alike principles. All booty divided equally, all major decisions made democratically, leadership roles assigned by merit and skill rather than hierarchy. A ship's captain has authority during operations but lives no better than the newest crew member when booty is split.

This egalitarian structure makes them fiercely loyal to each other and nearly impossible to bribe or co-opt. There's no leader to corrupt, no hierarchy to infiltrate. Each Tidejack fleet is independent, coordinating with others when convenient but beholden to no central command.

At sea, they dominate the Arql shoreline. Merchant vessels crossing from the Settan River toward the Krbsh Sea face a choice: pay the Tidejacks for protection or risk being raided. Some ships fight. Some flee. Most pay. It's cheaper than losing your cargo, and the Tidejacks are professional enough not to kill unless you resist violently.

On land, the Tidejacks pose as frontier guards collecting road taxes from travelers on the dangerous paths passing through Arql territory. They're good at it too, using primitive telescopes and flag communication systems to track caravans, coordinating attacks from concealed positions, appearing seemingly from nowhere to demand payment from startled merchants. And they're smart enough to avoid confrontations they can't win. The Ny Lands FTA are one of the few groups the Tidejacks genuinely fear. The FTA's reputation for deadly

competence makes tangling with them unwise. The Rider Arms patrols also command respect, and Tidejacks generally steer clear when they spot Rider insignia. But there are few Rider patrols as far south as Arq.

The Tagabant have made the mistake of traveling through Arq territory on occasions, underestimating the threat. Several Tagabant units have learned painfully that the Tidejacks on land are as dangerous as at sea, and that Dominion authority means nothing in territories where no one acknowledges authority at all.

The biggest conflicts come from raids on shipping. The Mobali communes and traders based in Pavanarune lodge complaints at the Night Hall. Delegations of talkative thinkers arrive in Arq, offering inducements and heartfelt pleas for ethical behavior, trying to convince the Tidejacks to take up fishing instead. The Tidejacks listen politely, accept whatever gifts are offered, and then go right back to piracy because it's more profitable than fishing and considerably more exciting.

Within Arq, the Tidejacks are mostly admired rather than condemned. They share their booty with clans and kinsmen, making them benefactors rather than criminals. A successful Tidejack crew returning to Barqtun or Bartun with seized cargo distributes wealth throughout their community, funding feasts and festivals, helping bands in need. This generosity creates social standing that pure violence never could.

Skotskaa

Most Arq is nomadic, but a few permanent villages exist. Skotskaa, located upstream from Barqtun, is the most notable.

Skotskaa is one of the rare settlements where long-term residence doesn't feel like giving up freedom, where permanent buildings don't imply permanent constraints, where community forms without hierarchy. The village is sizable by Arq standards, perhaps five hundred residents, though population fluctuates as people come and go. Buildings are more substantial than temporary camps: stone

foundations, proper roofs, structures designed to last generations. But the architecture still reflects Arq sensibilities with irregular layouts, organic growth rather than planning, constant modification as needs change.

Skotskaa survives through fishing, some agriculture, and serving as trading post for nomadic bands. Its location on a river and not too far from the frontier with the Ny Lands provides access to reliable food sources, and the village has developed expertise in net-making, boat construction, and the kind of preservation techniques needed to store fish for trade.

What makes Skotskaa unusual is the population diversity and the high incidence of mutations and subtle traits. It's not unusual to find someone with mild psychic abilities, empathic sensitivity that goes beyond normal social awareness, or barely-visible physical traits marking non-huum DNA. Truly pure huum from Skotskaa are so rare that the concept barely has meaning.

This genetic diversity reflects Skotskaa's position as a crossroads. Bands pass through, individuals settle temporarily or permanently, relationships form across every imaginable boundary. The result is a population that embodies Arq's fundamental nature: mixed, mutable, resistant to categorization.

The Hidden River

Arql religious beliefs center on the concept of the hidden river or lost river. This is a spiritual geography that may or may not correspond to physical reality.

Unlike the Settan River cults that dominate the central and western South, Arql beliefs treat water as something lost or concealed. The stories speak of a time when a great river flowed through what is now Arq, sustaining civilization, connecting communities, making life abundant. Then something happened. Maybe the Catastrophe, perhaps, or something older and the true river was hidden, driven underground, or simply lost.

Some interpret this literally. Along with its regular rivers, there are underground aquifers. Some treat the legends metaphorically, arguing that the hidden river represents lost knowledge, lost connections, the sense that something essential has been taken and must be recovered. Some Arql scholars believe their ancestors lived near a different river entirely, perhaps in the distant north or even in lands beyond the Saskan Lands, and that Arq represents a place of exile, a substitute homeland for people driven from their true origin.

This gives Arql spirituality a melancholic, searching quality distinct from Settarune's anarchic abundance or Baranuq's quiet certainty. The religious practices involve pilgrimage to springs and streams, perhaps fragments of the lost river, meditation in caves listening for underground water, and rituals invoking water spirits who might reveal where the hidden river has gone.

The Settan River itself, is still far from Arq's northern border. It doesn't satisfy this spiritual longing. It is someone else's river. The hidden river, the lost river of Arq, remains absent, and its absence shapes Arql consciousness in ways outsiders struggle to understand.

Trade Without Markets

Arq doesn't have market days. It has trading, constantly, opportunistically, in patterns that make sense to participants but baffle organized merchants.

A band arrives at Barqtun with furs and carved bone implements. They wander through the settlement until they find someone interested. Negotiation happens in multiple languages, maybe Sogomsh, maybe Arql, maybe a hybrid dialect invented on the spot. No prices are posted. Value is determined by conversation, by assessment of need, by relationship between buyer and seller.

Payment might be in goods, might be in service (the buyer promises future assistance), might be in information (knowledge of where to find medicinal plants is valuable currency). Coins exist and circulate, but they're just one exchange medium among many. The absence of scheduled market days means trading happens constantly at low

intensity rather than in periodic bursts. Someone always has something to trade, someone always needs something, and connecting these needs happens through social networks and casual inquiry rather than through formal marketplace structures.

This system works because Arq's population is mobile. You don't need scheduled markets when people are constantly moving through territory, encountering others, making connections. The bands and the permanent settlements serve as nodes in a network that operates through movement rather than through fixed gathering points.

For outsiders trying to conduct business in Arq, this is maddening. You can't plan a trading expedition when you don't know where your potential customers will be or when they'll be ready to trade. Success requires flexibility, language skills, and willingness to abandon the commercial practices that work everywhere else in the Saskan Lands.

Military Resources

Arq has no military organization. No bands train specifically for war, no settlements maintain defensive forces, no coordinating body could mobilize provincial response to external threat. This is both weakness and strength. An organized invasion of Arq would find no central target, no authority to compel surrender, no infrastructure to capture. An army would wander through territory finding scattered bands who might fight, might flee, might simply vanish into wilderness the invaders can't navigate.

Moreover, Arq has nothing worth conquering. No wealth concentrated in towns, no agricultural surplus to seize, no administrative apparatus to co-opt. You could occupy Barqtun and achieve nothing except controlling a chaotic marketplace that would immediately disperse if it felt threatened. Probably the most important resource are the salt mines, which are managed mainly by Ny Landers.

The Rider Arms and Tagabant forces patrol Arq's borders from time to time, particularly by making the long expedition to the southern frontier with Komikol, keeping watch for signs of aggression from

the Komikol communities. These patrols have minimal interaction with Arql bands, who mostly ignore them. The feeling is mutual. As long as the Arqli don't cause trouble for other provinces, the military authorities let them continue their incomprehensible way of life.

The Tidejacks represent Arq's closest thing to organized violence, but they're not a provincial army. They're independent operators who happen to base themselves in Arq because the province's chaos provides perfect cover for their activities.

Legends That Echo

Arq contains stories so old that other provinces' legends reference them without fully understanding their source.

Tales of shape-shifters who walked between human and animal forms. These stories originate in Arq, where genetic boundaries remain fluid and where memory might preserve pre-Catastrophe genetic engineering that created the sint populations. Stories of the first speakers, the beings who taught language to the hum, are told in Arql around fires, in versions so detailed and strange that linguists suspect they contain genuine historical memory encoded in narrative form.

The legends of the sky folk who fell to the ground bringing gifts and curses appear throughout the Saskan Lands, but Arql versions contain specifics that suggest actual events rather than pure mythology. The tale cycles concerning the wars between scaled and furred peoples, between those who walked on two legs and those who ran on four; Arq preserves all these stories in forms so ancient that the Arql language itself barely suffices to tell them properly.

Scholars from Byenung who make the difficult journey to Arq return transformed, their understanding of Saskan history fundamentally altered by encountering legends that predate everything they thought they knew. Some become obsessed, spending years learning Arql and Arqq, sitting with elders, trying to reconstruct histories that may or may not have actually happened but which shape how the Arqli

understand their place in the world.

The Terpinol Academy maintains its linguistic outpost in Barqtun partly for practical language preservation but partly for access to these legends. If the deep past of the Saskan Lands is recorded anywhere, it's in the stories told in Arql caves by firelight, in languages that preserve memory through sound and rhythm rather than through writing.

B'arqo's Homeland

Barqtun is noted as B'arqo's ancestral home, though what that means in Arql context is characteristically ambiguous.

B'arqo is a storyteller, wit, and traveler whose sharp observations and darker humor mark him as distinctively Arql even as he operates throughout the Saskan Lands. His ability to see through pretense, his resistance to authority, his comfort with ambiguity and chaos are Arq traits, carried into contexts where they create friction and insight in equal measure.

That he comes from Barqtun suggests he emerged from the most concentrated chaos Arq offers, the place where every contradiction and possibility exist simultaneously. Whether he has family there, whether he returns regularly, whether from Barqtun means something specific or just indicates general Arql origin, these details remain appropriately unclear.

What matters is that B'arqo carries Arq's essential character: the refusal to be confined by others' categories, the wit that comes from seeing systems from outside, the survival skills developed in a place where you cannot depend on structure or authority for anything.

The Overwhelming Swirl

Even visitors from the Ny Lands, themselves considered wild and strange by northern standards, can find Arq overwhelming. A Ny Lander arriving in Barqtun expects to feel at home among fellow

tribal people who are utterly resistant to Fatunik control. Instead they find themselves lost in a sensory overload that makes the Ny Lands seem orderly by comparison.

The linguistic chaos alone is disorienting. Conversations shift between languages mid-sentence. Trade negotiations happen in pidgin hybrids invented for the occasion. Ritualized greetings are made in an Arql dialect whose meanings are contextual rather than fixed.

The visual environment is equally overwhelming. In the Ny Lands, even in their calculated chaos, patterns exist. Tribal affiliations marked by dress, status indicated by ornament, spaces organized according to understood principles. In Arq, none of these patterns hold. You cannot read social status from appearance. You cannot predict behavior from species. You cannot even determine whether a gathering is commercial, social, religious, or all three simultaneously.

The sounds are intense. Animal calls from sint community members whose voices don't resemble human speech. Musical instruments playing in scales that sound wrong to ears trained on northern music. The constant background noise of a population that doesn't value quiet and doesn't organize sound into discrete events.

The smells are complex too. Unfamiliar foods, animal scents from the majority sint population, herbs and preparations used for purposes that aren't immediately obvious, the salt-water smell of the coasts mixed with desert sand and rich earth and vegetation.

To experience Arq is to be constantly slightly off-balance, never quite understanding what's happening, relying on intuition and flexibility because rational analysis provides no foothold. Some visitors find this exhilarating. Most find it exhausting. All leave changed, carrying the memory of a place that shouldn't work but somehow does, that shouldn't be as alive and vital as it is but undeniably is.

Arq is what happens when you remove all governing structure and see what emerges.

The answer, surprisingly, is not chaos in the destructive sense but rather organized complexity at scales too small for central control. Bands coordinate internally. Trading networks function through

relationship rather than regulation. Disputes are resolved through negotiation, reputation, and when necessary, through violence that's brutal but bounded.

Is this a success? By northern standards, absolutely not. Arq has no impressive infrastructure, no architectural achievements, no systematic knowledge preservation, no capacity to mobilize for large-scale projects. Life is often hard, sometimes violent, and utterly devoid of the securities that civilization supposedly provides.

But by Arq's own standards, it works perfectly. Folks are free, genuinely free, not just theoretically free within restricted parameters. Communities form and dissolve organically. Knowledge persists through oral tradition. The land sustains those willing to work with it rather than attempting to dominate it.

The scholars who occasionally visit from intellectual circles expecting to find their theories validated leave disappointed. Arq doesn't operate on principles. It doesn't articulate ideology. It simply exists, stubbornly resistant to explanation, profoundly itself.

The Dauni Vakasaqua, with their sophisticated decentralized organization, sometimes look at Arq with bemused respect. "They've achieved what we attempt," a senior DK member once observed, "though I'm not sure they've achieved it intentionally or whether it just happened to them and they've learned to live with it."

The Ancient Ground

Arq is old. The landscape bears marks of the ancient wars between reptilian sints from Komikol and Saskan defenders fighting to establish hum presence. Ruins dot the territory. They are structures so ancient their purpose is unclear, built with techniques no longer practiced, marking battles whose details have dissolved into legend.

The Kollikan River carries not just water but memory, flowing north from territories where sentient reptilian civilizations existed long before hum arrived, bringing genetics and history that mix with Saskan populations, creating the extraordinary diversity that

characterizes modern Arq.

The sense of deep time pervades everything. An Arql elder telling stories doesn't speak of long ago or in ancient times but uses temporal markers that predate the Catastrophe, that reference events from before the current age, that assume listeners understand they're hearing memories from before the world broke.

This temporal depth is part of why Arq resists categorization. It's not just a province that lacks government; it's a place that predates the concept of provinces, that remembers when the Saskan Lands didn't exist as such, when different rules applied and different possibilities remained open.

Walking through Arql territory, you might stumble across a stone formation that's clearly artificial but whose purpose is unguessable. You might find a cave with markings that look like writing but in no language anyone can read. You might encounter a grove of trees growing in patterns too regular to be natural but too ancient to have clear origin.

The Arqli accept these mysteries without needing to solve them. "The ancestors placed that there," they might say, or "The old ones knew," and then move on with the practical business of living. The past is present, acknowledged, respected, but not obsessed over.

No Future

Arq has no plans. No five-year development goals, no provincial improvement schemes, no collective vision of what Arq should become.

This infuriates northern administrators who periodically propose reforms, infrastructure projects, educational initiatives designed to bring Arq into the modern Saskan world, to make it legible and manageable and properly governed. These proposals fail not through Arql resistance but through Arql indifference. You can't implement reforms in a province where no authority exists to implement them. You can't build infrastructure when the population is nomadic and

would simply route around whatever you construct. You can't impose education when the oral tradition transmits knowledge more effectively than schools ever could.

Arq will continue being Arq. The bands will move through their territories. The Tidejacks will raid shipping. Barqtun and Bartun will remain glorious messes. The legends will be told around fires. The languages will evolve or fade according to their own logic. The genetic mixing will continue, producing new variations on what it means to be sentient and alive.

And scholars from elsewhere will continue to visit, to be overwhelmed, to struggle to understand, and to return home carrying fragments of insight from the place that preserves what the rest of the Saskan Lands has mostly forgotten: that order is optional, that authority is constructed, and that life finds ways to flourish in conditions that rational planning would declare impossible.

The mists rise over the Arql Sea each morning. The bands wake in temporary camps or in villages like Skotskaa. The day begins without schedule or authority, and somehow, magnificently, it works.

When the Black Sails Come

There's a children's rhyme sung in coastal villages along the Krbsh Sea, taught to youngsters to help them count and learn their colors:

*One black sail means run away, Two black sails means hide and pray,
Three black sails means all is lost, Count the bodies, count the cost.*

It's not a cheerful rhyme. Children don't sing it happily. But they learn it, because knowing when to run might save your life.

The Tidejacks are the most feared organization operating in the southern Saskan Lands, more feared than the Tagabant, more feared than Kahila resistance cells, more feared than anything except perhaps the Ilyushan. This fear is earned through decades of systematic violence, professional brutality, and the kind of ruthless efficiency

that comes from operating as democratic death squads accountable to no one but themselves.

They call themselves the Tidejacks. Their victims call them worse.

The Tidejacks are semi-pirate, semi-mercenary outfits operating primarily from Arq bases, running small fleets, typically two to three ships per independent cell, across the Krbsh Sea, occasionally into the more dangerous waters of the Bay of Bar.

The ships are stolen mostly from Mobalbesq traders, occasionally from Ny Lands merchants, rarely Fatunik patrols. Some groups build or repair their own craft using skills learned through generations of maritime raiding. The vessels are maintained obsessively because your ship is your life, your weapon, and your only escape when things go wrong.

Each Tidejack cell operates independently. There is no central command, no coordinating authority, no Tidejack king or council. Cells cooperate when it is convenient to sharing intelligence about rich targets, coordinating attacks on well-defended convoys, dividing territorial waters to avoid competition. But these alliances are temporary, pragmatic, and dissolve the moment interests diverge.

What unites them is method: democratic internal organization combined with professional violence against everyone outside the crew.

The Democracy of Wolves

The Tidejacks' egalitarian structure is real. Booty is divided equally among all crew members regardless of role. Major decisions on which targets to hit, whether to fight or flee, how to respond to threats are made through crew votes. Leadership positions are assigned based on merit: the best navigator navigates, the best fighter leads boarding actions, the captain earns their position through demonstrated competence and loses it immediately if that competence fails.

This is not theoretical democracy. It's enforced through the simple fact that a ship's crew in close quarters can very easily dispose of a

leader who violates the share-and-share-alike principle or who makes decisions the crew won't follow. Several would-be Tidejack tyrants have mysteriously fallen overboard during storms. The others learned the lesson.

The result is crews with extraordinary cohesion and loyalty. You cannot bribe a Tidejack because there's no leader to corrupt and because betraying your crew means losing the only community that will accept you. You cannot intimidate them individually because the collective is more important than any single member. You cannot break them through normal hierarchical pressure because they have no hierarchy to exploit.

This makes them extremely effective and extremely dangerous. A Tidejack crew fights with the coordination of a military unit combined with the desperation of people who have nothing to lose and everything to gain.

But do not mistake internal egalitarianism for general benevolence. The Tidejacks are democratic among themselves and predatory toward everyone else. They have created equality within their crews by externalizing all violence and exploitation onto their victims.

What Happens

A merchant vessel crosses the Krbsh Sea carrying goods from Pavanarune to Kurosol. The route is known, traveled regularly, generally considered safe with reasonable precautions. Three hours into the crossing, the lookout spots sails on the horizon. Black sails. The merchant captain's stomach drops. He knows what's coming but hopes maybe they're not Tidejacks, maybe it's a legitimate fishing vessel, maybe they'll pass without incident.

The black sails close rapidly. The merchant ship tries to flee but the Tidejack vessel is faster, better handled, crewed by people who've spent their lives learning to chase down prey. Within an hour, the Tidejacks are alongside, close enough to hail.

The Tidejack captain calls across the water: "Heave to. We'll board

and inventory your cargo. Cooperate and you'll live. Resist and you'll feed the fish. Your choice."

The merchant captain knows his options. He can fight. His crew of eight against the Tidejacks' twenty, with the raiders carrying better weapons and vastly more experience in ship-to-ship combat. He can try to flee. But they've already been caught, and running now might be interpreted as resistance. Or he can cooperate and hope the "protection fee" is bearable.

He heaves to.

The Tidejacks board efficiently, weapons visible but not immediately threatening. They're professional about it—no unnecessary violence, no casual cruelty, just systematic inventory of cargo and assessment of the merchant's capacity to pay.

Serla reviews the manifest. "You're carrying grain, dried fish, some spices, looks like about three thousand in trade value. Standard fee is twenty percent. You pay us six hundred, we let you pass. We'll take it in coin if you have it, goods if you don't."

The merchant captain tries to negotiate. "That's more than my profit margin. I'll lose money on this run—"

"Not my problem," the pirate says. "You're paying for safe passage through waters we control. You want to keep all your profit, build a bigger ship with enough crew to fight us off. Until then, you pay the fee."

The merchant pays. The Tidejacks take their share, mostly coin, some premium spices and depart. The merchant continues to Byenung, his cargo reduced but intact, his crew shaken but alive.

This is the good outcome. The one where cooperation works. The one where the Tidejacks take their cut and let you live.

When It Goes Wrong

A different merchant, carrying similar cargo, decides to resist. Maybe

he's hired fighters. Maybe he's just foolish. Maybe he's desperate enough to gamble on escape. The Tidejacks close. The merchant ship tries to run. The Tidejacks pursue, and when they're within range, they don't hail they attack. Arrows first, targeting the steersman and anyone who looks like leadership. Then grappling hooks, boarding planks, the controlled chaos of armed fighters pouring onto the merchant vessel.

The merchant's hired guards fight back. They kill two Tidejacks a young man who'd been with his crew for less than a season, and a veteran fighter named Morven who'd raided these waters for twenty years. The Tidejacks kill all eight guards, efficiently and without mercy. Then they kill the merchant captain who hired them. Then they kill the crew who obeyed his orders to resist. They take everything: cargo, supplies, the ship itself if it's worth stealing or they burn it if not. Nothing is wasted. Bodies go overboard. The Tidejacks sail away richer by the full value of the cargo instead of just twenty percent.

Later, around fires in Arq camps, they'll toast the dead, tell stories about their lives, and distribute their share of the booty to their families. But no one questions whether the raid was worth it. Resist and die, that's the rule. It has to be the rule, or the whole system collapses. Word spreads. Other merchants hear what happened to the ship that resisted. The next time Tidejacks approach, very few people choose to fight.

The Land Operations

The maritime raids are famous, but the Tidejacks also operate on land, posing as frontier guards collecting road taxes from travelers through Arql territory.

The method is sophisticated. Tidejack scouts using primitive telescopes and flag communication systems borrowed from maritime signaling track caravans from concealed positions. When a promising target enters isolated terrain where escape is difficult, the Tidejacks emerge from cover, blocking the road ahead and behind.

The leader approaches, friendly but firm: "You're traveling through dangerous territory. Bandits operate in these parts. We maintain security for a small fee: twenty percent of cargo value. Pay the fee, we escort you safely through. Refuse and... well, we can't guarantee your safety."

The threat is implicit but clear. We're the bandits we're warning you about. Pay us not to rob you.

Most travelers pay. The Tidejacks pocket the fee and actually do provide escort, because maintaining the fiction of legitimate security service makes the scam work better. Travelers who feel they received value for payment are less likely to complain or to organize resistance or to go hire some mercenaries.

But occasionally someone refuses. Maybe they're genuinely too poor to pay. Maybe they're foolish enough to call the bluff. Maybe they're simply unlucky. The Tidejacks rob them. Thoroughly. Take everything valuable, leave them with enough food and water to survive the walk to the nearest settlement, and send them on their way as object lessons. If the victims resist violently, the outcome is the same as at sea. Bodies left by the roadside, stripped of anything useful. The Tidejacks move their operation to different territory for a while, wait for the incident to fade from memory, then return.

Why the FTA Fears Them

The Ny Lands Free Trade Association is known throughout the Saskan Lands as competent, disciplined, and deadly when protecting their clients. They go out of their way to avoid confrontations with the Tidejacks. This is not cowardice. This is professional assessment of threat.

The FTA fights with military precision, using tactics developed over generations of mercenary operations. They win through superior training, better equipment, and coordinated group action. The Tidejacks fight with the fury of people who have nothing to lose and who know that losing means death. They fight dirty. No rules, no restraint, no mercy. They fight as crews with perfect internal

coordination born from living together on small boats where trust is survival.

The FTA can usually beat the Tidejacks in open combat. But the cost is severe. Tidejack crews don't surrender. They don't retreat unless escape is clearly possible. They fight until they win or until they're all dead, and they'll take as many enemies with them as they can. The FTA, being professionals, recognize that fighting to the death against people who want to fight to the death is a terrible business. So they negotiate. When FTA-protected caravans enter Arql territory, they send scouts ahead to make arrangements. The Tidejacks, recognizing the FTA's capabilities, offer discounted protection fees. Both sides maintain face, no one dies, business continues.

But the fear is real. FTA members who've actually fought Tidejacks tell stories that make younger recruits go pale. The older FTA veterans drink more after those stories and stare into fires longer than usual.

A Mobalbesq merchant whose ship was taken three years ago, who barely escaped with his life by diving overboard and swimming to shore: "They're animals. Worse than animals. Animals kill for food. The Tidejacks kill because it's easier than letting you live. They smile while they do it. I watched them cut my crew's throats. People I'd sailed with for years, good people. And the Tidejacks were laughing. Not cruel laughter, not sadistic. Just... casual. Like they were gutting fish. Efficient. Professional.

"I made it to Byenung, filed complaints with the Night Hall. You know what they told me? 'We're aware of the problem. We're working on diplomatic solutions.' Diplomatic solutions! With pirates! With murderers!

"I don't sail anymore. Can't. The sight of black sails, even if it's just dark cloth on a fishing boat, makes me shake. My wife says I wake up screaming sometimes. I don't remember the dreams, but I remember the reality.

"People say the Tidejacks share equally, that they're democratic, like

that makes them better somehow. They share the money they stole from people they killed. That's not democracy. That's a conspiracy of murderers dividing the spoils."

A Settarune farmer whose daughter joined a Tidejack crew five years ago and hasn't been heard from since: "She was always wild, always looking for something beyond village life. The Tidejacks recruiter came through. They do that sometimes, looking for new members. She left with him. Didn't even say goodbye properly. "At first she sent messages. Exciting stories about sailing, about freedom, about making more money in a month than she'd make in a year farming. Then the messages stopped. I don't know if she's dead or if she just doesn't want to talk to her family anymore. Maybe both. The Tidejacks become their crew, abandon their old connections. They say it's loyalty. I say it's cult behavior. If she walked into my village tomorrow, I don't know what I'd do. Part of me wants to welcome her home. Part of me wants to ask how many people she's killed. Part of me knows I wouldn't like the answer."

The Arq Perspective

Within Arq itself, views of the Tidejacks are complex and deeply divided.

Some bands admire them, see them as heroes who've rejected northern civilization's constraints and created their own free communities based on genuine equality. The Tidejacks' willingness to rob northern merchants and Dominion vessels is seen as justified redistribution, taking from wealthy oppressors and spreading the wealth among Arql communities.

The fact that Tidejacks share their booty with families and clans in Arq creates genuine economic benefit. A successful Tidejack crew returning to Barqtun or Bartun might distribute enough wealth to sustain several extended families for seasons. This generosity creates social standing and obligation networks that protect Tidejacks from criticism within their home communities.

But other Arql bands view the Tidejacks with suspicion or outright

fear. The violence that Tidejacks direct outward can also turn inward. Disputes between Tidejack crews and local bands occasionally escalate into violence. The Tidejacks' casual relationship with killing makes them dangerous neighbors even when you're not their target.

An elder from Skotskaa, speaking privately: "They're our people, yes. They come from Arq, they speak our languages, they share our contempt for northern authority. But they've become something... separate. Something harder. You spend years killing people for money, it changes you. The young people who join Tidejack crews... Some of them come from good bands, were raised with proper values. But after a few seasons raiding, they come back different. Cold. The light in their eyes has changed to something else. We don't turn them away. They're still Arql. But we watch them carefully. And we keep our children away from their stories, because those stories make violence sound glorious when it's actually just violence."

The Tidejacks recruit primarily from Arq but accept members from anywhere willing to embrace their lifestyle. The process is straightforward: express interest, get vouched for by an existing crew member, prove yourself useful, and survive your first few raids.

Many recruits don't make it past that first season. Either they're killed in action, or they discover that living with the reality of piracy is very different from fantasizing about adventure and freedom. The psychological weight of killing people, even when it's justified as defense or as enforcement of their rules, breaks some people. They leave if the crew lets them, or they drink themselves to death if they can't leave.

Those who survive become true Tidejacks, fully integrated into crew culture, cut off from their previous identities. The crew becomes family. The democratic structure becomes religion. The violence becomes routine. This transformation worries outside observers. The Dauni Vakasaqua, who generally avoid judging others' life choices, quietly discourage young people from joining Tidejack crews. The Traveling Sisters, when they encounter former Tidejacks suffering from trauma or guilt, provide what care they can but note that the

damage is often permanent.

The Beqawar watch the Tidejacks with particular attention, not because they pose immediate large-scale threat but because they demonstrate how humans can create sophisticated social structures with qualities like genuine democracy, effective distribution of resources, and strong community bonds, while simultaneously engaging in systematic predation against outsiders. It's a troubling model. If the Tidejacks can maintain internal equality through external exploitation, what does that suggest about human capacity for organizing cooperative violence? What happens if that model scales beyond small ship crews?

Conflicts and Limitations

Despite their effectiveness and fearsome reputation, the Tidejacks face significant limitations. Their lack of central coordination means they sometimes work at cross-purposes. Two Tidejack crews might target the same merchant vessel, creating confusion and occasionally violence between the crews themselves. The egalitarian structure that makes individual crews cohesive prevents them from organizing larger fleets that could dominate entire sea routes or conduct more ambitious operations.

The Tagabant Riverwaq, operating in Pavan Bay, have developed effective counter-piracy tactics specifically targeting Tidejack methods. Several Tidejack crews have been destroyed in Pavan Bay confrontations, their survivors imprisoned or executed. This has made the Tidejacks more cautious about operating in northern waters, reducing their range and limiting their targets.

The biggest failure came three years ago when a coalition of Tidejack crews attempted a major raid on a Mobalbesq convoy protected by the Night Hall's security forces. The convoy carried critical supplies for several Outer Lands communes, and the Night Hall had invested heavily in protection.

The raid turned into a massacre. The Tidejacks, expecting typical merchant resistance, encountered disciplined fighters with superior

numbers and better equipment. Seven Tidejack ships were sunk. Over a hundred Tidejacks were killed. The few survivors fled back to Arq, where they faced harsh questions from their communities about why they'd attempted such a poorly planned operation.

The incident damaged Tidejack prestige throughout Arq and made subsequent raids more difficult. Merchants felt emboldened by the defeat, and some began hiring better protection, calculating that the cost of security was now worth it given Tidejack vulnerability. The Tidejacks adapted by becoming more selective about targets, avoiding heavily defended convoys, and focusing on softer prey. But the aura of invincibility was punctured, and everyone knows it.

The Moral Abyss

The Tidejacks present an uncomfortable reality that challenges simplistic moral frameworks. They are genuinely democratic internally, treating each member as equal regardless of background or identity. They share wealth far more fairly than most commercial operations. They provide economic support to Arql communities that have few other resources. They resist northern domination and refuse to be controlled by any authority.

They are also murderers, thieves, and terrorists who create genuine trauma in everyone they encounter outside their crews. They sustain their internal equality through systematic violence against innocents. They rob people trying to make honest livings, kill those who resist, and justify it all through claims of resistance against oppression, as if the merchant carrying grain from Settarune to feed Outer Lands communes is somehow an oppressor deserving death.

Some observers, particularly northern intellectuals uncomfortable with the Fatunik Authority, try to romanticize the Tidejacks as noble rebels fighting against hierarchy. These observers should spend time talking to the Mobalbesq widows whose husbands were killed by Tidejack raids, or to the merchants who've lost entire livelihoods to Tidejack piracy, or to the children in coastal villages who have nightmares about black sails.

Other observers, particularly Dominion authorities, treat the Tidejacks as pure evil requiring extermination. These observers ignore that the Tidejacks emerged from conditions the Dominion helped create, the abandonment of Arq to whatever system could survive there, the exploitation of southern resources without corresponding support, the structural violence of a system that makes piracy economically rational for people with few alternatives.

The truth is more complicated and more troubling. The Tidejacks are both victims of systemic injustice and perpetrators of individualized violence. They've created egalitarian communities through predatory violence. They demonstrate that oppressed people can organize democratically while simultaneously showing that democratic organization doesn't automatically produce ethical behavior.

They are what they are, sentient beings who've chosen a particular adaptation to harsh conditions, who've created internal solidarity by externalizing all violence and exploitation, who've found meaning and purpose in a life that requires constant moral compromise, and who've become very, very good at killing people who get in their way.

When the Black Sails Come

Stand on a dock in a coastal village near the Arql Sea. Watch the horizon. See sails approaching. You can't tell yet what color they are, just that vessels are coming. You wait. Your stomach tightens. Broodkins stop playing. Adults move closer together, not quite panicking but preparing. Everyone knows the drill.

The sails resolve into focus. Black. Three ships, moving fast, clearly hunting. You have minutes, maybe. You can't outrun them. You can't fight them. Your choices are: hide and hope they pass, or gather what little wealth you have and prepare to pay.

Most people choose payment. They gather coins, trade goods, anything valuable, and they wait on the dock with forced calm, hoping the Tidejacks are in a reasonable mood, hoping the protection fee won't be too steep, hoping no one does anything stupid that might trigger violence. The Tidejacks pull alongside. They're efficient,

professional, almost courteous. They inventory the village's wealth, calculate the fee, collect it, and depart. The whole interaction takes maybe an hour.

After they leave, the village breathes again. People return to work, shaken but alive. The children slowly resume playing, though they keep glancing at the horizon, checking for more black sails.

Someone starts singing the counting rhyme, soft and bitter:

*One black sail means run away, Two black sails means hide and pray,
Three black sails means all is lost, Count the bodies, count the cost.*

The Tidejacks don't hear it. They're already moving toward their next target, dividing the booty, maintaining the democratic system that makes them efficient predators.

And in Arq, in the camps and settlements where Tidejacks rest between raids, they tell different stories, stories of freedom and brotherhood, of resistance against northern oppression, of equality achieved through collective action. They share the wealth they've stolen and call it justice.

Both stories are true. Both stories are insufficient. The Tidejacks are neither heroes nor villains but something more troubling: proof that huum and sint can organize sophisticated egalitarian communities while remaining predators, that democracy can coexist with brutality, and that the victims of oppression can become oppressors themselves without recognizing the transformation.

The black sails continue sailing. The villages continue paying. The bodies continue feeding the fish. And Arq continues sheltering the crews who make it all possible, admiring them, fearing them, profiting from them, and trying not to think too hard about the blood that finances the booty being shared so democratically among the brotherhood of wolves.

Ha! Yes, of course. Let me add a brief coda that makes that literal:

The Literal Pack

A detail often overlooked by northern observers who hear stories about Tidejack wolves and assume it's metaphorical is that some of them actually are wolves.

Arq's extraordinary sint diversity includes wolf-sint populations, beings with wolf traits ranging from subtle, like enhanced senses and pack-bonding instincts, to obvious like lupine features and predatory reflexes. Many have gravitated to Tidejack crews where their capabilities are valued and where the democratic structure doesn't penalize them for being non-huum.

A mixed crew, huum, wolf-sints, snake-sints, perhaps a rabbit-sint navigator with exceptional spatial awareness, operates with capabilities that purely huum crews cannot match. Wolf-sints tracking prey by scent across kilometers of open water. Snake-sints moving silently through a merchant ship's hold. The collective predatory instincts of beings who evolved or were engineered for hunting, now applied to hunting humans.

When coastal villagers speak about the wolves coming, they're not always speaking metaphorically. This makes the egalitarian structure both more impressive and more disturbing. The Tidejacks have achieved genuine cross-species democracy; no hierarchy based on being huum or sint, just competence and loyalty. But they've achieved it by creating packs of mixed predators who've decided that everyone outside the pack is prey.

The merchant who survives a Tidejack raid might not even realize that the crew who robbed him included non-huum members. In the chaos of boarding action, with weapons drawn and terror high, you don't always notice the predatory grace, the too-keen eyes, the movements that aren't quite human.

But afterward, in nightmares, you remember. The way one of them moved. The sound one of them made. Not quite a laugh, not quite a growl. The eyes that reflected lamplight wrong.

The black sails are frightening enough. But sometimes, when the Tidejacks board your vessel, you realize that the monsters aren't

wearing masks.

They're just wearing black sails.